

The Magic Mountain



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF THOMAS MANN

Thomas Mann was born in Lübeck, German Empire (present-day Germany) to a bourgeois family. After Mann's father, a senator and grain merchant, died in 1891, the family moved to Munich, where Mann studied at the Ludwig Maximilians University of Munich and the Technical University of Munich. Mann lived in Munich from 1891 to 1933 and began his writing career there, working as an editor for the satirical magazine *Simplicissimus* and publishing his first short story, "Little Mr Friedemann," in 1898. He married Katia Pringsheim in 1905; the couple had six children together. In 1912, Mann's wife moved to a sanatorium in Davos, Switzerland for several months to receive treatment for a respiratory illness. Mann visited her in Davos several times, and his experiences there would serve as inspiration for his novel *The Magic Mountain*, which he began writing that year. The onset of World War I in 1914, however, would bring this project to a halt. Though Mann initially supported the German Empire's nationalist cause, he gradually came to embrace democratic ideals following the German Republic's establishment in 1919. The themes Mann examines in *The Magic Mountain*, published in 1924, demonstrate the gradual political conversion Mann underwent during this time. Mann, warned that it would not be safe to return to Munich following the Nazis' rise to power in 1933, lived in Switzerland for a time before emigrating to the United States in 1938. He became a U.S. citizen in 1944. Though he visited both East and West Germany in the years following World War II, he never returned to Germany to live. His later notable works include novels *Lottie in Weimar: The Beloved Returns* and *Doctor Faustus*, as well as several essays about the moral obligations of writers. In general, his works, particularly early ones, are characterized by a deep philosophical bent and the creative individual's struggle between the world of imagination and real, ordinary life. He died in August 1955 at the age of 80 in Zürich.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

Thomas Mann began work on *The Magic Mountain* in 1912, but the project was interrupted when World War I broke out in 1914. Though not an overtly political work, given the allegorical implications of the story's setting (an international sanatorium in the years leading up to the war), it is impossible not to read the novel without reflecting on the sociopolitical tensions that laid the foundation for the conflict. Historians identify numerous factors as long-term and immediate causes of World War I. While the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand

(the intended heir to the Austro-Hungarian Empire) by a Serbian nationalist was the event that triggered Austria-Hungary to declare war, broader issues such as European imperial expansion, a rise in nationalism across the continent (but in Serbia, in particular), and tension among alliances involving European powers, Russia, and the Ottoman empire all laid the foundation for the conflict. Prior to the onset of World War I, countries across the continent had formed alliances, with powers vowing to support one another should war break out between an allied country and an outside country. One alliance formed in 1907 between France, Britain, and Russia and was known as the Triple Entente. The alliance was a particularly significant source of tension, with the German Empire—located geographically and ideologically at the center of these Western and Eastern powers—seeing its creation as a political and existential threat. As tensions between alliances grew, nations declared war against other nations on a smaller scale, eventually resulting in the formation of two sides of the war: the Allied Powers (Russia, France, and Great Britain) and the Central Powers (Germany, Austria-Hungary, and the Ottoman Empire).

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

Mann's first novel, *Buddenbrooks* (1901), follows the generational decline of a wealthy German family. While the origins of *The Magic Mountain*'s Hans Castorp borrow certain elements from Mann's upbringing, *Buddenbrooks* draws more heavily from Mann's own family history. Mann originally intended for *The Magic Mountain* to be a novella-length satirical accompaniment to his 1912 [Death in Venice](#), a novella about an older writer who abandons his disciplined, honorable character for pleasure and self-indulgence when he travels to Venice and becomes obsessed with a young boy, a transformation that ultimately leads to his titular demise. Mann has influenced a number of later authors, including Yukio Mishima, whose notable works include *Confessions of a Mask*, *The Sea of Fertility* tetralogy, and [The Sound of Waves](#). Finally, *The Magic Mountain* is a Bildungsroman, a literary genre that follows a protagonist's psychological and moral development as they come of age. Other notable coming-of-age stories include [Great Expectations](#) by Charles Dickens, *What Maisie Knew* by Henry James, and [Little Women](#) by Louisa May Alcott.

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** The Magic Mountain
- **When Written:** 1912–1924
- **Where Written:** Munich, Germany

- **When Published:** 1924; first English translation published 1927
- **Literary Period:** Modernism
- **Genre:** Novel, Bildungsroman
- **Setting:** The International Sanatorium Berghof, a fictional sanatorium in the Swiss Alps
- **Climax:** World War I is declared, freeing Hans (who will have to serve in the military) from the spell of disillusionment and inwardness under which he has spent the majority of his stay at the Berghof.
- **Antagonist:** Abstract Ideals; Inwardness; the Berghof and the spell it casts on its inhabitants
- **Point of View:** Third Person

EXTRA CREDIT

A Medical Mann. Given that the novel takes place at a tuberculosis sanatorium, Mann spends considerable time describing the symptoms and treatments characters deal with, and many doctors praised Mann for his medical accuracy at the time of the novel's initial publication. For instance, he references artificial pneumothorax, a newly developed method used in the treatment of pulmonary tuberculosis.

The Mentionable Mountain. Since its publication in 1924, numerous works of literature, music, and visual art have referenced *The Magic Mountain* directly or indirectly. Hayao Miyazaki's film *The Wind Rises* (2013) features a character named Hans Castorp; Gore Verbinski's psychological horror film *A Cure for Wellness* (2016) was inspired by *The Magic Mountain*; and musician Father John Misty's 2017 album *Pure Comedy* features a song called "So I'm Growing Old on Magic Mountain," which references Mann's novel.



PLOT SUMMARY

Hans Castorp, a young engineer who has only recently finished university, travels in the years leading up to World War I from his home in Hamburg to the Swiss Alps to visit his sickly cousin Joachim. His cousin is a resident at the Berghof, which is a sanatorium for tuberculosis patients. Situated high in the mountains, the Berghof is far removed from the ordinary world down below.

Hans spends his first days strolling the grounds with Joaquim, who teaches Hans about life at the sanatorium and introduces him to several of the sanatorium's residents. These include Settembrini, an Italian intellectual with a commitment to humanist ideals who immediately takes it upon himself to become Hans's mentor. Hans also meets Dr. Behrens, the sanatorium's director, and Dr. Krokowski another of the sanatorium's doctors, who "dissects" patients' minds and presents lectures on psychoanalysis.

From the start, Hans feels there's something odd and vaguely unsettling about the Berghof, though the strange atmosphere simultaneously enchants him. Residents and staff alike adopt a detached, indifferent attitude toward suffering, illness, and death. Patients seem to get worse, not better, under Behrens's care. It's not uncommon for residents' discharge dates to be postponed months or even years. Even stranger, nobody seems to mind sticking around: in fact, it's not uncommon for discharged residents to return to the Berghof, having struggled to readapt to ordinary life. Over the course of days and then weeks, Hans acclimates to life at the Berghof, and he starts to live as the permanent residents do.

Hans initially plans to stay only for three weeks, as he's scheduled to start his first real job upon his return. But just as he's getting ready to leave, he falls ill. Behrens performs a precautionary **X-ray** on Hans's chest and discovers a "moist spot" in his lungs—meaning Hans has tuberculosis and must remain at the sanatorium until he recovers. Hans takes this news in stride. His reaction disturbs Joachim, who, unlike most other residents of the Berghof, wishes to re-enter society as soon as possible, determined to return to his military service.

Following his diagnosis, Hans commits to his new existence as a resident of the Berghof, never seeming to mind when Behrens repeatedly pushes back his discharge date. Instead, he occupies himself with various intellectual pursuits, becoming deeply interested in biology, human anatomy, and philosophy. He regularly ventures out to a nearby meadow to "play king," or indulge in lofty philosophical musings about life, death, and the passage of time. Settembrini regularly lectures Hans on humanism and urges Hans to recover, leave the Berghof, and become a productive member of society. Hans, however, stubbornly dismisses this advice and continues to waste his days on self-indulgent musings.

In addition to Hans's intellectual pursuits, he also falls for an ill-mannered and sensuous young Russian woman, Clavdia Chauchat. Though initially Clavdia's poor manners disgust Hans, he comes to understand Clavdia's rudeness as a type of freedom—and one she has earned through physical illness, specifically. Following this realization, Hans becomes infatuated with Clavdia despite Settembrini's warnings about Clavdia and the dangerous "Asiatic" principles she represents.

Hans's romance culminates during the sanatorium's Walpurgis Night festivities, when he and Clavdia have an intimate and flirtatious conversation. Clavdia gifts Hans a photo of her **X-ray** and ridicules Hans for what she considers his characteristically German, bourgeois sensibilities. Hans nevertheless declares his love for Clavdia. Clavdia shocks Hans by announcing that she's leaving the Berghof tomorrow, though she coyly adds that she'll likely return at some point. Hans is heartbroken to see her go.

Toward the end of Hans's first year at the Berghof he meets Naphta, a Jesuit and a professor of classical languages who becomes Settembrini's intellectual adversary: while

Settembrini espouses Enlightenment values of humanism and democracy, Naphta has radical, communist sympathies that Settembrini views as regressive and anti-humanitarian. The men frequently debate their respective positions, and Hans and Joachim frequently observe these often-fiery arguments.

In September, a little over a year after Hans's arrival at the Berghof, Joachim leaves to resume his military service, a decision he makes against Behrens's advice. Hans, meanwhile, remains at the Berghof. Without Joachim for company, he befriends two residents, Wehsal and Ferge. His favorite uncle, James Tienappel, also comes to visit him. James attempts to convince Hans to leave the Berghof but is unsuccessful. Though strangely enchanted by the sanatorium, just as Hans was when he first arrived, James ultimately leaves in a hurry, apparently disgusted by Dr. Behrens's particularly gruesome description of a decomposing body. He does not say goodbye to Hans.

That winter, Hans takes up skiing. On one outing, he ventures deep into the woods and gets lost when a storm hits. He takes shelter beside a shed, falls asleep, and has a dream about old, half-naked witches dismembering a small, blond-haired child. Hans awakes and reflects on the interconnectedness of illness, death, and sickness. He concludes that the only thing stronger than death is love—not reason, as Settembrini would argue. Eventually he finds his way back to the Berghof.

By late spring, the strain of Joachim's service has taken a toll on his health, forcing him to return to the Berghof. His health continues to deteriorate, and eventually he dies. Following Joachim's death, Hans loses what remaining motivation he had to make good use of his time, and he gives himself over to the malaise and meaninglessness that characterizes life at the Berghof for so many of its residents.

Clavdia returns to the Berghof, but she's accompanied by a lover: Mynheer Peeperkorn, an old, retired colonial Dutchman who loves to drink, entertain, and indulge in all manner of decadent pleasures. He captivates his audiences with his grand gestures and bravado, though much of what he says is utter nonsense. In private, Clavdia admits to Hans that she is drawn to Peeperkorn's dominance and takes pleasure in submitting to him. Hans responds ambiguously to Peeperkorn's arrival. On the one hand, he continues to pine for Clavdia and is jealous of her new lover. On the other hand, he quite likes Peeperkorn and seems to want Peeperkorn to like him back. Settembrini doesn't understand Hans's fascination with Peeperkorn and tries to convince Hans that the man is a hedonistic fool, but to no avail. Peeperkorn eventually confronts Hans about his and Clavdia's romantic history, but he continues to behave amiably toward Hans, nonetheless.

One day, Peeperkorn leads Clavdia, Hans, Settembrini, Naphta, Wehsal, and Ferge on an outing to a nearby waterfall for a picnic. He tries, as usual, to engage his audience with his commanding presence and riveting rhetoric, but the great roar of the waterfall drowns out his words, greatly dispiriting him.

He dies by suicide after returning to the Berghof that night, having injected himself with poison. Clavdia leaves after Peeperkorn's suicide, and Hans never sees her again.

Eventually a "Great Stupor" descends upon the Berghof, and residents become restless, agitated, and generally gloomy. They occupy themselves with tedious activities and silly parlor games to pass the time.

Some years into Hans's stay, a young woman named Elly Brand arrives at the Berghof, and eventually the other residents discover she has a hidden talent: she has extrasensory perception and can communicate with the spirit world. Krokowski, whose interests have shifted toward more supernatural matters over the years, starts conducting hypnosis sessions and séances with Elly, which some residents attend. Hans attends one séance and asks, against his better judgment, for Elly to manifest Joachim's spirit. She does so, and the experience deeply disturbs Hans.

As time passes, the political situation in the world below worsens to the point where war seems inevitable. The atmosphere of the Berghof turns tense, as well. Settembrini and Naphta get into a philosophical argument that becomes so heated that Naphta challenges Settembrini to a duel. When the appointed hour of the duel arrives, Settembrini, an avowed pacifist, refuses to shoot Naphta. Instead, he aims pistol upward and fires directly into the sky. Naphta, infuriated by Settembrini's "cowardice," responds by shooting himself in the head. Naphta's suicide deeply affects Settembrini, who from that point on spends most of his time in bed, becoming a shell of his former self.

Meanwhile, tensions "down below" continue to brew, though Hans stopped paying attention to the happenings of the real world long ago. In total, Hans spends seven years at the Berghof. In his seventh year, war is finally declared, at the sanatorium erupts in chaos as residents rush to pack their things and leave. At long last, it's time for Hans, too, to leave the Berghof.

The novel closes with a grim description of Hans fighting on a battlefield alongside thousands of other young men. The narrator doubts that Hans will survive the war, though his exact fate remains unknown.



CHARACTERS

MAJOR CHARACTERS

Hans Castorp – Hans Castorp is the novel's protagonist. He is a young and impressionable German engineer who comes to the Berghof to visit his sickly cousin Joachim. Hans initially intends only to stay for three weeks at the sanatorium, finding its ill residents and their monotonous daily life strange and disturbing. But Hans seems almost to fall under the spell of the otherworldly place, acclimating to its quirks and developing a

fever just as he is set to depart, and he ends up extending his stay indefinitely. He leaves only when outside circumstances intervene and he must leave to fight in World War I. Unlike Joachim, who never loses sight of the obligations and responsibilities he has in the real world, Hans eagerly leaves the real world behind to immerse himself in the monotony and listlessness of life at the Berghof. Outwardly, Hans appears invested in making productive use of his time, poring over anatomy and biology textbooks and engaging in lofty philosophical musings. But his inability to form any decisive, committed opinions of his own or to act on any of the ideals he does entertain, however fleeting they may be, renders his time at the Berghof ultimately meaningless. Ignoring his mentor Settembrini's repeated pleas for Hans to return to the real world and become a productive member of society, Hans allows himself to be corrupted by the dangerous ideals of irrationality, decadence, and submission that characters like his love interest, Clavdia Chauchat, represent, and ultimately he wastes seven years of his life at the Berghof. Though Hans's exact fate is left a mystery, the novel strongly implies that he dies fighting in the trenches in World War I.

Joachim Ziemssen – Joachim Ziemssen is Hans Castorp's cousin. He is ill with tuberculosis and is a resident of the Berghof, where Hans visits him at the beginning of the novel. A soldier, Joachim has a deeply engrained sense of duty, and this never leaves him, even after all the time he's spent at the sanatorium. Joachim is unique as a character in that he has a deep sense of honor. What's more, he is able to translate his beliefs into practical action: he has a sense of duty to his nation, and he acts on that honor by doing everything he can to recover from illness and return to his military service. For this reason, he is shocked when Hans eagerly agrees to stay at the Berghof indefinitely following his unexpected illness. Joachim eventually checks out of the Berghof against Behrens's advice in order to return to his military service, an ill-advised (albeit honorable) choice that ultimately brings about his demise. Only a few months into his service, his health takes a turn for a worse, and he's forced to return to the Berghof. Not long after, he succumbs to his illness and dies.

Clavdia Chauchat – Clavdia Chauchat is a resident of the Berghof. She is of Russian descent but married to a French man, hence her French name. Clavdia's husband never appears in the novel, however, and she hardly speaks of him. Though sensuous and beautiful, she is also ill-mannered, lazy, and irrational, and she represents (in the book's oversimplified portrayal) the corrupting force of Eastern sensibilities. She becomes Hans's romantic interest, and it's ultimately (if indirectly) because of her that Hans ends up staying at the Berghof as long as he does. Clavdia abruptly departs following her and Hans's evening of flirtation during the Berghof's Walpurgis Night festivities, though she coyly suggests that she may return at a later, unspecified time. In consequence, Hans remains at the

Berghof for years awaiting her return. When she finally does return, she is not alone, having brought a new lover, Mynheer Peeperkorn, with her. Clavdia confesses to Hans that she is takes pleasure in submitting to Peeperkorn, a trait that contributes to the novel's negative (and oversimplified) portrayal of Eastern sensibilities.

Mynheer Peeperkorn – Mynheer Peeperkorn is Clavdia's lover. He is an older, retired colonial Dutchman with a bold personality and a taste for the fine pleasures of life. He is adept at entertaining audiences with his personable demeanor and bold manner of speaking, though ultimately much of what he says is nonsense, and he's never able to complete a thought. Peeperkorn represents excess, decadence, and irrationality, traits the novel associates negatively with Eastern sensibilities. Hans responds to Peeperkorn's arrival with ambivalence. On the one hand, he is jealous of the man's relationship with Clavdia and resents him somewhat. But he also quite likes Peeperkorn and wants Peeperkorn to like him, too—despite, or perhaps even because of, Settembrini's warnings that Peeperkorn is a fool. Peeperkorn invites Hans and some others to visit a nearby waterfall with him one day, and he becomes deeply dejected when he tries and fails to entertain his guests, the loud roar of the waterfall rendering his words inaudible. Later that night, he dies by suicide, having injected himself with poison.

Lodovico Settembrini – Lodovico Settembrini is a resident of the Berghof. An Italian intellectual, he is devoted to Enlightenment ideals of humanism, personal freedom, and democracy and loves to talk about them using crafty but compelling rhetoric. He represents the rationality and democracy that characterize (in the book's oversimplified reading) Western ideals. Immediately upon meeting Hans, he appoints himself the impressionable youth's mentor, a situation Hans reacts to with considerable ambiguity. While he does enjoy listening to Settembrini talk, he also resents the older man for condescending to him. As a result, he disregards a lot of the genuinely good advice Settembrini offers him. The novel generally portrays Settembrini and his Western ideals in a positive light, particularly compared to the corrupting forces of irrationality, submission, and decadence that other characters (namely Clavdia Chauchat, Leo Naphta, and Mynheer Peeperkorn) represent. However, like these other characters, Settembrini's flaw is in his failure to act on his principles. Ultimately, though he may urge Hans to take control of his life and return to the real world, he fails to heed his own advice.

Leo Naphta – Leo Naphta is a man from a Jewish family who became a Jesuit as a youth. He intended to become a priest, but his failing health brought his studies to a halt. In the novel's present, he is working as a professor of classical languages in Davos-Dorf and is one of Behrens's outpatients. He and Settembrini both rent rooms in Lukačnek's house in Davos-Dorf. The men are intellectual adversaries and frequently

engage in fiery debates. While Settembrini is a humanist who believes in Enlightenment ideals of democracy, rationality, and personal freedom, Naphta supports a radical form of communism, which Settembrini views as highly irrational and antithetical to liberty and human progress. Naphta's religious beliefs also lead him to find great meaning in suffering, illness, and death, viewing death as the path out of the flawed, human world of evil and vice and a gateway to the higher spiritual realm. Naphta enters the story just after Clavdia's initial departure from the Berghof, and he essentially replaces her as a corrupting, irrational force who preys on the impressionable, naïve Hans. Settembrini sees how Naphta's views—particularly his reverence for death and suffering—entice Hans, and he cautions his young mentee not to fall under the spell of Naphta's irrationality. He even goes so far as to accuse Naphta of corrupting the youth, a slight that enrages Naphta and compels him to challenge Settembrini to a duel. When Settembrini, an avowed pacifist, refuses to shoot at Naphta, Naphta responds by shooting himself in the head.

Dr. Behrens – Dr. Behrens is the director of the Berghof. Settembrini detests the man and sneeringly calls him Rhadamanthus, a reference to one of the judges of the dead in the underworld in Greek mythology. Settembrini's nickname for Behrens links Behrens with death and destruction. And indeed, it is apt to associate Behrens with death—he rarely succeeds in rehabilitating patients, many of whom seem to become sicker under his care, and he routinely pushes back patients' discharge dates indefinitely. In reality, though, Behrens has very little control over his patients' fates, as many of them are so ill that recovery is impossible. While Behrens conveys an outward interest in healing his patients, this is merely a front to conceal the hopelessness of their situations. Behrens's attitude toward death and illness is detached and unsentimental, and this appalls Hans, who believes there ought to be dignity and meaning in illness, suffering, and death.

Dr. Krokowski – Dr. Krokowski is Behrens's assistant. He's a friendly, spirited man in his early 30s. Krokowski has a passion for psychoanalysis and regularly "dissects the patients' psyches" in his basement office. He also presents bimonthly lectures with psychoanalytic themes. Fittingly, one of his core theories is that physical illness is symptomatic of repressed negative thoughts. Krokowski has extremely pale skin, dark eyes, and a long black beard, and he dresses all in black, giving him an ominous appearance. Indeed, Settembrini mockingly calls Krokowski "Minos," the mythological King of Crete who sent seven young girls and seven young boys into Daedalus's labyrinth to be eaten by the Minotaur. Minos is also known for his role as the judge of the dead in the underworld. In giving Krokowski this nickname, Settembrini is implying that Krokowski (and his supervisor Behrens, whom Settembrini calls Rhadamanthus, another mythological judge of the dead in the underworld) has no interest in healing patients. Rather, his

treatment of them brings them closer to death—an outcome in which Krokowski may even take perverse pleasure.

Pribislav Hippe – Pribislav Hippe was a boy Hans went to school with in the seventh grade. He appeared to be of mixed origins and had narrow, slanted eyes, suggesting Slavic-Wendish roots. His eyes caused the other students to bully him and are his defining feature in Hans's memories of him. Hans develops something of a fascination with Hippe despite hardly interacting with him, and this parallels his romance with Clavdia Chauchat years later. Clavdia reminds Hans of Hippe, though he doesn't consciously realize this connection at first. Notably, the single interaction Hans had with Hippe, which comes back to him in a dream in his early days at the Berghof, was when he asked to borrow Hippe's pencil in class one day. The seemingly banal exchange took on great significance for Hans, and he stored shavings from the pencil in his desk for years after. Hans replicates this interaction at the Berghof when he asks Clavdia to borrow her pencil during the sanatorium's Walpurgis Night celebrations. The almost supernatural fixation Hans has with Pribislav and Hippe, and in particular their narrow eyes, illustrates the seductive pull of the supposedly "Eastern" principles they represent, like irrationality and decadence.

Barbara Hujus – Barbara Hujus is a resident of the Berghof who died prior to Hans's arrival. Joachim recounts crossing paths with a priest and altar boy on their way to Barbara's room to perform the Catholic ritual for the dying. He followed them into Barbara's room and watched as Barbara kicked and screamed with all her might the moment she realized what was happening. Joachim tells Hans this story, seemingly to teach Hans why the sanatorium tries to hide the dead and imminently dying from its heartier patients—fear can make people behave unpredictably and irrationally, and so it's best for everyone if the dying accept their fates reasonably and discreetly. Hans finds this attitude appalling and disrespectful.

Head Nurse von Mylendonk – Nurse von Mylendonk is the head nurse at the Berghof. She has a harsh, frank personality that rubs many residents the wrong way; Settembrini, for one, quite dislikes her. She carries a bag of **thermometers** available for purchase around the sanatorium, and she sells one to Hans toward the end of his first three weeks at the Berghof upon examining him (Hans has fallen ill just before he's scheduled to head home) and discovering that he hasn't checked his temperature since arriving at the sanatorium.

Anton Ferge – Anton Ferge is a Russian man who is a resident at the Berghof. When Hans first meets Ferge, Ferge is recovering from a pneumothorax that almost killed him. Ferge is one the patients Hans and Joachim visit during Hans's phase of visiting the Berghof's "poor sick" in an effort to dignify their suffering. The cousins appreciate Ferge's frank, unaffected manner, and Hans refers to him as the "simple martyr." Ferge recovers, though, and takes over Settembrini's spot at the cousins' dining table after Settembrini moves out of the

sanatorium. He and Wehsal are the Berghof residents with whom Hans is friendliest after Joachim's death.

Ferdinand Wehsal – Ferdinand Wehsal is a merchant from Mannheim who becomes a resident at the Berghof. Hans finds Wehsal's gloomy, self-deprecating disposition rather pathetic. Wehsal has a crush on Clavdia Chauchat (which also annoys Hans), though he never approaches her, opting to stare at her from afar and lament his lovesickness instead. He becomes one of Hans's closest acquaintances at the Berghof after Joachim's death, and he and Anton Ferge frequently join Hans when he visits Settembrini and Naphta.

Hermine Kleefeld – Hermine Kleefeld is a resident of the Berghof. She's a mischievous young woman who plays a prank on Hans early in his stay at the Berghof, "whistling" through her side as he passes her by, a maneuver she's able to do due to a side effect of the pneumothorax treatment she underwent to treat her tuberculosis. She's the appointed leader of the "Half-Lung Club," a group of residents who have undergone the same pneumothorax treatment.

Herr Albin – Herr Albin is a resident of the Berghof. He's a bit of a rabblouser—early in Hans's stay, he overhears Herr Albin antagonizing several female patients, playfully (but effectively) intimidating them with his knife and threatening to retrieve his revolver from his room. Herr Albin insists that his illness should excuse his poor behavior, and this justification lays the foundation for Hans's later musings about illness, death, and suffering as sources of great dignity and freedom. It's Herr Albin who provides the revolvers for Settembrini and Naphta's duel toward the end of the novel.

Tous-les-deux – Tous-les-deux is the nickname residents of the Berghof give to a Mexican woman who has come to the sanatorium to be with her eldest son, who is gravely ill and eventually dies. Her other son comes to see visit his brother and falls ill and dies, too. Despondent and grieving, she dresses all in black and spends her days roaming the Berghof's grounds. Tous-les-deux's nickname comes from her inability to speak any German and hardly any French—unable to communicate with anyone, she greets every person she encounters with the exclamation "tous les deux!" ("both"), referencing her two dying sons.

Elly Brand – Elly Brand is a young woman from Denmark who becomes a resident at the Berghof sometime after Joachim's death. She appears quiet and unassuming on the outside, but the other patients soon realize that she's concealing a remarkable and unsettling talent: she is clairvoyant and can communicate with the spiritual realm via a spirit named Holger, who functions as something of a guardian angel to her. Dr. Krokowski immediately takes an interest in Elly and begins seeing her for private hypnosis sessions. Krokowski proposes that if his theory of physical illness as a manifestation of repressed negative emotions is true, then it follows that Elly's extrasensory perception would allow her to project the spirits

she communicates with into the physical realm. Krokowski's theory proves correct, and he eventually invites residents to participate in seances in which Elly manifests apparitions of the deceased. Hans attends one such séance and, despite his better judgment, asks Elly make Joachim appear. When the figure of Joachim as he appeared on his deathbed suddenly materializes in the room, the experience deeply disturbs Hans.

Marusya – Marusya is a coquettish young Russian woman who is a resident of the Berghof. She sits with Clavdia Chauchat at the Good Russian table in the dining hall. Hans notices that Joachim tries not to look at her, and when he does look at her, his face takes on a sickly, unhappy appearance. It's evident that Joachim has a crush on Marusya and is ashamed about it, a dissonance that represents his inner struggle between his sense of duty and his bourgeois sensibilities. Joachim finally interacts with Marusya when he returns to the Berghof after his illness forces him to abandon his military service, and it's when Hans observes this brief, flirtatious episode that he knows Joachim will die soon.

Frau Stöhr – Frau Stöhr is a resident of the Berghof who sits at Hans and Joachim's table in the dining hall. She's described as having long, "rabbitlike" teeth. She's an obnoxious woman who tries in vain to disguise the fact that she is uncultured and unintelligent, but her attempts to appear refined fool nobody. She often goes off on tangents about nonsensical subjects, such as the many different kinds of fish sauce she knows how to make, and she loves to tell anyone who will listen (and even those who don't care to listen) about the present status of her illness. The existence of the simple-minded, frivolous Frau Stöhr complicates Hans's working hypothesis that being ill makes a person "venerable."

The Overblown Woman (Frau Zimmermann) – "The overblown woman" is the nickname Behrens gives to a Berghof resident whose real name, Hans eventually learns, is Frau Zimmermann. She's one of the people Hans visits when he's going through his phase of visiting the Berghof's "poor sick" in an effort to dignify their suffering. Frau Zimmermann is a nervous-seeming woman who laughs nonstop about her dire condition. The origins of her nickname relate to a botched pneumothorax she had prior to arriving at the Berghof—a doctor tried to refill her oxygen but gave her too much, which caused her heart to constrict and gave her shortness of breath. Frau Zimmermann's unserious attitude infuriates Behrens. She dies before Hans can visit her a second time.

Leila Gerngross – Leila Gerngross is a resident of the Berghof. She's gravely ill and expected to die. Hans and Joachim send the young woman flowers and then visit her during Hans's phase of spending time with the sanatorium's "poor sick" in an effort to dignify their suffering. They encounter Leila's parents during this visit, and Hans feels annoyed and a bit dejected when Frau Gerngross seemingly makes light of the cousins' visit.

Fritz Rotbein – Fritz Rotbein is a resident of the Berghof. Hans

and Joachim visit the young man and bring him flowers during Hans's phase of spending time with the Berghof's "poor sick." Rotbein is so happy to have visitors that he actually weeps. He begs the cousins to come back again, but he undergoes an unsuccessful operation and dies before they have the chance.

Karen Karstedt – Karen Karstedt is one of Behrens's outpatients. She is among the "poor sick" patients Hans and Joachim visit during Hans's phase of visiting the sanatorium's "poor sick" in an effort to dignify their suffering. He and Joachim visit with Karen several times. Initially well enough to leave her bed, she accompanies the cousins on several outings around town. On one occasion, they wander around a cemetery and stumble upon an unoccupied plot that will become Karen's grave. She later dies, and Hans is disappointed at not being able to participate in her funeral.

Uncle James Tienappel – James Tienappel is Hans's favorite uncle. He visits Hans at the Berghof sometime after Joachim has left to return to his military service. James's primary reason for visiting is to convince Hans to leave the sanatorium, but he is ultimately unsuccessful. Upon his arrival at the Berghof, Tienappel takes in the sanatorium with the same ambivalence that Hans did when he first got there, simultaneously disturbed and transfixed by the otherworldly place. Ultimately, however, he reacts with disgust when Behrens, at Hans's prompting, describes the gory reality of what happens to a human body as it decomposes. James leaves first thing the next morning without saying goodbye to Hans, and they don't see each other again.

Hans's Grandfather – Hans moves in with his grandfather following the death of his parents. Hans's grandfather was a senator and devout Christian, and he was skeptical of change and new ideas. Hans associates him with formality, respectability, and tradition. Hans's grandfather dies when Hans is seven years old, and as Hans examines the corpse at the funeral, he muses on the simultaneous spirituality and "base physicality" of death, ideas he will return to throughout his stay at the Berghof.

The Austrian Horseman – The Austrian horseman is a resident of the Berghof. The day Hans first arrives at the Berghof, he overhears the man's horrific, sickly cough, and the experience quite affects him. Indeed, the man's cough seems to be the catalyst that sets Hans's intellectual pursuit to uncover the underlying meaning behind illness and death into motion.

Holger – Holger is the spirit through which Elly Brand supposedly convenes with the spiritual realm—he's described as her "guardian angel." After Elly's supernatural abilities come to light, she leads some other residents in a séance, during which Holger speaks to the group via a Ouija board, spelling out that he has "beautiful brown, brown locks" when the group's ladies inquire about his appearance.

The Loud Russian Couple – Hans's neighbors at the Berghof

are a Russian husband and wife who have loud sex in their adjacent room, behavior that initially puzzles and then later disgusts Hans when he realizes what they are doing. Fittingly, he finds, the couple sits at the "Bad Russian" table in the dining hall. The couple's rudeness and blatant sexuality contributes to the book's negative (and oversimplified) portrayal of Eastern sensibilities.

Emerentia – Emerentia (to whom the novel mostly refers pejoratively as "the dwarf") works at the Berghof. Though she appears sporadically throughout the novel, readers only learn her name after a drunk Mynheer Peeperkorn, in his characteristically personable and obnoxious fashion, asks her what it is. The interaction, however insincere, makes Emerentia blush with satisfaction.

MINOR CHARACTERS

Fräulein Engelhart – Fräulein Engelhart, a schoolteacher, is a resident of the Berghof. She sits at Hans and Joachim's table in the dining hall and teases Hans about his obvious crush on Clavdia Chauchat.

Schalleen – Schalleen is a longtime servant of the Tienappel family. When the Tienappels take in the young orphan Hans, she becomes something of a surrogate mother to him.

Consul Tienappel – Consul Tienappel is Hans's great uncle who became his guardian after the death of Hans's grandfather. He's a respected, affluent Consul and ensures that Hans has a comfortable, privileged upbringing.

Luise Ziemssen – Luise Ziemssen is Joachim's mother. She comes to the Berghof to be with Joachim in his final days. She and Hans are at Joachim's side when he dies.

Lukačnek – Lukačnek is a women's tailor. He rents rooms in his Davos-Dorf home to Settembrini and Naphta.

Dr. Heidekind – Dr. Heidekind is a doctor who treats Hans when he is a young boy. Diagnosing young Hans as somewhat anemic, he instructs him to drink a glass of porter each day when he returns from school, a ritual Hans faithfully performs from that point forward.

The Magnuses – The Magnuses are a married couple who are both residents at the Berghof. Herr Magnus is a brewer.

TERMS

Sanatorium – A sanatorium is an antiquated term that refers to a medical facility for people experiencing chronic health conditions. These facilities are usually located away from urban areas, in specialized climates intended to promote wellness. Sanatoriums dedicated to the treatment of tuberculosis were widespread throughout Europe starting in the late-19th century.

Tuberculosis – Tuberculosis (historically known as “consumption”) is an infectious bacterial disease that mostly affects the lungs. Most tuberculosis infections have no accompanying symptoms, but a minority of cases (around 10 percent) lead to active disease, which is characterized by a chronic cough, fever, and weight loss. An active infection can also spread to other organs, leading to additional complications. The disease can be fatal if left untreated.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



TIME

Throughout *The Magic Mountain*, the novel's omniscient narrator makes abundant, explicit references to time, focusing on time's subjectivity in particular. The novel opens with the arrival of its protagonist, Hans Castorp, at the Berghof, a sanatorium located in the Swiss Alps, where he's traveled to visit his cousin Joachim, who is ill with tuberculosis. Though initially Hans only plans to stay at the Berghof for three weeks, he falls ill just before he's scheduled to depart and ultimately remains at the sanatorium for seven years. While one might expect each of the novel's seven chapters to cover one year of Hans's stay at the Berghof, this is not the case; indeed, Hans's first three weeks at the sanatorium drag on well into Chapter 5. In these first several chapters, the narration describes Hans's complicated process of getting “acclimatized” to the Berghof's strange and unfamiliar way of life in hilariously excessive detail, as when the narrator describes Hans's learning, step by step, the complicated process by which all the Berghof's residents wrap themselves in camel-hair blankets to keep warm in colder weather. However, once Hans's initial three weeks are up and he accepts that he is now a permanent resident of the Berghof rather than a temporary visitor, the narrative's pace accelerates rapidly, and stretches of months and years go by swiftly and unceremoniously. At the same time, experiences that affect Hans profoundly, such as his romantic tryst with Clavdia Chauchat or his impassioned research of various scientific subjects, disproportionately take up many pages. The novel's examination of time plays out in its plot, too, with Hans often philosophizing about the nature of time.

In both its plot and its structure, *The Magic Mountain* portrays time as something irregular and unpredictable—and, above all, something that is experienced in subjective and strange ways. It also shows how one's retrospective sense of time is often quite different from one's lived experience of time. This is why the

narrator, who tells Hans Castorp's story after it has unfolded, knows which moments will affect Hans profoundly (and therefore which ones should take up a considerable amount of the story's “time”) and which moments are inconsequential. Finally, in highlighting the subjective nature of time, which plays an essential role in a person's efforts to make sense of their own life and of history, the novel ultimately makes the overarching point that human experience in general is shaped by undependable, tenuous, and highly mutable thought processes.



COMING OF AGE

The Magic Mountain is, at its core, a Bildungsroman—a story that traces the educational journey its protagonist undergoes over the course of their formative years. Thomas Mann's novel follows Hans Castorp, a young and impressionable engineer, as he transitions from youth to adulthood. Hans first arrives at the Berghof with minimal life experience: he's only recently completed school and has yet to enter the workforce. Meanwhile, his philosophical ideas about life and death are simultaneously underdeveloped, overconfident, and malleable. Early in his stay at the sanatorium, Hans meets an older resident, Settembrini, who swiftly assumes the role of Hans's mentor. Throughout Hans's stay at the Berghof, Settembrini, an intellectual, constantly lectures Hans on the Enlightenment ideals of rationality, progress, and humanism. Though Hans does find value in some of Settembrini's teachings and often enjoys listening to the man speak, he just as often resents the older man's tendency to lecture and condescend to him. As a result, Hans intellectually rebels against his mentor, disregarding the genuinely good advice Settembrini tries to impress upon him and entertaining the potentially ill-advised lessons of dubious characters like the Leo Naphta and Mynheer Peeperkorn. In this way, *The Magic Mountain* portrays naivety and overconfidence as defining characteristics of youth.

While the novel suggests that it is natural and expected that younger generations may disrespect or rebuff the lessons older generations try to teach them, it implies that this response isn't necessarily harmless. Indeed, disregarding such wisdom can even have devastating consequences, as is the case with Hans, whose formative years ultimately lead to little more than tragedy. Though Hans does finally act on Settembrini's positive advice to stop wasting his youth at the Berghof, reenter the world, and become a productive member of society, he does so not because of a mature and voluntary personal revelation. Rather, Hans only rejoins society when he's forced to fight in World War I, where he will almost certainly meet a violent, premature end. Hans's story, then, ends before he can put the lessons he has learned in his formative years to positive, meaningful use. Not only does Hans's naïve obstinance cause him to overlook helpful advice and waste his youth, but the

uncontrollable forces that govern his world deny him the ability to learn from his mistakes.



DEATH AND ILLNESS

The Magic Mountain takes place at the Berghof, a sanatorium for tuberculosis patients. As such, the novel is rife with vivid descriptions and

philosophical considerations of illness, suffering, and death. Protagonist Hans Castorp arrives at the Berghof no stranger to death, having been orphaned at a young age. Hans, therefore, starts out with both a familiarity with and an acceptance of death. While Hans acknowledges that there is value in the rituals people carry out after a person has died, he also accepts the frank, visceral reality of death, which makes unavoidably clear the novel's unsettling emphasis on the idea that, in the end, humans are little more than rotting meat.

Hans's attitude toward death develops over the course of his stay at the Berghof. Upon realizing the lengths to which sanatorium staff go to hide the reality of death from its residents, removing corpses from the facility during mealtimes or in the middle of the night, he begins to deem it an insult to life itself to deal with death in such a clinical, detached manner. Meanwhile, Dr. Krokowski, one of the sanatorium's two main doctors, gives weekly lectures in which he theorizes that illness is the physical manifestation of repressed emotions. For both Hans and Krokowski, then, death and illness become meaningful and even noble parts of the human experience. In Krokowski's view, illness can give insight into a person's inner life. In Hans's view, suffering through illness or dying become noble and intrinsically meaningful tasks rather than tragic and senseless impediments to life.

Settembrini, on the other hand, despises such attitudes, which he argues devalue and dishonor human life. From Settembrini's perspective, there is nothing inherently meaningful or noble about illness or death. Rather, he sees these realities as impediments to a well-lived life—and unfortunate evidence of the myriad ways the physical human body stands in the way of the rational soul's ability to realize its full potential. In its ambiguous portrayal of death and illness, then, *The Magic Mountain* examines the anxiety, confusion, and terror with which humans confront and try to make sense of the frailty of the body and the inevitability of death. While the novel acknowledges that attaching meaning and honor to death and illness can help humans cope with their mortality, it also suggests that such efforts are in vain and that death is as tragically meaningless as it is inevitable.



EAST VS. WEST

Mann began writing *The Magic Mountain* in the years leading up to World War I. Published less than a decade after the war's end, the novel

functions as an allegory for Europe at the onset of World War I, narrativizing the social and political tensions that contributed to that conflict. The Berghof, located in historically neutral Switzerland, functions as a blank slate on which the competing worldviews that divided Europe play out. The facility hosts residents from different countries across Europe, and each represents the ideals of their home country.

In particular, the novel underscores the conflicting (rather simplified) worldviews at the time between the West (represented most notably by the Italian Settembrini) and the East (represented by Clavdia Chauchat, Dr. Krokowski, and Mynheer Peeperkorn, among others). The novel, in turn, represents Western ideals as embracing rationality, progress, and individual freedom, while it portrays Eastern ideals as regressive, superstitious, and irrational. The German Hans Castorp exists in between these opposing worldviews, reflecting Germany's geopolitical status at the center of Eastern and Western powers (at the start of World War I, Germany was the leader of the Central Powers, positioning them against Russia, Italy, and the Allies).

One notable way the novel emphasizes this tension between the West and the East is through Hans Castorp's gradual abandonment of his rational, bourgeois sensibilities for the allure of decadence and general moral decay he experiences at the Berghof, a transition that largely coincides with his ill-fated romance with Clavdia Chauchat, a Russian woman who lives at the sanatorium early in Hans's stay. At first, Clavdia's lethargy, disheveled appearance, and poor manners disgust Hans—he finds them an insult to the ideals of honor and industriousness that his bourgeois German sensibilities have taught him to value. But the longer he stays at the Berghof, the more susceptible he grows to Clavdia's charm, and the more he starts to embrace Clavdia's supposedly "Eastern" ideals, ultimately becoming so indifferent to society that he stops sending letters home, stops reading the paper, and spends his days playing meaningless games of solitaire and resting in his private room. In this way, *The Magic Mountain* uses Hans's experience at the Berghof to convey the opposing social and cultural forces and political powers that divided Europe in the years leading up to World War I. In a broader sense, the novel establishes a duality between rationality and irrationality—bourgeois sensibilities and godless decadence—to reflect historical anxieties about the moral decay of modern society, which the novel implicitly associates with certain supposedly "Eastern" ideals.



ABSTRACT IDEALS VS. LIVED EXPERIENCE

Throughout *The Magic Mountain*, Hans Castorp encounters many new philosophical and scientific ways of looking at the world and finding meaning in life. This becomes especially vital—and complicated—over the course of

his stay at the Berghof due to its remove from the real world. Situated in the Swiss Alps, the Berghof exists out of place and time, in a world that has no relationship to the goings on of society. Residents of the sanatorium spend their days tracking their temperatures and taking their “rest cures,” and they have minimal contact with the outside world. As a result, many long-term residents inevitably descend into a state of malaise and apathy. Life at the Berghof compels its residents to exist in a state of abstract unreality, in which the concerns of ordinary life become irrelevant. Some patients spend their days absorbed in tedious activities designed to pass the time, playing cards or spreading mindless gossip. Others, like Settembrini and Naphta, lecture on their respective philosophical ideals. Hans Castorp initially gravitates toward this latter camp, absorbing himself in scientific and philosophical texts to feed his curiosity about the world and often retreating to a nearby meadow to engage in indulgent philosophical musings.

Ultimately, however, the novel reveals the intellectual engagement that Settembrini, Naphta, Hans, and others gravitate toward to be just as tedious and meaningless as any of the other mindless hobbies that Berghof residents pick up. Despite Hans’s sincere curiosity about the world, and despite Settembrini’s staunch commitment to progress and rationality, both characters fail to translate their abstract beliefs and interests into real action. In other words, their engagement with the world remains just as nonexistent as uncurious Berghof residents who waste their days playing with silly gadgets in the social lounge, spreading gossip, or sleeping. In contrast, the novel presents Hans’s cousin, the soldier Joachim, as an example of a character who models a good and productive way of being. Joachim’s uncurious nature and subservience to authority ironically do not render him passive and unengaged with reality. To the contrary, his commitment to his ideals of honor and duty motivate him to act and rejoin society, leaving the unreal bubble of the Berghof behind to return to the flatlands and his military service. Ultimately, the novel celebrates Joachim’s ability to demonstrate his commitment to his ideals through decisive action, a feat no other character manages to do.

residents’ calm acceptance of their situation even more baffling. He struggles to rationalize and accept how the seriously ill can go about their days laughing, feasting, and acting as though everything is completely normal when the threat of death looms menacingly over their heads. This puzzling acceptance of illness and death comes through most strikingly for Hans in the meticulous taking and recording of one’s temperature, an act all residents carry out as casually and regularly as he indulges in his Maria Mancini cigars—indeed, Dr. Behrens even jokingly refers to a thermometer as a “mercury cigar.”

But as Hans spends more time at the Berghof, he becomes acclimated to its environment, and he eventually begins to see the idle, aimless, and irrational existence of a resident as an alluring escape from the chaotic and stifling social norms of ordinary society. As he undergoes this process of acclimatization, he gradually loses his taste for his Maria Mancinis, signifying his growing alienation from the ordinary world outside the Berghof. Eventually, his cigars bring him no pleasure at all, and this signals his complete disassociation from his old life and its stifling bourgeois social norms. When he finally buys a thermometer from the head nurse and uses it to take his temperature—an act he carries out voluntarily—it signals his choice to disavow the stifling, bourgeois social norms of his old life and give in to the allure of the illness and death as an alternate path toward meaning and self-knowledge.



X-RAY

X-rays represent Hans’s unhealthy and self-destructive fixation on death. Hans first sees his X-ray during a checkup with Dr. Behrens. The sight of his skeleton displayed so plainly on the screen before him forces Hans to acknowledge his mortality for the first time in his life. Though Hans has dealt with the deaths of loved ones, the revelation of his own mortality deeply unsettles him; indeed, he describes the X-ray image as a sight “which no man was ever intended to see [...]” From that point forth, he makes it his goal to understand and dignify death. But Hans’s project quickly consumes him to the point that his efforts to understand, dignify, and make peace with the inevitability of death end up debasing his life. First off, he regards his X-ray image as indisputable proof of both his illness and his need to remain at the Berghof in order to heal. In this way, the X-ray image precludes his return to the real world down in the flatlands and the life of purpose he might have created there, had not the threat of death distracted him. Hans also starts carrying his X-ray image in his wallet as though in place of an ID card, signaling death’s takeover of his identity. Later, he exchanges X-ray images with Clavdia Chauchat, representing death’s takeover of his relationships.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



THERMOMETERS/CIGARS

In *The Magic Mountain*, thermometers symbolize Hans’s initiation into the Berghof’s culture of illness, idleness, and irrationality. When Hans first arrives at the Berghof, the pervasive presence of illness he discerns there deeply unsettles and confuses him. However, he finds



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Vintage edition of *The Magic Mountain* published in 1996.

Part 1, Chapter 1: Arrival Quotes

☞ Time, they say, is water from the river Lethe, but alien air is a similar drink; and if its effects are less profound, it works all the more quickly.

Related Characters: Hans Castorp, Joachim Ziemssen

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 4

Explanation and Analysis

This passage happens early in the book. Hans is on his way to the Berghof, where he has arranged to spend three weeks visiting his sickly cousin, Joachim. As Hans's train ascends the mountains, the narrator muses about the nature of time and the effects that visiting a strange new place can have on a person. This introduces the reader to one of the novel's main themes: time, and how the subjective experience of time's passage affects how a person makes sense of themselves and their life.

Here, the narrator compares time to "water from the river Lethe." In Greek mythology, the river Lethe—the river of forgetfulness—is one of five rivers that lead to the underworld. When the narrator describes time as "water from the river Lethe," then, they suggest that the passage of time gradually inspires forgetfulness. In a broader sense, this means that time can alter a person's sense of self and their ideals, too.

But breathing in the "alien air" of a strange, unfamiliar place—the very thing Hans is about to do at the Berghof—can have this same effect, and it can happen suddenly rather than gradually. In addition to introducing the theme of time, then, this passage also establishes the educational journey toward self-realization that young Hans, the protagonist of this coming-of-age novel, will begin to undergo upon arriving at the Berghof.

Part 1, Chapter 2: Room 34 Quotes

☞ It was a cough, apparently—a man's cough, but a cough unlike any that Hans Castorp had ever heard; indeed, compared to it, all other coughs with which he was familiar had been splendid, healthy expressions of life—a cough devoid of any zest for life or love, which didn't come in spasms, but sounded as if someone were stirring feebly in a terrible mush of decomposing organic material.

Related Characters: Hans Castorp, Joachim Ziemssen, The Austrian Horseman

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 12

Explanation and Analysis

Hans has just arrived at the Berghof. He and Joachim are walking down the hallway on their way to get something to eat when Hans hears the horrific, unsettling sound of a sick man's cough. This is a significant moment in Hans's development because it's his first experience with illness since arriving at the Berghof. Joachim is sick, of course, but the tubercular cough that Hans hears in this moment represents a severity of illness Hans has never before encountered. Over the course of his long stay at the Berghof, Hans will spend considerable time thinking about the significance of illness, suffering, and death, especially as they relate to human life. In a sense, hearing this man's cough, which seems to be "devoid of any zest for life and love," initiates Hans's philosophical investigation of death.

The man responsible for the dreadful sound is an aristocrat whose name is never mentioned—he is only ever referred to as the Austrian Horseman. In denying the man the dignity of a name, the narration objectifies and dehumanizes him. The man's dehumanization illustrates a realization Hans will come to later, when he views Joachim's skeleton on the X-ray displayed in Behrens's office: that sickness reduces a person to a physical body. Indeed, this passage emphasizes the physical process by which the man's illness has overtaken his body, describing in visceral, disgusting detail "the terrible mush of decomposing organic matter."

Hans will spend ample time musing about life, death, and illness over the course of his stay at the Berghof. At first, he will gravitate toward the notion that illness and suffering are deeply meaningful and instrumental in shaping life.

Part 1, Chapter 3: In the Restaurant Quotes

☞ “Quickly and slowly, just as you like,” Joachim replied. “What I’m trying to say is that it doesn’t really pass at all, there is no time as such, and this is no life—no, that it’s not,” he said, shaking his head and reaching again for his glass.

Related Characters: Joachim Ziemssen (speaker), Hans Castorp

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 14

Explanation and Analysis

This passage takes place during Hans’s first meal at the Berghof. Over dinner, Joachim gives Hans an overview of life at the sanatorium, and Hans casually remarks that time must pass quickly for Joachim and the other sanatorium residents. In his response to Hans, Joachim establishes some of the main ways that life at the Berghof differs from life in ordinary society: at the Berghof, explains Joachim, time “doesn’t really pass at all, there is no time as such, and this is no life [...]” He suggests that the Berghof somehow exists outside of time and space. It doesn’t demand the same structure or sense of urgency as life in ordinary society, and this makes time effectively irrelevant.

Also of note in this passage is how it ends: Joachim trails off, as though not sure of what he meant to say in the first place. Joachim’s confusion gives insight into his character, revealing him as a person who doesn’t have much practice at or interest in philosophizing. Indeed, Joachim’s incurious nature is one of his defining features, and it is this aspect of his character that establishes him as Hans’s opposite.

Finally, Joachim’s response sheds light on his feelings about being a resident there. Joachim does not view the respite from reality that the Berghof offers as a positive thing. Being at the Berghof “is no life,” he insists, and he repeatedly voices his frustrations at wasting his life away at the Berghof when he’d rather return to his military service in the flatlands. This is another key way the novel establishes Hans and Joachim as opposites. Whereas Hans gives in to the seductive allure of malaise and illness, Joachim is more disciplined: he has a strong sense of duty and remains determined to return to his life down in the flatlands.

Part 2, Chapter 2: At the Tienappels’/Hans Castorp’s Moral State Quotes

☞ For a person to be disposed to more significant deeds that go beyond what is simply required of him—even when his own times may provide no satisfactory answer to the question of why—he needs either a rare, heroic personality that exists in a kind of moral isolation and immediacy, or one characterized by exceptionally robust vitality. Neither the former nor the latter was the case with Hans Castorp, and so he probably was mediocre after all, though in a very honorable sense of that word.

Related Characters: Hans Castorp, Clavdia Chauchat, Leo Naphta, Consul Tienappel

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 31

Explanation and Analysis

Part 2 of *The Magic Mountain* travels backward in time, beginning with Hans’s childhood and ending with his journey to the Berghof in the novel’s present. The purpose of this interlude is to give readers insight into the experiences and ideas that have shaped Hans into the young man he is at the beginning of his stay at the Berghof. *The Magic Mountain* is a Bildungsroman (a coming-of-age story), and so it is critical for readers to understand where Hans is at developmentally so they can better track his educational journey toward maturation and self-realization.

Though orphaned at a young age, Hans’s wealthy great-uncle, Consul Tienappel, takes him in. All things considered, Hans enjoys a comfortable, privileged, and happy upbringing. Above all, the narrator stresses the ordinariness of Hans’s upbringing, and how that ordinariness has led to Hans being quite ordinary (or “mediocre”) himself. Put simply, Hans is not “disposed to more significant deeds that go beyond what is simply required of him,” meaning he isn’t exceptionally ambitious. He has neither the moral imperative nor the energy to rise above the mases and achieve great things. He simply drifts through life, experiencing whatever experiences come his way. But while Hans’s ordinariness might not predispose him to greatness, it’s not necessarily a negative trait to have.

Here, the narrator portrays Hans’s “mediocre” nature as an “honorable” trait, suggesting that his ordinariness leaves him openminded and impartial. He is, in effect, a blank slate. This aspect of his character plays a critical role in the maturation and self-education he undergoes at the Berghof, where he encounters a variety of personalities with vastly different ways of looking at the world. Hans’s initial

ordinariness leaves him open to receiving the good advice his mentors give him. But it also leaves him undiscerning and thus vulnerable to the irrational and morally dubious points of view he gleans from people like Leo Naphta and Clavdia Chauchat.

Part 3, Chapter 3: Teasing/Viaticum/Interrupted Moment Quotes

☞☞ Joachim searched for an answer. “My God,” he said, “they’re so *free*. I mean, they’re young and time plays no role in their lives, and they may very well die. Why should they go around with long faces? I sometimes think that illness and death aren’t really serious matters, that it’s all more like loafing around, and that, strictly speaking, things are serious only down below in real life. I think maybe you’ll come to understand that in due time, after you’ve been up here with us a little longer.”

Related Characters: Joachim Ziemssen (speaker), Hans Castorp, Hermine Kleeefeld

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 50

Explanation and Analysis

During a walk one day, a young woman named Hermine Kleeefeld “whistles” at Hans through a hole in her abdomen. Joachim explains to a perplexed Hans that this is a side effect of pneumothorax, a type of tuberculosis treatment. He also explains that Hermine in fact heads a group of patients who have had the same procedure. It’s called the “Half-Lung Club.” Hans is aghast at this lighthearted attitude toward serious illness, but Joachim, as this passage shows, sees no harm in it. There’s already a high chance that these patients will die of their illnesses anyway, so what’s the point of “go[ing] around with long faces?” Joachim asks. It’s not as though a person’s attitude toward death has any influence on when or how they die.

Joachim goes a step further, suggesting that perhaps “illness and death aren’t really serious matters,” after all, at least not compared to things that happen “down below in real life.” Joachim’s remark lays the foundation for a conflict that will consume Hans for the remainder of his stay at the Berghof: how to accept the reality of death without letting death consume his life.

Part 3, Chapter 5: Clarity of Mind Quotes

☞☞ “You said ‘actually.’ But ‘actually’ doesn’t apply,” Hans Castorp responded. He was sitting with one thigh hiked up on the railing; the whites of his eyes were bloodshot. “There is nothing ‘actual’ about time. If it seems long to you, then it is long, and if it seems to pass quickly, then it’s short. But how long or how short it is in actuality, no one knows.” He was not at all used to philosophizing, and yet felt some urge to do so.

Joachim contested this. “Why is that? No. We do measure it. We have clocks and calendars, and when a month has passed, then it’s passed—for you and me and everyone.”

Related Characters: Hans Castorp, Joachim Ziemssen (speaker)

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 63-64

Explanation and Analysis

Hans has just watched Joachim take his temperature, a process that Joachim explains takes seven minutes. Joachim, upon removing the thermometer from his mouth, explains that he likes the process, since it makes him understand what seven minutes “actually” means. In this passage, Hans contests Joachim’s use of the word “actually,” which implies that there is a single, objective way to measure and time. Instead, Hans suggests, time is entirely subjective: it’s defined in terms of how it feels to the person experiencing its passage. Something that “seems long [...] is long,” and something that “seems to pass quickly [...] is short.”

This passage describes one of the first signs that Hans has started to change upon arriving at the Berghof—that he has fallen under the (magic) mountain’s spell, as it were: he suddenly feels an uncharacteristic compulsion to “philosophiz[e].” Indeed, Hans will spend much of the next seven years philosophizing on a variety of subjects, including the subjective nature of time.

Joachim’s response to Hans is important, too. Notably, it develops his character by establishing him as Hans’s opposite. Though Joachim has been at the Berghof for several months already, he has not fallen under the Berghof’s spell. Instead, he remains steadfastly tied to the real world he left behind and to which he strives to return. In the real world of society, life, and lived experience, time is measured with “clocks and calendars,” and its meaning doesn’t change according to one’s sense of it.

Part 3, Chapter 8: Herr Albin Quotes

☞ On the whole, however, it seemed to him that although honor had its advantages, so, too, did disgrace, and that indeed the advantages of the latter were almost boundless. He tried putting himself in Herr Albin's shoes and imagining how it must be when one is finally free of all the pressures honor brings and one can endlessly enjoy the unbounded advantages of disgrace—and the young man was terrified by a sense of dissolute sweetness that set his heart pounding even faster for a while.

Related Characters: Hans Castorp, Joachim Ziemssen, Leo Naphta, Herr Albin

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 79

Explanation and Analysis

Hans has just overheard a resident named Herr Albin antagonize a group of women, playfully (but perhaps also somewhat seriously) threatening to kill himself. Herr Albin, as he goes on to explain to these women, believes that his disease is incurable and that this gives him the freedom to do things on his own terms, behaving irrationally and immorally and rejecting social norms as he pleases.

After things have settled down, Hans considers the significance of what Herr Albin has just proposed: that illness gives a person the opportunity to discard “honor” and embrace “disgrace.” Though Hans does not have Joachim's extreme self-discipline and sense of honor, his comfortable upbringing with the Tienappels has imbued him with bourgeois sensibilities a general respect for conventional social norms. Herr Albin's suggestion that there might be a different way to live thus horrifies Hans—but it also entices him, sending his “heart pounding” as he considers its implications. Hans's ambivalent response to Herr Albin's outburst lays the foundation for Hans's gradual undoing as he succumbs to the allure of illness, suffering, and death. Ultimately, his misguided belief that illness leads to greater personal freedom and a deeper understanding of life will set him back on his path toward self-actualization.

Part 4, Chapter 1: A Necessary Purchase Quotes

☞ Illness is, rather, a *debasement*—indeed, a painful debasement of humanity, injurious to the very concept itself. And although one may tend and nurse illness in the individual case, to honor it intellectually is an *aberration*—imprint that on your minds!—an aberration and the beginning of all intellectual aberrations.

Related Characters: Lodovico Settembrini (speaker), Hans Castorp, Leo Naphta

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 97

Explanation and Analysis

During one of Hans's conversations with Settembrini, Hans suggests that suffering and illness might “ennoble” a person, an idea he's been toying with since arriving at the Berghof. Settembrini immediately corrects Hans, drawing on his humanist ideals to set Hans back on track. In this passage, Settembrini describes illness as “a debasement of humanity, injurious to the very concept itself.” Illness, in Settembrini's view, very literally debases a person's humanity in that it diminishes both their quality of life and their capacity to contribute to society. When Settembrini claims that “to honor [death] intellectually is an aberration,” he means that death—and suffering and illness, both gateways to death—does not in itself lead to higher insight. Instead, it prevents or cuts short humanity's capacity to reach its full potential.

In time, Settembrini's influence on Hans will come under siege as a variety of outside influences capture Hans's interest. There is culture of the Berghof, for instance, which elevates illness to something of a status symbol. Leo Naphta, Settembrini's intellectual rival, will later argue that all mortal humans are fundamentally ill. Naphta glorifies illness and suffering for their ability to reveal the physical realm's fundamental wretchedness—and, by comparison, the spiritual realm's fundamental goodness.

Part 4, Chapter 6: Analysis Quotes

☞ Any symptom of illness was a masked form of love in action, and illness was merely transformed love.

Related Characters: Hans Castorp, Dr. Krokowski

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 126

Explanation and Analysis

This line describes the conclusion Krokowski comes to at the end of one of his bi-weekly Sunday lectures. It is the first of these lectures Hans attends, and he (along with the rest of the residents) takes great interest in what Krokowski has to say. Krokowski's early lectures have a psychoanalytic focus, with Krokowski putting forth the general theory that

a person's physical, observable symptoms and behaviors are caused by repressed inner emotions. Here, he specifically identifies symptoms of physical illness as "a masked form of love in action." Krokowski proposes that repressed lust—a common feature of conventional bourgeois society—manifests as physical illness.

Krokowski's lectures influence Hans as he develops his own theories on life, death, illness, and love. The rather scandalous topic of Krokowski's lecture initially makes Hans feel uncomfortable and out of his element, as it challenges his conventional bourgeois sensibilities. By the lecture's conclusion, however, Hans experiences a hint of a personal awakening, though he still has lingering doubts about Krokowski's psychoanalytic theories.

in this passage as well. As Hans readily admits here, his heart had begun to pound well before he first developed feelings for Clavdia Chauchat. In this light, his logic that Clavdia must be the cause of his thudding heart reads as a not-altogether-convincing attempt to justify his feelings of love and lust for Clavdia—feelings that challenge the ideals he was brought up on, about which he seems to feel some level of shame or guilt (note that he cannot bring himself to refer to his "justifiable emotion" by name) and which he seems to recognize as irrational and self-destructive.

Part 4, Chapter 8: Table Talk Quotes

☝ One could no longer say that it thudded on its own accord, for no reason, and without any connection to his soul. There was a connection now, or at least it would not have been difficult to establish one—a justifiable emotion could easily be assigned to his body's overwrought activity. Hans Castorp needed only to think of Frau Chauchat—and he did think of her—and his heart had a suitable emotion to make it pound.

Related Characters: Hans Castorp, Clavdia Chauchat, Dr. Krokowski

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 138

Explanation and Analysis

Hans's feelings for Clavdia Chauchat continue to grow, though he has yet to interact with her directly at this point. Here, Hans reflects that he finally has an explanation for his heart's heavy pounding, which has been an ongoing problem for him since he first arrived at the Berghof. "There [i]s a connection now," Hans muses, noting that "a justifiable emotion could easily be assigned to his body's overwrought activity." That emotion—which Hans notably leaves unspoken—is his budding love for Clavdia Chauchat. Hans doesn't say so explicitly, but it's clear that the logic he employs here comes from Krokowski's recent Sunday lecture, during which Krokowski theorized that symptoms of physical illness are an expression of repressed love (or lust). Though Hans exited that lecture feeling uncomfortable and unconvinced, this passage shows that he is slowly shedding his bourgeois sensibilities.

However, Hans's characteristic ambivalence comes through

Part 4, Chapter 10: The Thermometer Quotes

☝ "Illness makes people even more physical, turns them into only a body."

Related Characters: Hans Castorp (speaker), Joachim Ziemssen, Dr. Behrens

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 175

Explanation and Analysis

Hans accompanies Joachim to his checkup. As Dr. Behrens examines Joachim, Hans looks at his cousin's unclothed, frail form and considers how illness affects a person's body and soul. Just before this passage, Hans lamented the tragedy of Joachim's body turning on him. Unlike Hans, who has gradually adjusted to life at the Berghof and does not despair when he suddenly falls ill and must postpone his exit indefinitely, Joachim has never allowed himself to adjust to the Berghof or to the culture of illness. He is a soldier with a strong sense of duty, and he has been resolute in his goal to recover as fast as possible so that he may return to his military service. And yet Joachim's strength of will cannot compete with his illness. Though he wants to recover, he cannot transcend the force of his illness. Ultimately, as Hans alludes to here, he is subject to the whims of his body and the organisms that prey on it.

The frank, unromanticized view of illness demonstrates the degree to which Hans has been listening to and absorbing some of what Settembrini has tried to teach him. Earlier, Settembrini criticized Hans for wanting to believe that illness and suffering "ennoble" a person, warning Hans that illness debases life. Hans, in noting how Joachim's illness has continued to ravage his body even as he strives to recover and return to his military service, shows that he has internalized Settembrini's advice enough to apply it to situations in his own life, if only in a fleeting and noncommittal way.

Part 5, Chapter 1: Eternal Soup and Sudden Clarity Quotes

☞ “The only healthy and noble and indeed, let me expressly point out, the only *religious* way in which to regard death is to perceive and feel it as a constituent part of life, as life’s holy prerequisite, and not to separate it intellectually, to set it up in opposition to life, or, worse, to play it off against life in some disgusting fashion—for that is indeed the antithesis of a healthy, noble, reasonable, and religious view. [...] Death is to be honored as the cradle of life, the womb of renewal. Once separated from life, it becomes grotesque, a wraith—or even worse. For as an independent spiritual power, death is a very depraved force, whose wicked attractions are very strong and without doubt can cause the most abominable confusion of the human mind.”

Related Characters: Lodovico Settembrini (speaker), Hans Castorp, Leo Naphta, Dr. Behrens

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 197

Explanation and Analysis

Dr. Behrens has recently examined Hans and, finding him sufficiently ill, demanded that Hans postpone his departure. Then, he put him on bedrest. Settembrini visits Hans during this time to check up on his young mentee—but also to dispense some important advice about how to make sense of his new illness.

In this passage, Settembrini elaborates on some of the ideas he has already shared with Hans, notably the relationship between life and death. Settembrini delivers these remarks in response to Hans’s claim that exposure to death gives a person insight into life’s inherent cruelties—in short, that engaging with death gives a person insight that ignorant, unaffected people lack. Settembrini contests this view with great force, however, highlighting Hans’s critical error in conceptualizing life and death as separate, competing forces. An understanding of death as “an independent spiritual power” gives rise to all manner of dangerous, self-destructive ideas and behaviors, such as those that Leo Naphta later espouses. Settembrini, in short, urges Hans to “honor” death as an inevitable, inseparable event of life—not as a separate force that acts “in opposition to life.”

Part 5, Chapter 2: “My God, I See It!” Quotes

☞ And Hans Castorp saw exactly what he should have expected to see, but which no man was ever intended to see and which he himself had never presumed he would be able to see: he saw his own grave. Under that light, he saw the process of corruption anticipated, saw the flesh in which he moved decomposed, expunged, dissolved into airy nothingness [...] he beheld a familiar part of his body, and for the first time in his life he understood that he would die.

Related Characters: Hans Castorp, Dr. Behrens

Related Themes:   

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 215-216

Explanation and Analysis

Hans has recently fallen ill and accepted his new life as a resident of the Berghof. During a checkup, Behrens X-rays Hans, and Hans sees his insides for the first time. What Hans sees deeply unsettles him, and he describes it as something “which no man was ever intended to see and which he himself had never presumed he would be able to see: [...] his own grave.” Hans had firsthand experience with death early in his life: both his parents died when he was very young. Previously, he reasoned that this early exposure to death may have enriched him in some abstract way, giving him insight into the inherent cruelty and brutality of human existence. Yet seeing his own organic matter displayed on the X-ray image affects him in a wholly new and unexpected way: it forces him to confront the horrifying reality of his own inevitable death. Hans has put considerable thought into the nature of life, death, and illness since his arrival at the Berghof. But from this point forward, his knowledge of death as the unavoidable terminus of life will gradually corrupt his self-education, leading him down a path of self-destruction and self-indulgence.

Part 5, Chapter 3: Freedom Quotes

☞ “Analysis is good as a tool of enlightenment and civilization—to the extent that it shakes stupid preconceptions, quashes natural biases, and undermines authority. Good, in other words, to the extent that it liberates, refines, and humanizes—it makes slaves ripe for freedom. It is bad, very bad, to the extent that it prevents action, damages life at its roots, and is incapable of shaping it. Analysis can be very unappetizing, as unappetizing as death, to which it may very well be linked—a relative of the grave and its foul anatomy.”

Related Characters: Lodovico Settembrini (speaker), Hans Castorp, Dr. Krokowski

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 219

Explanation and Analysis

This passage comes from one of Hans and Settembrini's conversations. Hans has just mentioned Krokowski's psychoanalytic lectures, prompting this response from Settembrini (who is not particularly fond of Krokowski or his fixation with psychoanalysis). Settembrini begins by acknowledging the benefits of psychoanalysis, noting its capacity to promote the Enlightenment ideals that form the core of Settembrini's own worldview. Psychoanalysis is good for society in that it allows people to identify repressed personal biases and use logic to challenge accepted social norms and ideas about authority that otherwise threaten the individual's ability to achieve happiness and personal freedom.

However, Settembrini contends, psychoanalysis may cause more harm than good in "that it prevents action, damages life at its roots, and is incapable of shaping it." Here, Settembrini seems to refer to Krokowski's theory, derived from psychoanalysis, that humans are fundamentally ill, or irrational: that there are dark, repressed, irrational forces lurking beneath the surface of all humans that threaten or make impossible humanity's essential goal (in Settembrini's humanist worldview) to advance civilization through rational engagement with the world.

Of course, readers should note that Settembrini's position is not without its flaws. Just as his approach to the "foul anatomy" of death is to minimize or outright deny its impact on life, so too he rejects the "unappetizing" psychoanalytic claim that there are irrational, self-destructive, and uncontrollable forces within every human—even über-rational humans like Settembrini himself.

Part 5, Chapter 8: Danse Macabre Quotes

☞☞ "Just listen, and tell me if it isn't the funniest thing you've ever heard in your life."

Related Characters: The Overblown Woman (Frau Zimmermann) (speaker), Hans Castorp

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 301

Explanation and Analysis

Hans, in his quest to dignify death, takes to visiting the Berghof's sickest residents. Since arriving at the Berghof, he has been disappointed at and bothered by the residents' and staffs' blasé, disrespectful, or dismissive attitudes toward death and illness. Hans arrived at the Berghof with certain expectations about what death and illness do to a person's character, and many of the ill residents at the Berghof have seriously challenged those expectations. Even Hans's project of visiting residents with the most serious conditions and showing them how people ought to treat sickness has fallen short, with even these most critically ill—and therefore, in Hans's mind, most critically needing to be dignified—failing to show their own suffering the respect and seriousness Hans thinks it deserves.

The Overblown Woman (whose real name is Frau Zimmermann) is one of these examples. The above quotation is her introduction to the horrific story of how a doctor overblew her lungs with oxygen, a major error that resulted in devastating consequences for her health. Yet to hear the woman introduce the story now—"tell me if it isn't the funniest thing you've ever heard in your life"—one would think she is about to tell a story about a flea circus rather than a grave and horrific medical error. What's more, the woman dies before Hans can return for a second attempt at dignity. This passage thus illustrates Hans's main frustration as he undertakes his personal journey toward understanding death: he wants to find some kind of logic or decorum that will also allow him to reliably understand (and therefore feel less anxious and troubled by) death and suffering, as though it were a field of science, yet the fundamentally irrational nature of death and humans renders that impossible.

Part 5, Chapter 9: Walpurgis Night Quotes

☞☞ "Oh, love is nothing if not foolish, something mad and forbidden, an adventure in evil. Otherwise it is merely a pleasant banality, good for singing calm little songs down on the plains. [...]"

Related Characters: Hans Castorp (speaker), Clavdia Chauchat

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 336

Explanation and Analysis

This quotation is an excerpt from Hans and Clavdia's flirtatious interaction, which takes place during the

Walpurgis Night celebration. It is significant in that it is the first time they have truly interacted—up to this point, they have only exchanged knowing glances from across the dining hall or as they passed each other in the hall. Now, Hans effusively and foolishly declares his love for Clavdia, explicitly remarking on the “foolish” nature not only of his romance but of love in general. He also mentions the “mad and forbidden” nature of love, describing it as “an adventure in evil.” In emphasizing the perverse and irrational nature of passion, Hans draws a comparison between his passion for Clavdia and his ongoing fixation on death—two things has repeatedly regarded with ambivalence, simultaneously tempted by and fearful of their implicit danger.

Hans’s ambivalence at romance comes through even as he declares his love for Clavdia—the italicized text of this passage indicates that the conversation is being carried out in French, which is not Hans’s native tongue. This linguistic remove heightens the romance’s surreal quality—indeed, Hans remarks a number of times throughout this conversation that he feels as though he is dreaming. This suggests that while on some level he wants to live outside the confines of ordinary society and give in to abandon and passion, the bourgeois sensibilities he was brought up with give him pause.

engineer” (Settembrini’s quasi term of affection for Hans) suggests that Settembrini may be willing to make amends with Hans. But Settembrini’s mention of “pomegranate” (an allusion to the Greek myth of Hades and Persephone, in which Hades tricks Persephone into returning to the Underworld for a few months each year) suggests Settembrini’s lingering disappointment and betrayal. Settembrini has repeatedly warned Hans not to give in to the temptation of Clavdia, who embodies all the “Eastern” sensibilities—irrational passion, illness, decadence—that Settembrini fears will distract Hans from living a life that conforms to Settembrini’s Western ideals. When Settembrini asks how Hans “like[d] the pomegranate,” then, he’s suggesting that Hans’s misstep has irrevocably corrupted him and that it is no longer possible for him to return to the right, good path of Western ideals from which he has strayed.

Part 6, Chapter 1: Changes Quotes

☞ “Well, my good engineer, how did you like the pomegranate?”

Related Characters: Lodovico Settembrini (speaker), Hans Castorp, Clavdia Chauchat

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 394

Explanation and Analysis

Part 6 picks up after the Berghof’s Walpurgis Night celebration, during which Hans spent a flirtatious and subliminally sensual hour with Clavdia Chauchat. Settembrini has ignored Hans ever since he observed Hans and Clavdia together, having repeatedly warned Hans not to associate with Clavdia, whom he considers a corrupting influence on young, impressionable Hans. This remark, made as he and Hans pass each other in the hallway, is Settembrini’s first effort to reestablish communication with Hans.

The remark is simultaneously affectionate, mocking, and accusatory. On the one hand, addressing Hans as “my good

Part 6, Chapter 2: Someone Else Quotes

☞ “Oh, you and your learning! You’re always learning up here—about biology and botany and slippery turning points. And you started in on ‘time’ your first day here. When what we’re here to do is to get healthier, not more clever—healthier, until we’re truly healthy, so they can finally let us go free and send us back to the flatlands cured.”

Related Characters: Joachim Ziemssen (speaker), Hans Castorp, Clavdia Chauchat, Lodovico Settembrini, Leo Naphta, Dr. Behrens

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 379

Explanation and Analysis

Hans and Joachim are walking back from a visit with Naphta and Settembrini, during which Naphta and Settembrini debated their respective ideals. Hans recognizes that much of what Naphta said was irrational but finds himself intrigued by the man nonetheless, and he’s annoyed at Joachim for his disinterest in their new acquaintance. Hans’s insistence annoys Joachim in return, and he lashes out at Hans, expressing his growing impatience with Hans for “always learning up here[.]” Since Clavdia left the Berghof, Hans has begun his self-education in earnest, throwing himself into textbooks on philosophy and various fields of science. Joachim sees Hans’s studies as a distraction from what should be his and Joachim’s primary goal: “to get healthier, not more clever,” so that they can return to the flatlands and resume their lives there.

Joachim, the dutiful soldier, has not allowed himself to succumb to the allure of illness and self-indulgence that abounds at the Berghof, and he views Hans's studies—which offer no practical benefit to him in his immediate life—as a sign of Hans's weak-willed nature.

This passage marks a significant development in Hans and Joachim's relationship. Although Joachim has never supported Hans's intellectual pursuits or his willing and eager embrace of the Berghof's culture of idle decadence, he has not attacked Hans as directly as he does now, and tensions will continue to mount between them until Joachim unexpectedly announces his plans to return to his military service against Behrens's orders.

Part 6, Chapter 3: The City of God and Evil Deliverance Quotes

☞ His form is logic, but his nature is confusion.

Related Characters: Lodovico Settembrini (speaker), Hans Castorp, Joachim Ziemssen, Leo Naphta

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 399

Explanation and Analysis

Settembrini is walking Hans and Joachim back to the Berghof following their visit with Naphta when he pauses to caution the cousins against spending too much time with Naphta. Settembrini believes that Naphta's ideas are dangerous, especially to impressionable youths like Hans and Joachim. "His form is logic, but his nature is confusion," Settembrini declares. Settembrini is likely alluding to Enlightenment philosopher René Descartes's concept of mind-body dualism, which holds that the mind (or soul) and body are closely related but distinct entities, meaning one can exist without the other. While the mind consists of a non-physical substance, the body consists of a physical substance. Settembrini is adapting Descartes's concept to suggest that while Naphta's form (that is, the thoughts his physical body voices aloud) might seem logically sound, Naphta's "nature" (his mind) is fundamentally confused. With this distinction, Settembrini gestures toward the fundamental contradiction of Naphta's character: he must rely on reason to discredit reason, generating logical (or logical-sounding) arguments to back illogical ways of understanding the world. Similarly, Naphta uses his status as a Jesuit to outwardly proclaim an ascetic lifestyle and an essentially religious view of the world, yet his intellectual

debates with Settembrini expose the decadence and nihilism that underly his ideals.

Part 6, Chapter 4: An Outburst of Temper/ Something Very Embarrassing Quotes

☞ "Yes, you're cured. The spot at the upper left isn't worth talking about. Your temperature has nothing to do with it. I can't tell you what causes that. I assume it's of no further importance. As far as I'm concerned, you may leave."

Related Characters: Dr. Behrens (speaker), Hans Castorp, Joachim Ziemssen

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 411

Explanation and Analysis

Joachim has just announced his plans to leave the Berghof against Behrens's orders so that he can return to his military service. A dismayed Behrens asks if Hans will leave with Joachim, assuming that Hans will do just that. When Hans replies that he'll only leave if he has Behrens's permission, Behrens offers the above quotation in response. The revelation that he is apparently "cured" shocks and unsettles Hans, who has by this point fully settled in at the Berghof and committed himself to a life of illness and suffering. He has become so invested in his illness and its accompanying threat of death that he can no longer fathom a life back in ordinary society, which is no less saturated with death but where people suppress their awareness of it in order to live. When Behrens insists that Hans's temperature "has nothing to do with" the moist spot on Hans's lungs, he seems to indicate that Hans is suffering from a different kind of illness, one that is perhaps less physical and more existential in nature.

It is a major turning point in the story that Behrens, who was initially so eager to guide Hans into the Berghofian realm of illness and idleness, has finally lost his patience with Hans. Although the novel leaves room for ambiguity regarding the exact cause of Behrens's anger, part of it may stem from Hans's refusal to accept responsibility for his behavior. Up to this point, Hans has insisted to others and to himself that he is only staying at the Berghof because of his condition or because Behrens has advised him to, even though it is abundantly clear to the reader that Hans has voluntarily *chosen* to remain at the Berghof. While he may have been critically ill at certain points in the past, ultimately Hans stays at the Berghof—for seven years!—because he

wants to. The life of idle decadence he has experienced there appeals to him, even if he can't bring himself to admit it.

Part 6, Chapter 5: An Attack Repulsed Quotes

☞ And that was the end of the attempt by the flatlands to reclaim Hans Castorp. The young man admitted quite openly to himself that such total failure, which he had seen coming, was of decisive importance for his relationship to the people down there. For the flatlands it meant a final shrug, the abandonment of any claim; for him, however, it meant freedom finally won, and by now his heart no longer fluttered at the thought.

Related Characters: Hans Castorp, Uncle James Tienappel

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 432

Explanation and Analysis

Hans's uncle James Tienappel, who visited Hans at the Berghof with a plan to convince Hans to come home, has just left without saying goodbye. James's introduction to the Berghof was uncannily similar to Hans's: he found the strange, unfamiliar place simultaneously repulsive and alluring. Yet while Hans gave into that allure, James recognized the danger of doing so and left before it could happen. In James's absence, Hans reflects on the "decisive importance" of this moment. Now that his favorite uncle regards him as a lost cause and perhaps even a source of shame, "the flatlands" can no longer "reclaim" him. While Hans considers this a neutral outcome—"a final shrug"—for the flatlands, for him it is a victory. Now that there is nobody left to convince him to come home and resume his conventional life, he has finally earned his "freedom" from the stifling constraints of bourgeois society and all its expectations of honor, duty, and respectability. Now, by virtue of his illness, he has earned the right to be idle and eschew social norms. Of course, the irony is that while Hans has come to use illness to justify his malaise, the fact that "his heart no longer flutter[s] at the thought" suggests that he is really not as sick as he claims or believes himself to be. Instead, he has simply chosen to remove himself from the world.

Part 6, Chapter 6: Operationes Spirituales Quotes

☞ Illness was supremely human, Naphta immediately rebutted, because to be human was to be ill.

Related Characters: Leo Naphta (speaker), Hans Castorp, Lodovico Settembrini

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 456

Explanation and Analysis

Hans reflects on a remark that Naphta made during one of his and Settembrini's spirited debates, in response to Settembrini's claim that illness robs a person of their dignity and humanity. Naphta's rebuttal, as outlined in the above quotation, argues that illness is actually "supremely human [...] because to be human [i]s to be ill." Naphta's remark lays out the core difference of his and Settembrini's understandings of illness and of suffering in general. Settembrini regards illness as a deviation from humanity's default state, meaning humans are fundamentally healthy and sickness is something that happens to them, diminishing their quality of life. In this view, the "ordinary" people who inhabit the flatlands are healthy and residents of the Berghof are ill. Naphta's position, on other hand, suggests that illness is a fundamental characteristic of human existence. In this view, all humans are ill, and those who don't appear so on the surface (like the ordinary people of the flatlands, for instance) are merely repressing their illness. Although Naphta's and Settembrini's positions on the fundamental nature of humanity differ, they are alike in their primary goal: to establish a framework that rationalizes illness and suffering.

Part 6, Chapter 7: Snow Quotes

☞ Death is a great power. You take off your hat and tiptoe past his presence, rocking your way forward. [...] Reason stands foolish before him, for reason is only virtue, but death is freedom and kicking over the traces, chaos and lust. Lust, my dream says, not love. Death and love—there is no rhyming them, that is a preposterous rhyme, a false rhyme. Love stands opposed to death—it alone, and not reason, is stronger than death. Only love, and not reason, yields kind thoughts. [...] Oh, what a clear dream I've dreamed, how well I've 'played king'! I will remember it. I will keep faith with death in my heart, but I will clearly remember that if faithfulness to death and to what is past rules our thoughts and deeds, that leads only to wickedness, dark lust, and hatred of humankind. For the sake of goodness and love, man shall grant death no dominion over his thoughts.

Related Characters: Hans Castorp (speaker), Lodovico Settembrini, Leo Naphta

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 487

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, which is part of a much longer monologue, Hans relates the lessons he has taken away from a dream he has after losing consciousness in the snowstorm while skiing. There are two main parts of the dream. In the first, Hans encounters a group of happy, healthy children playing along the shore. Then the mood shifts, becoming more ominous, as Hans approaches a great temple. Inside, he sees old women, unclothed, dismembering a baby. His terror rouses him from his state of unconsciousness or subconsciousness, and he has the following revelation about life, death, and illness.

Hans's revelation here is so important because it brings clarity to the shortcomings that have undermined his self-education (effectively his quest to acknowledge the terrors of death and illness without rendering life meaningless as a result) over the course of the novel. In short, Hans realizes his error in trying to attach meaning or dignity to death in an effort to justify its existence. There was never any need to dignify death, he seems to suggest here, for it "is a great power" already. In fixating on death all this time, he has merely brought "wickedness, dark lust, and hatred of humankind" upon himself.

Hans's revelation that "Reason stands foolish before him" also outlines the shortcomings of Hans's mentors' philosophical approaches to death, as well. Both Settembrini and Naphta, in their overreliance on or overt avoidance of reason, respectively, failed to make a convincing argument for life's meaningfulness amidst the horrifying reality of death.

Hans's dream shows him a different path toward accepting death, and that is through "goodness and love," or a love of humankind. Ultimately, death is horrible and arbitrary—the fundamentally irrational fact that beautiful life can coexist with the horrors of suffering and illness makes this clear. So instead of appealing to reason to come to terms with the horrific reality of death, one must seek comfort in one's relationships with others.

Part 6, Chapter 8: A Good Soldier Quotes

☞☞ But honor was the death of him, or—if you turn it the other way around—death did him the honor.

Related Characters: Dr. Behrens (speaker), Joachim

Ziemssen

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 529

Explanation and Analysis

After Joachim dies, Behrens visits his room to pay his respects. In this passage, Behrens laments Joachim's decision to return to his military service, a choice that ultimately led to his death. Although Behrens had strongly advised Joachim to reconsider his decision to leave the Berghof prematurely, ultimately Joachim's sense of duty prevailed, and he left the Berghof against Behrens's orders. This inevitably caused his health to deteriorate, leading to his return to the Berghof, and finally to his death. This is why Behrens declares Joachim's "honor" to be "the death of him." Ultimately, the allure of illness that so many of the Berghof's residence succumb to could not persuade Joachim to abandon his sense of honor. Behrens thus implies that Joachim's commitment to honor was so great it bordered on foolish.

Behrens's amended claim that "death did [Joachim] the honor" reinforces Joachim's commitment to honor, but in a more sympathetic light. As Joachim's foolish decision to risk his health to return to his military service suggests, he would rather die than continue to live an idle, meaningless, and altogether dishonorable existence at the Berghof—an existence to which he was forced to return when his health took a turn for the worse. Thus, "death did him an honor" in killing him when it did, mercifully sparing him the degrading experience of illness he put his life on the line to escape.

Part 7, Chapter 10: The Great Petulance Quotes

☞☞ There were moments when, as you "played king," you saw the intimation of a dream of love rising up out of death and this carnal body. And out of this worldwide festival of death, this ugly rutting fever that inflames the rainy evening sky all round—will love someday rise up out of this, too?

Related Characters: Hans Castorp

Related Themes:    

Page Number: 706

Explanation and Analysis

These are the closing lines of the novel. Hans has finally returned to the flatlands, but not of his own volition: World War I broke out and he was forced to return to fight in the

battlefields. The novel's closing images are thus saturated with death and destruction—and not the calm, dignified sort Hans has long sought to capture. This death is chaotic, brutal, and eviscerating. As Hans perilously makes his way through the battlefields amidst gunshots and explosions, the narrator remarks on the likelihood that Hans will die here. Then, indirectly addressing Hans, the narrator recalls Hans's days of “playing king” in the meadow. They cite “the intimation of a dream of love rising up out of death and this carnal body,” referencing Hans's pivotal, revelatory dream at the end of Part 6, Chapter 7: Snow. That dream gave Hans the revelation that the force of love could somehow allow people to find meaning in life amid the incomprehensible horrors of suffering and death.

Shifting back to the novel's present, the narrator asks Hans, as he cowers on the battlefield, whether love will be enough

to make sense of “this worldwide festival of death, this ugly rutting fever that inflames the rainy evening sky all round.” The horrific, visceral details of this question indicate that it is rhetorical: there is no force, not even love, that is strong or compelling enough to explain or live with the horrors of the death, destruction, and chaos on this mass scale. With these closing lines, *The Magic Mountain* ends ambiguously yet tragically. Not only has the arrival of war cut Hans Castorp's life short before he has had the chance to live out the lessons he has learned over the course of his self-education, but the sheer enormity of its violence and brutality call into question whether those lessons would even hold up in the first place. Amid the abject horror of global war, Hans's naïve belief that love may “rise up out of death” and allow everything to make sense falls flat.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

FOREWORD

The narrator introduces the protagonist of their story, Hans Castorp: an “ordinary” young man. Castorp’s story happened very long ago. In fact, the story’s “pastness” is its defining feature, specifically the fact that it takes place just before the Great War (World War I). The narrator resolves to take their time telling the story, taking care to be very detailed and thorough, for Hans’s story spans the course of seven years, though it’s hard to believe it lasted that long.

From the start, the narration’s emphasis on “pastness” establishes the subjective experience of time as one of the novel’s central themes. In addition, the detail that Hans is an “ordinary” young man establishes him as average, unremarkable, and perhaps not well versed in worldly matters.



PART 1, CHAPTER 1: ARRIVAL

One summer, the “ordinary” Hans Castorp leaves his hometown of Hamburg and heads to the mountains, to a sanatorium in Davos Platz. He plans to stay there for three weeks. Getting there requires a long and arduous journey through the Alps. It requires boarding a train at Rorschach, then boarding another train to Landquart. Up to that point the journey is dull, and the passing scenery is unremarkable. But upon boarding another train at Landquart, the wild and treacherous ascent up the mountains begins.

The story begins with Hans leaving his home behind to journey into the mountains. The shift from boring, mundane scenery to vivid, wild, and treacherous mountains suggests that Hans is venturing into a new and unfamiliar world. This passage thus lays the groundwork for the mountains as a separate realm, one where the norms or rules of conventional society—norms that the ordinary Hans likely has grown up with—might not apply.



Hans Castorp is alone in a small compartment on the train. The only things he has with him are an alligator suitcase—which was a gift from his uncle (Consul Tienappel, who is Hans’s guardian)—a blanket, and his winter coat. The window is open, and the air grows colder as the train makes its ascent. Hans, who is rather delicate and pampered, rolls up the delicate silk collar of his overcoat. He has been traveling for two days now.

The Magic Mountain is a Bildungsroman, or a coming-of-age story that follows a protagonist’s educational journey from youth to adulthood. This passage, with its mention of Hans’s delicate disposition and little silk collar, emphasizes his youth and inexperience. At this early point in the story, he’s not seen much of the world and still has considerable learning to do.



People describe time as “water from the river Lethe,” but being in a strange place—breathing “alien air”—is not so different. Though less “profound, it works all the more quickly.” Hans has experienced this sensation already, though he went into the trip trying not to take it too seriously and not expecting to emerge from it changed. Yesterday, he was still preoccupied with thoughts of his everyday life: of his exams, and of Tunder and Wilms, the firm he was about to join. He just wanted to get the next three weeks over with. But now, as he is transported into a new and strange place, he can’t help but be fully invested in his journey. He’s excited, despite himself, and he wonders what it’ll be like “up there.” Being born just above sea level, he wonders if it’s even healthy for him to be up this high.

Once more, the narration explicitly draws attention to the strange and unsettling nature of time—in Greek mythology, the river Lethe, also known as the river of forgetfulness, is one of the passages to the underworld. In describing time as “water from the river Lethe,” the narration foregrounds the theme of time’s subjective nature, pointing to time’s ability to skew memory. Finally, in comparing the sensation of breathing the “alien air” of a strange, new place to “water from the river Lethe,” the narration suggests that being in a new place can, like time, skew a person’s perception and perhaps even cause them to lose sight of the person they were before they got there. This heavily indicates that Hans will undergo such a transformation during his stay at the Berghof.



Eventually the train reaches the end of its ascent and pulls into the small station of Davos-Dorf. Hans Castorp hears someone at the station call his name. Suddenly, his cousin Joachim Ziemssen is beside him. Joachim looks healthier than Hans has ever seen him. In a friendly, easygoing voice, he tells Hans that they're near the sanatorium—it's time for Hans to disembark. Hans gathers his belongings and gets off the train. The concierge of the International Sanatorium Berghof takes Hans's trunk to store it while Joachim and Hans get dinner.

Once inside their carriage, Hans asks Joachim how his own health is—Joachim looks well enough to return to the military—and if Joachim will be “coming back down” when Hans leaves in three weeks. This puzzles Joachim—he can't fathom that Hans is already thinking about leaving when he's just arrived. And “up here,” three weeks is practically nothing—time, Joachim explains, is totally different “up here” than it is “down below.” In fact, Joachim's next appointment isn't even for another six months. This shocks Hans, who can't imagine wasting so much of one's life. Joachim says that Hans will start seeing things differently once he's been here a while. Then, to answer Hans's initial question, Joachim says that he's feeling better, though the lower lobe is still rattling around quite a bit.

The carriage heads up a hilly road, and Hans sees the sanatorium in the distance. It's a long building with so many balconies along its walls that from afar it almost looks like a sponge. As the sun sets, Hans considers the magnificent scenery that surrounds him. He notes how glorious the air is up here. Joachim, looking extremely disgusted, says that Hans will soon tire of it. Inwardly, Hans thinks it's really strange how frequently Joachim is using the phrase “us up here.”

Joachim casually mentions that because of the high altitude here, sanatoriums must use bobsleds to cart the bodies down the mountains. The absurdity of how calmly Joachim has just spoken about dead bodies causes Hans to laugh, and he jokes that Joachim has become cynical since coming here. Joachim merely shrugs and explains that Behrens, the surgeon, is a cynic. Joachim thinks Hans will like him. He also mentions Krokowski, Behrens's assistant, who “dissects the patients' psyches.”

Thus far, the narration has hinted that Hans's journey into the mountains will be transformative in some way. That Joachim looks healthier than Hans has ever seen him suggests, then, that whatever transformation Hans undergoes during his time here may be for the better. Indeed, sanatoriums were generally located in areas with climates thought to be beneficial to people with conditions like tuberculosis and other chronic illnesses.



This passage provides background information about Joachim: Hans's observation indicates that Joachim is in the military. Joachim's remark about three weeks not seeming so long “up here” reinforces the notion that time is malleable and subjective—it can pass quickly or slowly depending on one's circumstances and one's environment. Here, Joachim suggests that something about the atmosphere of the sanatorium makes the days and weeks fly by. Hans's shock at how long and drawn-out Joachim's treatment at the sanatorium is shows that time is much more regimented and organized where he's from, in the world “back down” the mountain.



Joachim's frequent use of the phrase “us up here” establishes the Berghof and its residents as somehow distinct from ordinary society and the people who inhabit it—perhaps residents' shared experience of illness sets them apart from healthy people.



The image of a bobsled (which suggests fun and recreation) carting dead bodies (about which there is conceivably nothing fun) down the mountain juxtaposes lightheartedness with the horror of death in a way that strikes Hans as absurd. One of the aspects of life at the Berghof that Hans will have to adjust to is the unavoidable presence of death. At this early point in the novel, Joachim, an acclimated resident of the Berghof, has acquired a casual acceptance of death that Hans lacks.



PART 1, CHAPTER 2: ROOM 34

Hans and Joachim reach the sanatorium and step inside. The place is oddly empty, and Hans asks Joachim where all the guests are. "Taking their rest cure," explains Joachim. He himself would be lying out on his balcony if he hadn't requested to leave to pick up Hans from the station—it's a rule.

Joachim introduces another alien aspect of life at the Berghof: the "rest cure," a requirement for all patients struggling with chronic illnesses. Though presumably the practice has a medical purpose, it also gives readers (and Hans) additional insight into the passivity and idleness that characterizes patients' existence at the Berghof. In other words, life here involves a lot of lying around and doing nothing—a far cry from the hustle and bustle of life "down below," as it were.



Joachim leads Hans down a long white corridor until they reach Hans's room, Number 34. Joachim's room is to the right, and a loud Russian couple is in the room to the left. Hans and Joachim enter the room, which is white and furnished plainly and practically. A balcony at one end of the room offers a pleasant view of the valley. Hans thinks he'll be happy here for a couple of weeks. Joachim casually remarks that an American woman died there two days ago, but he assures Hans that the room has been sanitized.

Once more, Joachim very casually offers a detail that would shock most people—Hans will be staying in a room where a woman died just two days before. The ease with which Joachim relates this fact further underscores the pervasiveness of death at the Berghof. To Joachim, sanitizing a room someone recently died in is no more significant than soaking up some spilled milk.



Suddenly Hans hears a horrid cough coming from down the hall. It's a sound "devoid of any zest for life or love," and it "sound[s] as if someone were stirring feebly in a terrible mush of decomposing organic material." Hans is amazed—it's unlike any cough he's ever heard before. He remembers having the croup when he was younger, but that was nothing compared to this man's cough. Joachim shrugs it off, as he hears things like this every day.

Hans's horror at hearing this intense, gruesome cough—and the visceral detail with which the narration describes the cough ("a terrible mush of decomposing organic material") reflects his present ambivalence toward death and illness. While death and illness might shock and horrify him, they also seem to captivate him, particularly compared to Joachim, who barely registers the sick man's horrific cough.



PART 1, CHAPTER 3: IN THE RESTAURANT

Hans and Joachim sit down at the sanatorium's restaurant, where they have an elaborate meal. Hans finds the food exceptional, but Joachim is underwhelmed, having grown accustomed to the cooking here. He tells Hans it's great to have him here, since things can get pretty monotonous. This shocks Hans, who assumed time would pass quickly at the sanatorium. Joachim explains that time "doesn't really pass at all," and that there's not really "life" here.

Hans's and Joachim's opposite reactions to their meal further highlights how Joachim's familiarity with life at the Berghof has skewed his perspective. The more time he spends there, the harder it is for anything to surprise or excite him. For Hans, meanwhile, who has only just arrived, everything is new and interesting.



Joachim and Hans chat, and Joachim happily fills Hans in on the daily goings on at the Berghof. He talks about one of the residents, a woman named Frau Stöhr, who is illiterate and loves to gossip. The cousins laugh about her, but then Joachim suddenly turns serious, remembering how much time he's spent here and not knowing when he'll be allowed to leave. One can do so much with one's life "down below," but here, Joachim feels that he's wasting away.

Joachim realizes that Hans is drifting to sleep and gets up to guide him to his room. On their way there, they encounter Dr. Krokowski. Joachim introduces him to Hans. Dr. Krokowski is a friendly, energetic man. He's in his thirties and extremely pale, a trait that emphasizes his dark eyes and long black beard. Krokowski asks Hans if he's come here as a patient. Hans, detecting condescension in the doctor's tone, mumbles that he's totally healthy, has passed his exams—he's an engineer—and will only be here for a few weeks. Dr. Krokowski explains that this makes Hans quite unusual—he's never met anyone who's totally healthy. He asks again if Hans might be interested in seeking physical or psychological treatment, but Hans assures him he won't be. Joachim and Hans part ways with Krokowski and continue to Hans's room.

When Hans and Joachim reach Room 34, they find that the concierge has delivered Hans's things. After Joachim leaves, Hans lies down on the bed but feels suddenly disturbed, remembering that someone recently died there. He falls asleep and dreams nonstop, mostly about Joachim riding down the hill on a bobsled, with Dr. Krokowski steering the sled and the coughing Austrian horseman sitting at the front. Joachim repeats how coughing "doesn't matter to us—to us up here" and then he starts to cough the slimy, awful cough Hans heard earlier. Hans starts to laugh.

Joachim gets Hans up to speed on the people and social norms of the Berghof, initiating Hans's transformation from uninformed outsider to acclimated insider. Also note, however, that Joachim, despite his familiarity with the Berghof, hasn't let himself become fully at home there. Instead, he remains cognizant of the world "down below" and the life he lived there—a life he longs to return to.



Hans's inability to stay awake through supper reinforces how far outside of his comfort zone he is up here. His intense physical exhaustion indicates the stress and exertion of being in an unfamiliar place. Just as Hans's mind can't yet make sense of what life at the Berghof is all about, his body struggles to adapt to this new and challenging environment. Dr. Krokowski's appearance is rather ominous: with his pale skin and dark clothing, he cuts a rather morbid figure. Symbolically, perhaps, his appearance reflects his acclimation to the Berghof's death-saturated environment. It's curious that Krokowski asks Hans if he'll be seeking treatment here, given that Hans is merely visiting his cousin and isn't a patient himself. Krokowski's question suggests, perhaps, that the pull to seek treatment is catching, much like an infectious disease.



Hans's unease here reaffirms his present discomfort or confusion about death, especially compared to Joachim, who seems to accept death and suffering as unremarkable aspects of life—so remarkable, in fact, that they hardly deserve much thought. Hans's dream reaffirms his confused and anxious feelings about all the death and illness he's been confronted with today.



PART 2, CHAPTER 1: THE BAPTISMAL BOWL/GRANDFATHER IN HIS TWO FORMS

Hans Castorp hardly remembers his parents, who both died in a short span of time when Hans was between five and seven years old. Hans briefly lived with his grandfather, the senator, until the senator also died. Hans's grandfather's house was built on the Esplanade. Hans and his grandfather would dine together every day in one of the formal rooms downstairs.

Despite Hans's seeming discomfort with death, he's actually had considerable exposure to it, having dealt with the death of his parents as a young boy. Perhaps the shock and horror of this massive loss has in fact made him place more, not less, weight on death.



After dinner Hans's grandfather would move to the den, and sometimes Hans would join him in the dimly lit room, occasionally asking to see "the baptismal bowl." His grandfather would open the china cabinet, which was full of old antiques, and remove a tarnished silver bowl. On the bowl's underside were a list of names of the bowl's changing owners. Now, there are seven names. Hans's grandfather would list off the names to Hans, which included his father, and his father's father, and so on. Hans would listen, engrossed in the sound of his grandfather's voice—"that somber sound of the crypt and buried time" and think of religiosity, death, and history. Hans's grandfather would promise Hans that the bowl would be his in eight years, since the infant Hans was held over it when he was baptized, just as Hans's father and grandfather had been before him.

Hans's grandfather was a devout Christian. He held rigid, traditional beliefs and was suspicious of new ideas, despite coming of age in a time of great change and rebellion. He believed that children (and grandchildren) ought to obey and admire their elders and learn from them. He was a tall, gaunt man who was always impeccably dressed. Hans's grandfather's one vice was a penchant for snuff, though even this was "harmless" and simply suggested the "carelessness that age either consciously and merrily permits itself or brings with it."

A life-size portrait of Hans's grandfather hung above the sofa in the parlor, depicting Hans's grandfather as a town councillor, wearing his official uniform. A respected artist had painted it in the style of the late Middle Ages. Though Hans had only seen his grandfather dressed this way once, in a town parade, he nonetheless regarded the image as his "authentic and real grandfather." Compared to that image, the "lapses and eccentricities in his everyday appearance were apparently mere imperfections."

After his grandfather had died and it was time to say goodbye for the last time, seven-year-old Hans gazed into his grandfather's coffin and was happy to see that his grandfather was dressed in his uniform. He hadn't seen his grandfather in the late stages of his battle with pneumonia—he had been taken away and spared the sight of his suffering, of the doctors' comings and goings, and of Fiete's eyes, red from crying. Though Hans, too, cried for his grandfather, he accepted the situation because his parents' passings made him accustomed to death.

Hans's fascination with the "baptismal bowl" indicates his early fascination with ritual and tradition. He wants to find meaning in symbolic objects and practices. This is, perhaps, similar to the serious attitude toward death he demonstrates later in life: he wants to find some deeper meaning and significance in it, and this attitude makes it difficult for him to understand the nonchalance with which Joachim disregards death and dying.



This description of Hans's grandfather gives readers insight into the type of values that were instilled in Hans as a young child: he was brought up to respect tradition and conventional Christian understandings of morality. This, combined with Hans's grandfather's seeming distaste for most vices, establishes Hans's childhood as quite different from the passive, lazy atmosphere he will encounter at the Berghof years later.



Hans's high regard for the portrait of his grandfather indicates his respect for order and formality. That he considers this uniformed, official version of his grandfather to be "authentic and real," meanwhile, reflects his youthful idealism: he views perfection as superior and something to strive for and views the "lapses and eccentricities" that characterize daily life as inferior and flawed.



Despite enduring the deaths of numerous close family members, Hans has had minimal direct exposure to the experience of dying—his elders have hidden it from him, perhaps believing that confronting death in such a direct, blunt way would be too upsetting for such a young child. Thus, although Hans understands and accepts death as an abstract concept, he hasn't quite experienced what it's like to watch someone suffer and then die.



Looking at his grandfather's corpse, Hans observed that death was both spiritually and emotionally "gripping," as well as "something very material, physical." The religious side came through in the flower arrangements and the cross someone had placed in his grandfather's hands. And the material side—the side the flowers were meant to conceal—came through in the uncanny, waxen appearance of his grandfather's body. Hans observed that it was a thing in the coffin rather than a person. This aspect of death "is neither beautiful nor sad, but almost indecent in its base physicality." Just then, a buzzing fly landed on the body's forehead. Hans detected the faint scent of decay, likening it to the foul body odor of a friendless boy at school.

The disgust with which Hans regards his grandfather's decaying corpse—he finds it "almost indecent in its base physicality"—hints at Hans's (perhaps unconscious) refusal to accept death's inevitability. He finds the corpse "indecent" because it forces him to confront the disturbing yet inevitable fact that his grandfather—and all mortal beings—cannot overcome the limitations of the physical body. Ultimately, all life leads to death and decay, and this is a heavy and troubling fact for anybody—not least of all a young boy—to accept.



PART 2, CHAPTER 2: AT THE TIENAPPELS'/HANS CASTORP'S MORAL STATE

After the death of his grandfather, young Hans moves in with Consul Tienappel, his late mother's uncle and the executor for the Castorp estate. Tienappel provided Hans everything he needed and looked after his financial interests, liquidating the Castorp family firm and managing the investment of Hans's inheritance. The Tienappel house has a garden out front that is impeccably neat. The Consul has two sons, Peter and James. Peter is in the navy and rarely home, meanwhile James works for the family wine business. A servant who has worked for the family for years, Schalleen, prepares elaborate meals for the household and acts as Hans's mother.

The purpose of this section of the novel is to describe Hans's early years. This gives readers a better sense of the person Hans is when he arrives at the Berghof and begins his educational journey toward maturity. Here, readers learn that despite the tragedy that has characterized Hans's earliest years, he has enjoyed a cozy, bourgeois upbringing thanks to his affluent relatives.



All things considered, Hans grows up relatively happy, though perhaps initially a bit anemic, and so Dr. Heidekind prescribes him a glass of porter to drink each day when he returns from school. Young Hans is pleased to find that the prescription has a pleasantly calming effect, and he takes to dozing and dreaming the afternoons away. To an outsider, the clean and well-dressed boy would look right at home at the Tienappel estate.

This scene is played for comedy. Dr. Heidekind has essentially suggested that Hans get tipsy and then nap all afternoon, and he presents this as legitimate medical advice. But this also gives readers insight into the habits Hans has developed as a youth—notably, he's accustomed to idleness, which will make him right at home in the Berghof years later.



Young Hans likes to live well, and he enjoys vices of rich foods, **cigars**, and glasses of port. Having enjoyed an upper-class status since birth, he accepts his wealth with dignity and has everything taken care of for him. Even when he's away at school, he sends his clothing home for Schalleen to wash and mend. After dinner, he enjoys a Russian cigarette and then a cigar. The narrator notes that their goal is to say everything there is to say about Hans and to convey that information without judgment. Hans, they insist, was neither smart nor stupid, and it's only because of his eventual fate that the narrator refrains from calling him "mediocre" outright.

Hans, this scene makes clear, has lived a soft and easy life. He's endured great losses, to be sure, but generally, he hasn't had to struggle or exert himself all that much. Indeed, he can't even be bothered to do his own laundry and has Schalleen, the Tienappels' servant, take care of it for him. The narration emphasizes Hans's easy life and "mediocre" character to show readers just how inexperienced and impressionable he is at the start of his coming-of-age journey: when he arrives at the Berghof years later, he's effectively a blank slate, ready to be educated or corrupted.



One day, the Consul reminds Hans that the Consul's sons will inherit most of his money. And while Hans does have his own inheritance, the interest he's gained won't be enough for Hans to keep up the lifestyle he's grown accustomed to. So, Hans sets to work finding a career—ideally one that would let him prove his worth, both to himself and to others. He chooses that career after old Wilms, of the firm Tunder and Wilms, comes by to play whist with Tienappel one evening and suggests that Hans study shipbuilding and then come to work for his firm. Hans does so, and he finds his chosen course of study rewarding and well-suited to his calm disposition. He looks down on Joachim Ziemssen for becoming an officer, a job that demanded little intellectual rigor. Hans values hard work, though he “tire[s] easily.”

Here Hans encounters what is perhaps the first disruption to his easy, effortless existence: the Consul informs him that he'll have to get a real job if he wants to continue living the comfortable life he's grown accustomed to. But even this doesn't add all that much conflict to Hans's easy life: things simply fall into place for him when an acquaintance of his great-uncle's offers him a promising opportunity. This scene also establishes Joachim as a foil for Hans: while Hans likes the easy life and “tire[s] easily,” Joachim seems to value hard work and honor. That Hans, whom the narrator has emphasized is not particularly smart himself, should look down on Joachim for not choosing a job that demands intellectual rigor, paints Hans in a rather negative light—at least Joachim is doing something useful with his life. Hans has yet to begin his career in earnest.



When Hans comes home on vacation from school, people wonder which political party he'll side with. He comes from an old, renowned family name, so it seems inevitable that he'll hold some public office. It seems likely that he'd become a conservative like his grandfather. But Hans is an engineer—an embracer of modern technology—and so it's just as likely that he'd become a radical.

Again, the narration portrays Hans as an inexperienced and impressionable blank slate. He hasn't yet established which values and principles—political or otherwise—will guide his actions and influence his worldview.



When Hans leaves for the sanatorium in Davos Platz, he is 23 and has been studying at Danzig Polytechnic for four semesters, and he is about to join Tunder and Wilms as an unpaid engineer-in-training. But then things suddenly change. Studying for his exams exhausts Hans, and he returns home looking a bit too pale. Dr. Heidekind insists that Hans retreat to the Alps for a few weeks for “a change of air” before starting work on the docks. Consul Tienappel suggests that Hans pay his cousin Joachim a visit. This makes sense—Joachim, unlike Hans, is actually ill and has been sickly his whole life. At this point, he's been a resident of the International Sanatorium Berghof for five months and has grown dreadfully bored there. It's July when Hans leaves for the facility, and he plans to stay there just three weeks.

This passage concludes the novel's brief overview of Hans's past. Now, readers have a better sense of the kind of person Hans is. He was brought up with conventional, bourgeois values, he doesn't have much life experience, abhors hard work, and doesn't have any firmly held beliefs about the world and his place in it. And these aspects of Hans's personality mean he's especially vulnerable to others' influences.



PART 3, CHAPTER 1: THE SHADOW OF RESPECTABILITY

Back in the present, Hans wakes up early and takes his time getting ready. He laughs, remembering his ridiculous dream the night before. It's a beautiful day, and he hears music playing somewhere in the distance. Hans loves music, and he feels calm and pleasant as he listens to it now.

Hans's cheery and lighthearted disposition this morning is a far cry from the exhaustion and anxiety he felt the night before. The ease with which his mood shifts illustrates his impressionable, malleable nature.



Hans walks out onto his balcony and hears the noisy Russian couple next door, their “Giggles, gasps, grappings.” It’s clear the couple is having sex, but naïve—or perhaps willfully ignorant—Hans thinks perhaps that there’s some innocent explanation for the noises. A darkness washes over Hans’s face as he wills himself not to understand what he knows he’s hearing.

Not only does Hans come across as pitifully naïve in this scene, but he also reveals himself to be rather unyielding and judgmental: he believes there is something obscene or inconsiderate about his neighbors’ noisy intimacy, and he judges them harshly for not behaving according to his bourgeois standards of respectability.



Disgusted, Hans returns to his room to stop hearing the noises from next door, but he’s dismayed to find that they’re even louder indoors. Angrily, he observes the cheaply constructed, too-thin walls of his room. Hans has no good feelings toward the Russian couple and grunts something rude about them under his breath. By the time Joachim arrives to fetch Hans for supper, Hans looks woefully underslept.

The noisy Russian couple’s loud intimacy is further evidence that the Berghof exists apart from the rest of the world: in polite society, it would be rude to wake up one’s neighbors in this way, but at the Berghof, this particular social norm (and perhaps others, too) don’t seem to matter all that much.



PART 3, CHAPTER 2: BREAKFAST

Joachim greets Hans and asks how he slept. Hans grumbles about his strange dreams and about all the noise the Russian couple has been making. He asks about an older woman dressed in black (Tous-les-deux) whom he’d seen walking in the garden that morning. Joachim says she’s Mexican and doesn’t speak German. She’s visiting her son, who will almost certainly not recover and will likely be dead soon enough. And since then, her other son, who had only come to visit, has gotten deathly ill, too. As Hans thinks about this, his eyes turn red and puffy, as though he’s been crying—just as they did yesterday when he heard the man’s horrible cough.

Hans’s eyes become red and puffy as though in direct response to Joachim’s remark about the old woman’s gravely ill sons. Meanwhile, Joachim talks about the woman’s situation frankly and casually. This contrast reinforces Hans’s unease at death, illness, and suffering at this early point in the story. Meanwhile, Joachim’s casual attitude suggests that being surrounded by the sick and dying for several months now has taught him to accept death and illness as inevitable and unremarkable parts of life.



As Joachim and Hans walk to breakfast, Joachim tells Hans about the sanatorium’s various residents. Hans refuses to meet the noisy Russian couple, whom he despises. Joachim says this is fine—they’re barbarians and sit at the “Bad Russian” table. There’s also a “Good Russian” table, where the more civilized Russian residents sit, but it’s unlikely Hans will meet any of those Russians, either.

Joachim’s critique of the sanatorium’s Russian residents—even the “Good” Russians, he implies, aren’t worthy of Hans’s civilized, German company—sets up the novel’s critical (and oversimplified) stance toward Russia and so-called “Eastern” sensibilities.



In the dining hall, Hans and Joachim sit down at one of seven long tables, and Hans is pleased to see how elaborate breakfast is. One of the workers asks him what he’d like to drink, and Hans realizes that she’s a dwarf. This shocks him, but Joachim is totally unfazed. As Hans eats, he observes Joachim and the other residents, “companions in misfortune,” all eating and chatting happily together. He also observes the hall’s décor, which is sleek and modern but also with “a dash of fantasy” to it.

The abundant breakfast at the dining hall hints at the decadence and ease of life at the Berghof. Here, it seems, meals are a source of pleasure rather than sustenance. The almost comical abundance of food and the exaggerated cheer of the Berghof’s residents as they eat it indicate the novel’s critical stance toward such decadence. Meanwhile, the “dash of fantasy” in the Berghof’s décor reinforces the idea of the sanatorium as a place that exists outside of ordinary, bourgeois society.



Frau Stöhr sits at their table. Trying to appear “refined” as she talks, she raises her upper lip to reveal long, “rabbitlike” teeth. A man sitting next to her has a disgusted look on his face and says nothing. He doesn’t try to get acquainted with Hans, and Hans speculates that perhaps he’s too sick to see the point in making any new acquaintances. Joachim chats politely with Frau Stöhr, who complains to him of her health, noting her high temperature that morning. Hans joins in on the dull conversation. Inwardly, he considers how normal the dining hall feels—he’d worried it would be depressing being around sick people, but it feels perfectly ordinary.

On their way out of the dining hall, Hans and Joachim run into Director Behrens and Dr. Krokowski. Behrens, a tall, very thin man, introduces himself to Hans. He has purple cheeks that stand out against his white surgical clothing. Krokowski is also dressed in his professional clothing and behaves exactly as one would expect an assistant to behave, never speaking but making silent, knowing glances. Behrens notes that Hans—unlike Joachim whose military background has made him bad at being sick—will make a great patient. Hans, Behrens insists, is “civilian” and “comfortable.”

Behrens notes Hans’s pale complexion and declares that he’s anemic. He suggests that Hans should work on improving his coloring if he wants to do well with lady residents. Then, he gives Hans some advice: “to live for a while as if it were a slight *tuberculosis pulmonum*,” increasing the protein in his blood. Then he turns to Joachim, reminding him to stick the “**mercury cigar**” in his mouth and record the results for his checkup on Saturday.

The character of Frau Stöhr exists in part for comic relief, but she also functions as evidence of the ordinariness of illness and death—if someone as simple as Frau Stöhr can be ill and suffer, then clearly illness and suffering aren’t experiences that transform or enlighten a person. Hans gestures toward this notion when he reflects on how ordinary it feels to be around sick people—their sickness isn’t teaching him anything about life or death or inspiring him to be grateful for his own good health, for instance.



When Behrens notes that being a “civilian” will make Hans a great patient, he suggests a link between illness and passivity—civilians, unlike soldiers, have no duty to serve. Soldiers like Joachim, on the other hand, make bad patients because their military training instills in them a sense of duty that makes them prone to action.



In this scene, Behrens encourages Hans to live as though he were a sick resident during his stay at the Berghof, implying that Hans should rest well and not overextend himself during his stay. Meanwhile, when he tells Joachim to stick the “mercury cigar” in his mouth, he’s reminding Joachim to take his temperature, comically referring to a thermometer as a “mercury cigar.” This symbolism will take on more meaning later on.



PART 3, CHAPTER 3: TEASING/VIATICUM/INTERRUPTED MOMENT

As Hans and Joachim walk, Hans observes what a nice man Behrens is, noting the cleverness of his calling a **thermometer** a “mercury cigar.” And that reminds Hans—he’d like to go smoke a real one now. Hans assumes that Joachim still isn’t smoking, and he can’t understand how anyone could not smoke—he certainly couldn’t go a single day without tobacco. Joachim thinks this is a “a sign of a rather weak will,” and that’s what Behrens was suggesting when he called Hans a civilian, though Behrens didn’t necessarily mean it in a bad way.

That Hans smokes cigars, an activity he considers one of life’s pleasures, while Joachim abstains reinforces the cousins’ opposite personalities: while Hans is self-indulgent and laid back, Joachim is upright and principled. Joachim astutely points this out when he claims that Behrens, in calling Hans a “civilian,” was pointing to Hans’s “weak will.” This scene further establishes the symbolism of illness in the book. While genuine medical conditions like tuberculosis have nothing to do with a person’s temperament—one can’t choose whether they get sick—the book gradually establishes a symbolic link between illness and passivity.



Hans and Joachim start to climb a hill, but the task becomes too taxing for Joachim, so he tells Hans to go on ahead. Hans does so and encounters a group of men and women. A young girl with messy hair and half-closed eyes (Hermine Kleefeld) walks toward Hans and whistles as she passes by—but the whistle comes from her chest, not her lips. Hans is shocked, and when he sees that she's laughing, he realizes she was playing a prank on him.

Hans asks Joachim, who has caught up to him by this point, about the girl. Joachim calmly explains that the girl, Hermine Kleefeld, uses her “pneumothorax” to whistle. He explains that pneumothorax is a surgery Behrens performs, wherein nitrogen gas is put into the body through a small incision in order to give a sick lung time to rest. People who have had the surgery tend to bond over their mutual experience, and some of the patients here have formed a group, the “Half-Lung Club.” Hermine Kleefeld is an important member of the club due to her special whistling talent.

Hans finds the notion of a “Half-Lung Club” hilarious and starts to laugh. He doesn't understand how seriously ill people can be so cheerful. Joachim pauses a moment and then suggests that perhaps being sick and dying aren't such a big deal—after all, they're all just doing nothing up here. Perhaps things are only serious in the outside world, “down below in real life.” Joachim thinks Hans will see what he means once he's been at the sanatorium awhile, and Hans agrees.

Hans suddenly shifts his focus to his **cigar**, noting how awful it tastes. He can't figure out why this might be—is it because he slept badly last night? He also notes his hot, flushed face. Joachim says he felt the same way when he first arrived and that it's difficult to adjust to life up here, at first.

Hans and Joachim find a bench nearby and sit down. Hans asks Joachim if there have been many deaths since Joachim first arrived. Joachim says yes, though the staff deal with them in secret so nobody really hears about them. Hans observes that there's a lot going on behind the scenes, and Joachim agrees.

It's not yet clear how the girl has managed to whistle from her chest, but the strange talent is plausibly a side effect of the girl's medical condition. This silly encounter further establishes Berghof residents' casual, unserious attitude toward illness.



Pneumothorax was a legitimate method of treating tuberculosis. That residents who've had the procedure bond over their mutual experience suggests that contrary to Joachim's and other residents' casual attitudes toward death and illness, there is something transformative or at least meaningful about the experience of being ill: sick people, the Half-Lung Club suggests, have a perspective that healthy people lack.



Hans's laughter suggests (or perhaps attempts to conceal) his discomfort at the Half-Lung Club. Joachim, meanwhile, feels differently. To him, the Berghof is really quite unremarkable—death and illness are unavoidable parts of life, after all. Instead, it's the goings on “down below in real life”—meaning the political unrest across Europe, or perhaps simply the normal types of problems that people in ordinary society tend to suppress—that Hans should be concerned about.



The horrible taste of Hans's cigar symbolizes the growing hold the Berghof has on Hans. Cigars are a material good of the ordinary world, and Hans gradually loses the ability to enjoy them the longer he spends at the Berghof. It's as though the mountainous (and perhaps magical) setting of the Berghof has cast a spell on him.



It's curious that the staff deal with deaths behind the scenes—perhaps they don't want dying patients to have to confront the very real threat of death any more than they have to.



Joachim recalls a time he happened to witness something the staff had tried to hide from the other residents. He'd overslept and was in his room later than all the other residents when Barbara Hujus, a young Catholic girl, was brought the viaticum—the Catholic ritual for the dying. She'd been a lively teenager when Joachim first arrived, but her condition took a sudden turn for the worse, and her condition deteriorated rapidly. That day, Joachim was walking down the hall when he saw an altar boy and a priest enter Barbara's room, carrying a cross and the viaticum.

Just then, Joachim heard a ghastly scream, full of “misery and terror and defiance [...] and such ghastly pleading.” It was Barbara, who had crawled under her blanket as soon as she saw the priest, desperately refusing to receive the sacrament for the dying, kicking with all her might. Hans is confused. If she was strong enough to resist so fiercely, then why was she given the sacrament for the dying? Joachim explains that she was weak, and it was only her fear that had given her this momentary strength. Many people react this way, he explains, and Behrens knows how to respond to calm them. He simply and frankly tells them not to “make such a fuss.”

Hans is aghast—surely a dying person deserves more respect than this. Joachim agrees, but he thinks it's ultimately disruptive for people to cause a commotion “in such a weak-willed way.” But Hans fiercely rejects this, insisting that the dying deserve “nobler” treatment than what Behrens is giving them. Suddenly, the men see a man (later revealed to be Settembrini) walking toward them, and Joachim urges Hans to be quiet. The man, who has a “delicate” build, a moustache, and is dressed in checked trousers, approaches and greets them.

Despite the staff's attempts to prevent residents from seeing the dead, Joachim's gruesome story about witnessing the priest and altar boy visit Barbara Hujus's room indicates that it's impossible for residents to avoid the reality of death altogether, given the prevalence of serious or sudden illness in a sanatorium.



Joachim's story reveals that, despite residents' outwardly casual attitude toward death, a fear of one's own mortality (especially when it's imminent, as in Barbara's case) is engrained in all humans. Behrens's advice to dying patients not to “make such a fuss” might seem cold and detached, but perhaps it's also helpful: death comes to the dying (a group to which all humans, even those who are presently young and healthy, belong) regardless of how they respond to it, and so isn't it better to accept rather than resist one's fate?



Hans's shocked response to Behrens's suggestion that the dying not “make such a fuss” reinforces his present attitude toward death and illness: he believes they are somehow “nobler” experiences that demand and deserve respect. Joachim, on the other hand, finds it “weak-willed” or even self-indulgent to make such a big deal about death.



PART 3, CHAPTER 4: SATANA

It's difficult for Hans to tell how old the man is, but he seems to be in his thirties or forties. His clothes are loose and threadbare, but he has a “refined” expression on his face that lets Hans know he's a gentleman. Joachim introduces the man as Herr Settembrini. The Italian man insists that the cousins sit back down and continues to lean against his cane. Recalling Hans's earlier laughter, Settembrini asks, rather accusingly, if Hans's journey went well and how his treatment is going. Hans is surprised to hear that the man doesn't speak with an accent—it's hard to tell that he's a foreigner. He corrects Settembrini that he's not a patient—in fact he's perfectly healthy.

One way to read The Magic Mountain is as an allegory for Europe in the years leading up to World War I. In such a reading, Settembrini's lack of an (Italian) accent might symbolize his neutrality, suggesting that his allegiance is with the greater good of (western) Europe as a whole and with the triumph of Western ideals in general rather than with nationalist, Italian ideals. Settembrini's assumption that Hans is a patient could reveal something about how Hans appears to others, suggesting that he appears outwardly weak and passive.



Settembrini mockingly calls Hans “Odysseus” and commends his bravery for “descend[ing] into the depths” and being among the sick. When Hans explains that he’ll only be there for three weeks, Settembrini scoffs—weeks aren’t a unit of measurement people use here. Joachim explains that Settembrini is a literary man—he wrote the obituary for the poet Carducci and even had the pleasure of knowing him personally. Settembrini, upon learning that Hans is a shipbuilder, declares him a model for “a whole world of labor and practical genius.”

Settembrini goes off on a philosophical, humanist tangent in praise of Hans’s work, but it goes over Hans’s head. Hans apologizes for his slowness, explaining that he didn’t sleep well and has been out of sorts. He mentions his **cigar** tasting horrible. Settembrini calls Hans’s smoking habit a “vice,” explaining that it’s important to call things what they are. Settembrini rambles on about abstract ideas and theories. Eventually Joachim interjects, explaining that they must go to return to their “rest cure.” Settembrini says that he’s actually headed in the same direction, though, and so he joins Hans and Joachim on their walk home. He recites verses in Latin along the way, pausing only to ogle a young girl who crosses their path. Inwardly, Hans calls him a “windbag.”

Settembrini changes the subject to rail against Director Behrens, ridiculing him for his large feet, his “summer cure”—an idea he claims to have invented—and his general idiocy. Hans enjoys Settembrini’s insults and gossip, and he praises him for his clever turns of phrase and general intelligence. Just then, Settembrini turns and spots Krokowski and Behrens behind them. Out of earshot, Settembrini mocks Krokowski’s self-assuredness and characteristic black clothing. He asks Hans what he thinks of the doctor, and Hans replies that he really hasn’t spoken with Krokowski all that much. Settembrini encourages him to form opinions quickly—it’s only natural.

Settembrini rambles all the way back to the sanatorium. After finally parting ways with him, Hans asks Joachim if Settembrini has much money. Joachim thinks probably not, but he at least has enough to stay at the sanatorium. He also explains that Settembrini comes from a long line of literary types.

Settembrini’s description of Hans’s journey as a descent is ironic—Hans literally ascended the mountains to get to the Berghof. Settembrini’s clever remark gives readers (and Hans) a sense of his attitude toward the sanatorium and toward illness and suffering in general: there’s nothing noble about the situation. It’s comparable to hell, and being here won’t be enough on its own to inspire or educate Hans.



Settembrini’s praise of Hans’s engineering work points to his humanist values, which is one of his character’s defining features. Humanism is a philosophical movement that came out of the Renaissance movement. A humanist values human progress and social potential over supernatural or divine forces like religion. That Settembrini’s praise for Hans’s work goes over Hans’s head ultimately emphasizes Hans’s youth and inexperience.



It’s unclear why Settembrini harbors such disdain for Behrens and Krokowski. As medical doctors, they’re technically in the business of improving and sustaining human life, which the humanist Settembrini should approve of. His mocking of Krokowski’s black clothing and air of self-assurance perhaps suggests that Settembrini despises the doctor(s) for their self-importance. As doctors, they effectively act as gatekeepers between life and death, and they become gods in a sense. Settembrini, with his humanist respect for democracy and human progress, would resent such a hierarchy—to him, it’s no different than religious authorities using the threat of damnation to subdue the masses.



Settembrini’s apparent lack of wealth—or, at least, his disinterest in outward displays of wealth—reveal more about his character. He seems to have little patience for decadence or self-indulgence, a trait that puts him at odds with the atmosphere of the Berghof, with its emphasis on rest and relaxation and its sumptuous meals.



PART 3, CHAPTER 5: CLARITY OF MIND

Hans and Joachim arrive at Joachim's room. There, Joachim removes a **thermometer** from a leather case and takes his temperature. The process takes seven minutes, which seems like forever. Joachim notes that once you start paying attention to time, it "actually" seems to go so slowly. Hans says that "actually" is irrelevant—if it *seems* to take a long time, then it *is* a long time. Joachim argues that the world measures time objectively, with clocks and calendars. Hans continues to philosophize, countering that time must pass evenly in order to be measurable, and there's no proof that this is the case. Instead, "all our measurements are merely conventions," he argues. Joachim grumbles that his rising temperature must be "convention" too, then, since it got to over 100 degrees last night.

Hans tells Joachim he'll leave him be now—his head is spinning with ideas about time, and he doesn't want to stress Joachim out over them. He tells Joachim he'll see him at second breakfast, and with that, he heads to his own room for his "rest cure."

In his room, Hans is amazed at how great it feels just to lie down. He sleeps for an hour, and then he and Joachim head down to breakfast. In the dining hall, Hans eats another hearty meal. He observes the other patients at his table and spots a young Russian woman, whose name, he overhears, is Marusya. Hans notes that Joachim won't make eye contact with her and looks angry every time she speaks. Hans also spots members of the Half-Lung Club across the room, including Hermine Kleefeld.

Joachim quietly points out a man wearing a leather jacket and a woman wearing a feathered hat and old feather boa sitting at the "Bad Russian" table and says they're Hans's neighbors. Hans stares at them coldly, something he'd usually never do, and is shocked at how good it makes him feel. Hans realizes that his breakfast beer—which normally would have only made him feel a bit relaxed—has completely incapacitated him. And he also realizes he'd like more than anything to be back in his room, lying down. As Hans and Joachim leave the dining hall to take a walk, Hans asks Joachim when the next rest cure is and if they're going to walk very far.

This returns to one of the book's core themes: the malleable, subjective experience of time. Here, Joachim and Hans debate whether one's subjective experience of time affects the reality of time itself. While Joachim believes that time is objective and unchanging (seven minutes is seven minutes, regardless of whether that amount of time "feels" fast or slow), Hans believes that time changes with a person's subjective experience of it. The concept of time, in other words, has nothing to do with literal minutes or seconds (which are arbitrary measurements humans have invented to organize time's passing) and everything to do with how one experiences it. The rather superficial and self-indulgent nature of Hans's philosophizing reinforces his youthful naivety and his self-absorption.



Hans lets his passing fancies, however ill-formed or inconsequential they may be, take hold of his life. He doesn't share Joachim's disciplined, pragmatic approach to life.



Hans's "rest cure" is particularly self-indulgent because it serves no immediate medical purpose: he's resting out of idleness, not to recover from an illness like Joachim. Meanwhile, Joachim's apparent disdain for Marusya, though unexplained at this point, will become important later on. At any rate, his anger suggests that he isn't completely pragmatic and honorable and is just as vulnerable to human emotion as anyone else.



Hans's uncharacteristic rudeness suggests that the "magic" of the Berghof is already working on him: far removed from bourgeois society, he acts on his irrational whims and emotions, even if doing so would be unacceptable under normal circumstances. His desire to be back in his room is further evidence of the figurative "spell" the Berghof is casting on him: it's almost as though the malaise of the sanatorium's residents is more infectious than their physical illnesses. Of course, Hans's exhaustion could also have a simpler explanation: he could literally be getting sick.



PART 3, CHAPTER 6: ONE WORD TOO MANY

Joachim promises Hans that they're only going to take a short walk, through Davos-Dorf, like Joachim normally does. It's fun to people-watch, and they'll have two more rest cures later that day. Eventually they reach Davos-Dorf, which can hardly be considered a town any longer—the resort has completely taken over, with the streets full of hotels and rest-cure arcades. In Davos-Dorf, Hans tries to smoke another **cigar**. This one manages to taste a bit better than the last, but it's still far less enjoyable than it usually is.

Hans complains about Behrens demanding that Hans take his own temperature—surely he must have been joking. Hans doesn't even own a **thermometer**. Joachim shrugs and tells Hans it would be no deal to buy one—they can find one in a shop in town right now. Hans is skeptical—the rest cure is one thing, but taking his temperature seems like a bit much for someone who's merely visiting the resort. Suddenly, Hans clasps his chest and comments on his heart, which has been pounding practically the entire time he's been at the resort. He describes the sensation as akin to his body becoming detached from his soul, and it disturbs him.

As they walk, Joachim asks Hans what he thinks of the other residents. Hans complains about “little Mazurka” (mispronouncing “Marusya”) and her incessant giggling. Joachim laughs, agreeing that she's “too enthusiastic,” which is especially odd since she's quite ill. Just then, Hans notices that Joachim's face looks blotchy and drained of blood. He quickly changes the subject, talking about other residents instead. He learns that the woman he thought was a seamstress is actually a teacher, and her name is Fräulein Engelhart. Leo Blumenkohl, Joachim explains—the man with the perpetually-disgusted expression—is the sickest patient. He's been there for years.

Hans and Joachim approach a spa hotel and see a group of young men and women playing tennis. Joachim explains that he's not allowed to play, as he's supposed to always be resting. He explains that Settembrini jokingly calls the sickly residents “the horizontals.” Of course, people still play “forbidden games” at the sanatorium, like poker. But Hans is hardly listening at this point because he's too exhausted and disoriented. He and Joachim continue the rest of their journey in silence.

The touristy appearance of Davos-Dorf further indicates that there's an infectiousness to the Berghof's atmosphere of malaise and decadence. Just as Hans starts to sleep more and struggles to enjoy smoking his cigars (an activity he and the book associate with the ordinary world down below), the town of Davos-Dorf surrenders to the influx of hotels and rest-cure arcades that have popped up to cater to residents of the local sanatoriums and their visitors.



Hans's complaint about Behrens reflects his reluctance to fully give in to the allure of death, abandon, and decadence the Berghof represents. While it's clear that Hans has an innate tendency toward passivity and self-indulgent behavior, he also seems to recognize that such drives impede his ability to live a good, meaningful life—the type of life his bourgeois upbringing has trained him to strive for. His refusal to take his temperature, then, is a symbolic attempt to fight against certain aspects of his personality—his passivity and his self-indulgence—that he recognizes as harmful. But Hans's declining physical health (his pounding heart, for example) suggests that he won't be able to fight off these harmful impulses indefinitely.



The physical symptoms Joachim exhibits in response to Hans's mention of Marusya parallel the physical ailments Hans has developed since arriving at the Berghof. Both cases establish physical symptoms as observable manifestations of inner thoughts or states of being. Hans's pounding heart reflects his efforts to resist giving in to passivity and self-indulgence. Joachim's blotchy, pale face seems to reflect his efforts to resist giving in to his irrational feelings for Marusya.



Settembrini's description of the sickly residents as “horizontal” comically mocks their sedentary lifestyle—as part of their treatment, they're required to lie horizontally in bed. Hans's exhaustion further hints that he's getting sick. Symbolically, it suggests his struggle to resist the enticing pull of the Berghof and the decadent lifestyle it promises.



PART 3, CHAPTER 7: BUT OF COURSE—A FEMALE!

After taking a rest, Hans and Joachim head down for dinner, though Hans is still quite tired. He looks around and sees all the usual residents going about their business as usual. Frau Stöhr rambles on about her checkup that morning, explaining that Behrens informed her she'd have to stay there five more months. Dinner that night is elaborate and consists of six courses. Everyone fills their plates and eats ravenously, which somewhat disgusts Hans.

Two things happen during that meal that catch Hans's attention. First, someone slams the door shut again. This time, he's determined to catch the culprit, so he turns around quickly and sees that it's a young woman of average height and build. She goes to sit at the Good Russian table. Hans observes her hands as she arranges her hair. Hers aren't especially feminine—in fact, they are wide, and her fingers are short and stubby. Hans finds something “childish” about her hands. Fräulein Englehart sees who Hans is looking at and explains that the young woman's name is Madame Chauchat—a “charming lady,” she says, sarcastically. She might have a husband, but he's never been to the sanatorium and is a total mystery to everyone.

The second incident to catch Hans's attention is that Dr. Blumenkohl leaves the room, looking disgusted as usual. After he leaves, Frau Stöhr notes that he's very near death. Dinner wraps up in under an hour, and Hans finds himself back in his room, reclining in his comfortable lounge chair on his balcony, taking his rest cure between dinner and teatime. His heart continues to beat heavily as he naps. When he uses his handkerchief later, he sees that he's coughed up a bit of blood. He smokes another **Maria Mancini** despite it still not tasting very good.

Thus far, most of Hans's time at the Berghof has involved eating or sleeping. This reinforces the sanatorium's passive, decadent atmosphere. Hans's disgust at the residents' voracious appetites indicates that at this point in the story, he's still actively resisting the drive to give in to the temptations of indulgence and excess.



Madame Chauchat's poor manners and her place at one of the Russian tables establish her as a corrupting force. Her “childish” hands suggest an unrefined, unintellectual demeanor. Meanwhile her poor manners—her bad posture and her habit of slamming doors shut behind her—reflect the threat that the Eastern ideals she represents pose to human progress and Western social order.



Frau Stöhr's remark about Dr. Blumenkohl being very near death seems to be made more in passing than out of genuine concern for the man, further underscoring the frank, casual attitude toward death that many of the Berghof's residents share. Hans's ill-tasting Maria Mancini and his pounding heart reflect his inner struggle to resist the Berghof's pull. At this point, he wants to return to his life in ordinary society and live a productive existence there, yet it's becoming harder for him to honor those obligations when the Berghof's decadence continues to tempt him.



PART 3, CHAPTER 8: HERR ALBIN

Later, in the garden, Hans listens as two shrieking women plead with Herr Albin to put away his knife. Herr Albin continues smoking his cigarette and refuses to grant their request. He antagonizes them, suggesting that he go to his room and fetch his revolver, too, laughing as he lumbers off toward his room. He returns shortly after with the gun, explaining that he has it so that he can kill himself when things get too “boring” around this place. He puts the gun to his temple to demonstrate and his audience continues to plead with him to stop. He argues that they should excuse his behavior because he's suffering an “incurable” disease, and so nothing he does should matter anymore.

Herr Albin's argument that the “incurable” nature of his condition gives him license to behave as poorly as he likes is a game-changer for Hans. It alerts him to a benefit of existing in the odd, removed atmosphere of the Berghof—a benefit he hadn't yet considered. Here, he can act as self-indulgently as he pleases, with no regard for others or the broader project of human progress.



Hans, listening to this scene unfold, wonders whether Herr Albin is serious or joking. Regardless, he feels a little envious of the man's attitude. He considers how "disgrace" has as much merit and benefits as "honor" and wonders what life would be like if he were freed from the expectation to be honorable.

This scene marks a major shift in Hans's personal philosophy of life. He starts to see the bourgeois sensibilities of his ordinary life, with their emphasis on honor and respectability, as repressive and harmful. Meanwhile, the shameful, self-indulgent behavior he's been taught to disdain might just be the key to a liberated, full life.



PART 3, CHAPTER 9: SATANA MAKES SHAMEFUL SUGGESTIONS

Hans eventually drifts off, waking up a little past 3:00 p.m. Joachim drops by his room, and the two of them go downstairs for their afternoon snack. Hans asks if Joachim heard Herr Albin's outburst. Joachim did, and now he complains about the man's disruptiveness and how it's setting everyone back in their healing. When Hans asks if Herr Albin would really shoot himself, Joachim nods—people kill themselves quite often here. Disturbed, Hans decides he might want to leave sooner than later. Joachim thinks Hans ought to give the place a bit more time.

Hans continues to do nothing but eat and sleep. Despite his initial reservations about the place, he's getting used to and even growing to like the aimless idleness that characterizes daily life at the Berghof. Of course, Joachim's disapproval of Herr Albin suggests that a person still must choose to adopt such a lifestyle—Joachim, with his soldier's respect for honor and duty, has not allowed himself to surrender to dishonor and irresponsibility, however tempting it may be. Hans could follow Joachim's lead, but he doesn't appear to want to.



Hans and Joachim join the other residents in the dining hall for tea and snacks. Later, after another rest cure, they return for a fifth time, for supper. This meal is no less elaborate than the one that came before. Hans orders a beer but becomes too exhausted to finish it. In agony, he listens to insufferable Frau Stöhr blabber on about the many different fish sauces she can make.

Hans's inability to finish his beer—a habit he's indulged in since he was a young child—reflects the growing hold the Berghof has on him. Little by little—and perhaps without Hans even realizing it—he's losing his connection to the real world and surrendering to the alternate way of life the Berghof offers.



After supper, most of the residents gather in the lobby and split off into various "social rooms" to hang out before bed. In one room, Hans spots a group gathered around Madame Chauchat. Seeing the rude woman fills Hans with disgust. Settembrini approaches Hans and asks how he's feeling and how he spent his first day at the sanatorium. Hans tells him his day was like that of a typical resident, spent "in the 'horizontal fashion,'" to use Settembrini's term. He says he found the experience distracting but boring at the same time. He also describes the odd sensation he's had of having "grown older and wiser" over the one day he's been here.

The narration's emphasis on Hans's disgust at Madame Chauchat hints that she will figure as an important character in his story in one way or another. Meanwhile, Hans's observation that he's "grown older and wiser" is comical, given that he's only been at the Berghof one day. In a sense, he self-satirizes his coming-of-age journey. (Though, of course, one must remember, as Joachim has said from the start, that time does pass in strange ways up here.) Hans's remark also reinforces his present belief that experiencing illness and suffering can ennoble or enlighten a person.



Hans is about to excuse himself but pauses and asks Settembrini if at supper Frau Stöhr had really been bragging about all the fish sauces she can make, or if Hans imagined the exchange. Settembrini says he has no idea what Hans is talking about. He asks Hans if he'd like to leave this place first thing in the morning, since staying here obviously hasn't been good for him. Hans, alarmed, says he's only just gotten there and can't possibly know how he likes it so early on. Settembrini approves of Hans's logic—he loves good logic. And he's seen lots of people experience successful "acclimatization." He recalls one woman who grew to love it here so much that she refused to leave, even after she was fully healed, and tried to fake a fever in order to stay.

Hans and Joachim head to Joachim's room after the social hour ends. Hans watches Joachim wrap himself in blankets so he can stay warm while he lies out on the balcony during his rest cure. He marvels at Joachim's skill at swaddling himself in the blankets. Joachim says it just takes practice, and Hans will learn it too. Hans declines. He won't lie out on the balcony overnight, as that would be too close to something a resident would do. Then, feeling suddenly rather chilled, Hans bids Joachim goodnight and heads back to his own room.

Hans goes through the motions of getting ready for bed. He thought he would fall right asleep, but now he finds that his heart is pounding too loudly for him to sleep. He gets out of bed and takes a lamp outside to the balcony and lies there on his back. He thinks about Joachim's unhappy expression when he mentioned Marusya, particularly her physical features, and realizes Joachim must have a crush on her. Next door, the rude Russian couple keep Hans awake with their sexual activities. Eventually he does fall asleep, but he has dreams that are even more disturbing than the night before. In tonight's dream, Behrens approaches Hans and commands that Hans do "a few spiffing years of service with us up here."

It's unclear whether Settembrini is just messing with Hans or if Hans really did imagine Frau Stöhr's claims of fish sauce expertise. Either way, that Hans is uncertain enough to ask Settembrini shows the degree to which his mental state has declined since his arrival at the Berghof. This scene marks a pivotal moment in Hans's story. Settembrini, seeing Hans's confusion, makes it quite clear that Hans can—and perhaps should—leave the Berghof before his condition worsens. Yet Hans, seemingly against his best interest, chooses to stay at the Berghof anyway. From this point forward, Hans will repeatedly choose self-destruction over self-preservation.



Hans continues to waver between wanting to be a visitor of the Berghof and wanting to fully immerse himself in its "culture," so to speak. Though in the previous scene he claimed to Settembrini that he needed more time and experience to know whether he truly liked the sanatorium, now he actively declines an opportunity to test this notion, refusing to swaddle himself in warm blankets like a real resident. This ambiguity will become one of Hans's defining characteristics as he acquaints himself with new ideas and worldviews and yet fails to commit to or act on any one of them.



Hans's beating heart, anxious thoughts, and troubled dreams reflect his conflicted feelings about the Berghof. Though his beating heart indicates that his body is trying to resist the hold the place has on him, his dream about Behrens commanding him to do "a few spiffing years of service" indicates that Hans is on the verge of giving in to the sanatorium's allure. Hans's revelation about Joachim's crush on Marusya reveals Hans's naivety—most readers could have surmised that this was the nature of Joachim's discomfort. It also adds complexity to Joachim's character—despite his soldier's respect for duty and pragmatism, he, too, is vulnerable to irrational human emotions.



Then the dream moves on, and Hans is in a schoolyard. He's about to ask Madame Chauchat to borrow a pencil when he realizes who she reminds him of. He wakes up, determined to remember this revelation in the morning. Then he drifts back to sleep and dreams of Dr. Krokowski waiting to ambush him to "subject[] his psyche to dissection." Hans, terrified, flees from the doctor. He wakes up in a cold sweat. In his final dream, he tries to knock over Settembrini but finds he cannot. At that point, Hans has a breakthrough about the meaning of time: it's just "a silent sister, a column of **mercury** without a scale, for the purpose of keeping people from cheating." He vows to pass along this knowledge to Joachim in the morning.

As the night goes on, Hans dreams some more. He has one dream twice. In it, he's sitting in the dining hall when Madame Chauchat arrives, wearing a white sweater, one hand in her pocket and the other behind her head. She holds out her palm, oddly, for Hans to kiss. He does so, noting her gross, ungroomed nails. In that moment, he feels the same pleasant sensation of being free from honor that he felt when he listened to Herr Albin earlier that day.

Hans's dream is rich with symbolism. The detail of Hans realizing he knows who Madame Chauchat reminds him of—yet falling just short of revealing to readers who that person is—builds intrigue. Meanwhile, his efforts and ultimate failure to knock over Settembrini suggests Hans's ambivalence toward this older man who seems to have appointed himself Hans's mentor: though Hans wants someone to guide him, he also resists being told what to do.



In this highly symbolic dream, Hans links Madame Chauchat's ill-mannered traits with the freedom he observed in Herr Albin's poor behavior earlier that day—and by extension, the sickness that Herr Albin claims justifies that poor behavior. Thus, this dream perhaps suggests that Hans will continue to be drawn toward the freedom that Madame Chauchat represents, even though that freedom is predicated on the inherently self-destructive forces of illness, death, and decay.



PART 4, CHAPTER 1: A NECESSARY PURCHASE

On Hans's third day at the sanatorium, the weather turns, and the sunny warmth is replaced with cold gloom. Joachim tells Hans it'll snow soon. Hans can't believe it—it's only August. But sure enough, it starts to snow only moments later and continues all through the afternoon. The snow stops by the next day, but the temperature remains freezing. Joachim and Hans walk to town to get Hans more blankets for his room. Joachim explains that up here, all the seasons sort of blend into one another—you can expect snow all year round. He suggests that Hans get himself a fur-lined sleeping bag, too, but Hans wavers, not wanting to seem like a committed resident. In town, Hans and Joachim find Hans some camel-hair blankets like the ones Joachim has and arrange for them to be delivered to Hans's room.

Historically, sanatoriums were built away from city centers, in places with weather conditions and fresh air that was thought to be good for patients' health. But symbolically, the intense cold and unpredictability of weather conditions in the Alps also underscores the Berghof as a place outside the bounds of normal society. This scene also marks a major development in Hans's character. Though before he'd been reluctant to adhere to too many of the sanatorium's customs, now he gives in and buys camel-hair blankets like the ones that permanent residents like Joachim swaddle themselves in. Gradually, and perhaps despite his better judgment, Hans acclimates to the Berghof. As he does so, he warms—literally and figuratively—to its atmosphere of death, decay, and self-destruction.



Back at the sanatorium, Hans and Joachim encounter Settembrini. The three men take a walk together, and Settembrini grouses about the irrationality of the staff shutting off the heat. Then he starts talking about his late father, who loved the warm and would keep his study at exactly 77 degrees during winters. He rattles on about his father's intellectual interests and pursuits, rocking back and forth as he speaks. Then Settembrini starts complaining about Krokowski again, and about another resident, Magnus, who thinks literature is merely "beautiful characters" and therefore useless in real life.

Suddenly Hans joins in, noting the lack of good company at the sanatorium. Thinking of Frau Stöhr, Hans muses that one tends to think of sickness making people "venerable," while stupid people are "healthy and vulgar," so it's confusing to know how to respond when someone is both. Hans becomes turned around in his thoughts and trails off, which seems to make Settembrini and Joachim embarrassed for him.

After a pause, Settembrini praises Hans for his philosophical insight—he's surprised an engineer like Hans could be so thoughtful. But then he says he disagrees with everything Hans has just said and feels obligated to set him straight. There is nothing "venerable" or "elegant" about sickness—such a view belongs to older, superstitious days when religion would consider sickness "a passport to heaven." But "reason," argues Settembrini, has proven such a view false. All that is truly honorable, argues Settembrini, is honest work. Inwardly, Hans marvels at the intellectual sermon he's provoked. He also wonders about Settembrini's seeming obsession with work.

Settembrini continues his rant. Frau Stöhr is stupid, he contends, and it's a pity that she's also quite sick. The real tragedy, though, is when the universe places an intellectual, "life-affirming mind" in a sickly body. He starts to recite, in Italian, the lyrics of a poet who was hunchbacked and sickly, Leopardi. He concludes, "A soul without a body is as inhuman and horrible as a body without a soul," noting that it's just as sad for an able-bodied person to live purely for the body—for physical delights. Joachim cuts in to say that Hans said something along these lines recently. Settembrini nods at this and declares it the teacher's duty to point promising minds like Hans's in the right direction.

This scene further establishes Settembrini's character as representative of Enlightenment ideals: he is highly rational and values literature and other intellectual pursuits. Settembrini considers himself an outlier among the Berghof's general population. To his mind, the average Berghof resident is more like Magnus, who sees literature as little more than "beautiful characters."



Hans's embarrassing philosophical rant is played for comedy, but it also reveals two key details about his character. First, that he trails off suggests that intellectual pontification is not something he normally does. Given this, then, the fact that he acts on this uncharacteristic impulse to philosophize indicates that his time at the Berghof is changing him, making him more prone to self-indulgent musings.



Settembrini asserts his humanist sensibilities in this scene when he argues that humankind realizes its full potential on earth. This position contradicts older, religion-derived views that claimed humans couldn't realize their full potential until they died and (if they'd been good and god-fearing) went to heaven, where they'd be liberated from their sinful, material bodies.



Settembrini's view, like the older religious ones he just criticized, acknowledges the limits of the human body: it is a shame when an otherwise capable person becomes sick and therefore unable to use their "life-affirming mind" to its full potential. But that's about as meaningful as sickness gets: it's a shame that it happens, but it doesn't imbue the sick person with a higher purpose or a special wisdom. It is also significant that Settembrini indirectly refers to himself as teacher and to Hans as mentor, introducing a relationship that will inform their interactions for the remainder of the novel.



Hans and Joachim part ways with Settembrini once they reach the sanatorium lobby. Once alone, Hans exclaims at how easy it is to set Settembrini off on a rant. Nonetheless, he enjoys hearing him talk. Hans thinks that's what's most important to Settembrini—not the content of his lectures, but the way his words sound. Hans hasn't met a literary man before and is struck by Settembrini's intellectualism. Joachim adds that Settembrini has quite a lot of pride, which is honorable. Finally, Hans and Joachim part ways to rest and prepare for dinner.

That Hans appreciates the performance rather than the content of Settembrini's lectures indicates his reluctance to take to heart the wisdom Settembrini is trying to impart on him. Young and naïve, Hans obstinately rejects an older and more experienced (if perhaps somewhat patronizing) mentor's efforts to set him on the right path.



PART 4, CHAPTER 2: EXCURSUS ON THE SENSE OF TIME

Hans's blankets have arrived by the time he and Joachim return from dinner. Joachim tells him how to wrap the blankets around himself the way everyone at the sanatorium does. Hans struggles with the task but eventually manages with Joachim's help. Still, he's freezing—and also burning up at the same time. As Hans sits in his room, swaddled in blankets and reclining in his almost magically comfortable lounge chair, he mentally works through the rest of the day's activities and realizes he's completely adjusted to the daily schedule here. The narration contemplates the concept of time and of boredom, noting the false ideas people have about boredom. A lot of people think that filling time with "things" will make it pass faster, but this isn't necessarily true. What people are talking about when they talk about boredom is really monotony.

That Hans can't yet swaddle himself in the blankets as adeptly as Joachim, a long-time Berghof resident, shows that he's still somewhat hesitant to fully accept the Berghof and the different way of life it presents. Nevertheless, the genuine pleasure Hans feels at being swaddled in blankets and reclining in his wonderfully comfy lounge chair suggests that the more time passes, the more acclimated Hans will become to the Berghof. The narrator's philosophical musings about time reinforce the subjective and malleable nature of time as one of the novel's core themes.



The narrator says they've included this tangent because Hans, himself, was thinking along similar lines. Later, Hans remarks to Joachim about how strange it is that time seems to pass so slowly when one is in a new place. It seems he's been at the sanatorium for ages, but in reality he's only been there several days.

The narrator's (and Hans's) emphasis on how slowly time passes when one is in a new place seems to foreshadow an impending shift: as Hans becomes more acclimated to the Berghof, it's likely that time will start to pass more rapidly.



PART 4, CHAPTER 3: HE TRIES OUT HIS CONVERSATIONAL FRENCH

Hans still has a lot to get used to at the sanatorium, even as he gradually memorizes the goings on of daily life there. One day he learns that the balloon-shaped containers he'd noticed his first day there are filled with oxygen. They're used to temporarily revitalize patients just before they die. Behrens calls the dying patients the *morbundi*. Hans runs into him one day in the hall, and Behrens expresses regret that Hans won't be staying at the Berghof through the winter. Then he heads into a room to tend to a dying patient. Hans glimpses the *moribundus* as Behrens steps into the room. It's the first dying person Hans has seen at the sanatorium, and the pale, frail figure in the bed shocks and disturbs him.

Little by little, Hans grows more accustomed to life at the Berghof, and this reflects the growing hold the place has on him. Though he initially laughed at details about the place that didn't make sense to him or made him feel uncomfortable, as when Joachim described how bobsleds are used to transport dead bodies down the mountain, now Hans actively tries to learn about how patients are treated, and he even voluntarily gazes upon a dying patient.



Hans doesn't really get to know anybody well those first few days, still feeling like a visitor and thus not seeing the point. One day, though, Joachim introduces him to a nurse who patrols their floor. She loves to talk, blabbering on about her family back home, mostly her cousins, and the tedious details of her day. The other person Hans meets is the pale, Mexican lady dressed in black, whom people call Tous-les-deux. Hans and Joachim encounter her on one of their walks one day, and she greets them with her characteristic "Tous le dé." Hans, having known that this is what she'd say, replies, "*Et je le regrette beaucoup*." At this, her eyes widen, and Hans senses her emit a "fainted, wilted odor." He feels a sudden "warmth" in himself. She says thanks and walks away.

After Tous-les-deux has gone, Hans tells Joachim he does well with people like the woman, getting along with sad people better than happy people. It doesn't make him feel uncomfortable. He goes on about how illogical it is for the local women to feel so uncomfortable and nervous about death and about how much he loves coffins. He thinks that when people need to feel more spiritual, they ought to go to a funeral rather than to church. Suddenly he pauses and asks Joachim if the French he spoke with Tous-le-deux was okay. Joachim says it was.

*Despite Hans's growing familiarity with the place, his ambivalence persists, as his reluctance to get to know any of the other residents suggests. He almost seems in denial about the fact that he's getting used to—and perhaps even a bit enchanted by—the Berghof and the alternate way of life its setting offers him. Meanwhile, his calculated effort to engage with Tous-les-deux, replying, *Et je le regrette beaucoup* ("And I regret that very much") to acknowledge her grief over her sick and dying sons, shows that he is making a calculated effort to ingratiate himself with the broader Berghof community—even as he denies that he's anything more than a visitor passing through.*



Hans's remark about getting along better with sad people than happy people reiterates his belief that suffering affects a person in significant and predictable ways, imbuing them with a higher knowledge that ordinary, happy people lack. Despite Settembrini's warning, he still wants to believe that the best way to learn about life is through a fixation on death.



PART 4, CHAPTER 4: POLITICALLY SUSPECT

Every other Sunday, there's a band concert on the terrace of the sanatorium—it's a way for residents to know that two weeks have passed. The sanatorium's staff and residents both clearly "honor" Sunday, providing an especially elaborate breakfast that day and setting the tables with flowers. Residents dress up, too. Frau Chauchat wears a lace peignoir. The band concert happens right after breakfast. Most people sit on the steps leading to the garden to listen to the performance. Among them is Hermine Kleefeld, as well as Herr Albin. Hans and Joachim sit at a table by themselves because Hans wants to smoke a **cigar**—they've been tasting better lately. The doctors, Behrens and Krokowski, attend the concert too.

The reason behind the bi-weekly Sunday band concerts adds to the novel's examination of the subjective and arbitrary nature of time. It shows that people can't innately feel or keep track of the passage of time: they need external signposts like the Sunday band concerts to tell them how many units of time (in this example, weeks) have passed. This raises the question of why society organizes time into units of measurement like hours, days, and weeks anyway. Another detail to note here is the improved taste of Hans's cigars, which seems to indicate that his system has recalibrated itself, physically and emotionally, and that he feels increasingly at home at the Berghof.



Settembrini wanders toward Hans and Joachim's table and joins them. He explains that he's only going to drop by briefly—he doesn't like being forced to do things. He decries his stolen human dignity, and leaving on his own terms gives him an illusion of independence. When Hans asks if Settembrini likes music, he goes off on one of his characteristic philosophical tangents, criticizing the "semi-articulate" and emotional nature of music. He claims to dislike music for "political" reasons but nevertheless praises its ability to move people. Joachim thinks Settembrini is being too high-minded, though: the concerts are nice because they break up the monotony of life at the sanatorium, filling the hours and days with something different.

Settembrini's critique of the lack of genuine independence that life at the sanatorium offers residents underscores the value he places on personal liberty, and his attack on the "semi-articulate" emotional nature of music gestures toward the value he places on rationality—both of which reinforce his Enlightenment ideals. Joachim's response that the concerts are good because they fulfill a real purpose (breaking up the monotony of life at the Berghof) emphasizes his character's pragmatism. Though perhaps not as deep or curious a thinker as Settembrini, the novel casts Joachim's ability to find meaning and value in real life—that is, in lived experience rather than abstract ideas—in a positive light.



Settembrini counters that music can also have a dulling effect and argues that this can be politically dangerous. He rambles on. Hans listens for a bit, but he's tired and struggles to follow along. He watches a young girl sew a button onto the knee of the pants of a young boy. Both are serious ill. Hans thinks the young residents have odd pastimes.

Hans's inability (or perhaps unwillingness) to follow along with Settembrini's political and philosophical arguments convey his youth and inexperience. Settembrini has made clear his interest in serving as a mentor and imparting wisdom on the young protagonist, yet his wisdom falls on deaf ears.



PART 4, CHAPTER 5: HIPPE

Sunday afternoons also deviate from the sanatorium's normal schedule, with residents taking carriage rides. It's mostly the Russian women who participate in this activity. Hans watches Marusya and Madame Chauchat get into a carriage, laughing and chatting with each other. Each time he sees Madame Chauchat, he tries to recall the person she reminds him of, but he can't recall the revelation he had in his dream. Joachim, meanwhile, watches Marusya with sad eyes. After supper that night, Hans parts ways with Joachim earlier than usual and returns to his room, falling fast asleep well before nine.

The longer Hans stays at the Berghof, the more rest he needs to function. This could be due to the simple fact of the physical toll the sanatorium exacts on Hans's body—surely the high elevation of the Berghof's mountain setting is a physically exhausting adjustment to make. But it also indicates that Hans is succumbing to the allure of the sanatorium despite his claims that he's only a visitor passing through.



The following day brings another deviation from the norm when Krokowski delivers a lecture in the dining hall, something he does every other week. This talk is from a series called "Love as a Force Conducive to Illness." The talks are essentially mandatory. Hans is excited and curious about the talk. But before, he decides to go on a long walk by himself—something that turns out to be a very bad decision. He wants to prove that he's stronger and healthier than the residents—and he wants to get away from them for a bit, too. Joachim is wary and advises him not to overexert himself.

Hans's careless decision to go for a long walk puts him at risk of missing Krokowski's mandatory lecture. It seems like a pointed choice on Hans's part to differentiate himself from the Berghof's regular patients. The lectures are mandatory, yes, but only for permanent residents of the Berghof—and Hans, despite his growing affinity for the Berghof, is determined to prove that he's merely a visitor and thus doesn't have to follow the rules that real residents must follow.



Hans sets off after breakfast and breathes in fresh, open air. He starts up the slope of the mountain, singing and humming a song about love as a hikes. Soon, he's singing at full volume, belting out nonsense sounds when he forgets the words. At once, however, he feels short of breath. He tries to push on but eventually must sit beside a pine tree and gather his breath. He feels suddenly overcome with despair and feels his neck spasming. Instinctively, he thinks of his aged grandfather, and the thought disgusts him. Hans continues up the mountain, nonetheless. Later, his nose starts to bleed, staining his suit. Hans lies down until his bleeding stops and feels himself transported out of his body, while his real self travels to an earlier time and place—back to when he was 13.

In Hans's memory, he is in class—in seventh grade—talking to a boy named Pribislav Hippe, whom he has admired from afar for the past year. Hippe is a model student and the child of a history teacher. His appearance suggests his mixed origins: German and perhaps some Slavic-Wendish. All the children pick on him for his narrow, slanted eyes. Hans privately thinks of Hippe as his friend, though he doesn't know him, and he gets a rush of joy whenever they cross paths or Hippe chances to look at him. After that one conversation in class, another year passes, and then Hippe transfers to another school. By that point, Hans has already forgotten about him.

The conversation with Hippe happens when Hans is in drawing class. He doesn't have a pencil. He has acquaintances he could ask but feels he knows Hippe best—which is odd, since he's never even spoken to him. Hippe obliges, but he orders Hans not to break the pencil. Their conversation is brief, yet Hans feels happier than he has ever felt before. After he is finished with the pencil, he sharpens it and keeps a few of the shavings, storing them in his desk for a year or two. In the present, Hans wonders what happened to the shavings—he certainly never removed them, and so they might even still be in his desk at Uncle Tienappel's. It's Hippe, Hans now realizes, whom Frau Chauchat reminds him of. They look oddly similar.

With a start, Hans realizes he has to head back to the sanatorium to attend the lecture. The walk back is horrible, and he has to stop often to rest. He gets as far as the spa hotel in Platz when he realizes he won't be able to make it back to Berghof on foot because he's too spent, so he catches a ride with a delivery wagon headed for Dorf. When he arrives at the dining hall, he finds all the other residents gathered before Krokowski, who is already speaking.

Hans's singing seems to be another vain attempt to assert his vitality: he's determined to prove to himself, more than anyone else, that he's a healthy resident of ordinary society rather than a sickly resident of the Berghof. But his shortness of breath and his sudden memory of his aged grandfather, both of which seem to remind him of his mortality and the fragility of his body, suggest otherwise. Consequently, when he feels himself transported out of his physical body (apparently fading into a dream state of sorts), it suggests a conscious or subconscious desire to avoid confronting the discomfort revelation that he might not be as robust or physically healthy as he thought.



This scene adds to the conflict between Western ideals (which Settembrini, with his humanist values, represents) and Eastern ideals (which Madame Chauchat and Hans's rude Russian neighbors, with their bad manners and disrespect for social convention, represent). Hans's fascination with Pribislav Hippe, with his "Slavic-Wendish" origins and "slanted" eyes, symbolically suggests that Hans has been drawn toward Eastern ideals from a young age.



Hans's strong emotional attachment to Hippe's pencil shavings illustrates the underlying irrationality of passion: Hans can neither explain his inability to throw away the pencil shavings nor his initial fascination with Hippe. This scene also solves the mystery an earlier scene left unanswered: it's Hippe who Madame Chauchat reminds Hans of. This connection strongly suggests that Hans will become fixated on and perhaps even enchanted by Frau Chauchat now just as he was enchanted by Hippe as a youth.



In arriving late to a lecture that is mandatory for the Berghof's residents, Hans reasserts his identity as a visitor just passing through and therefore not subject to the Berghof's rules. This scene reaffirms the ambivalence that has come to characterize Hans's attitude toward the Berghof: he's drawn to it and wants to adopt the lifestyle it offers, yet he also wants to resist its pull. Ironically, of course, Hans's disregard for social norms—it's rude to show up late to a planned event—is exactly the sort of behavior he has observed and even admired in Berghof residents.



PART 4, CHAPTER 6: ANALYSIS

Hans sits down at a seat near the door and tries to act like he's been there the whole time. Hardly anybody notices him, which is good—he's pale, bloody, and looks generally awful. However, Madame Chauchat is in front of him—and she turns around to face him when he walks in. She looks just like Hippe. He looks at her horrible posture—so unlike the graceful way the women in his usual social circle hold themselves—with disgust. But in that moment, he recognizes in her the same freedom from honor he saw in Herr Albin. As he looks at her, his thoughts grow jumbled, and he can't pay attention to Krokowski's words.

Hans tries to focus. The subject of Krokowski's lecture is "the force of love," Krokowski's specialty. Krokowski's speech is both lyrical and intellectual, and it seems to affect both the men and women of the audience—but not Hans—emotionally. Hans hasn't heard anyone say the word "love" so much in his entire life, and he starts to feel uncomfortable. Krokowski says love is among the most puzzling, discomfiting of all human instincts. He presents passion and chastity as dueling forces, suggesting that fear seems to cause chastity to triumph in society. But this is merely an illusion, and beneath the surface, repressed love and passion linger. And the way this repressed passion presents itself on the surface, Krokowski explains, is as illness. The room collectively sighs as he voices this conclusion.

Hans watches Frau Chauchat fix her hair and becomes distracted by her stubby, unrefined hands. He thinks about Krokowski's theory about bourgeois forces stifling love. Hans thinks about how enticingly women dress, and he suddenly feels overcome with zeal for life. He realizes that to truly enjoy one's life, one must consciously remember that it is "magical." Of course, Hans counters, there's a logical explanation for why women dress the way they do: to entice men in order to procreate and bring about the next generation. Hans thinks that sickly women like Madame Chauchat should really be forbidden from dressing this way. It's illogical for a man to be attracted to a sick woman—just as it was illogical for Hans to be attracted to Hippe. Hans looks up at Krokowski just then and thinks he looks like Jesus on the cross.

Krokowski ends his lecture by raising his arms toward the crowd and praising "psychic dissection," urging his audience to come to him and let him relieve them, through analysis, of "hidden suffering, of shame and affliction."

Hans's feelings toward Clavdia are as ambivalent as his feelings toward the Berghof: he is simultaneously drawn to and disgusted by the way she disregards the social norms and values of his bourgeois society. At the same time, though, her poor manners and slouching appearance suggest the freeing quality of illness Hans first noted in Herr Albin.



The lecture's focus on "the force of love" is comically relevant to Hans's life, since his growing, suppressed love for Clavdia corresponds with his declining health. Krokowski portrays love as irrational and instinctual: a force as mysterious as it is powerful, and one that modern society—out of fear—seeks to repress. Hans's discomfort at Krokowski's talk of love, with its coded allusions to sexuality, reflects his youth and inexperience at this early point in the novel. He is young, and his understanding of the world is limited to what his bourgeois upbringing has taught him. Hans, in short, was brought up in the very society that fears (and so suppresses) love.



Hans makes a few key observations in this scene. First, he seems to accept Krokowski's notion that bourgeois social norms stifle love, and he questions whether he is really going about life the right way: is it better to rationally suppress one's dark, inner urges or to live a "magical" life full of unrepressed, irrational bursts of passion, even if they ultimately lead to self-destruction? Here, Hans's disgust toward Chauchat seems slowly to shift toward attraction. Through the Christ-like figure of Krokowski, he has seen the light.



Krokowski's practice of "psychic dissection" is his tongue-in-cheek term for psychoanalysis. By calling it a "dissection," he reinforces the link between repressed passion and physical illness. To understand illness, one must cut into the self to reveal the "hidden suffering, of shame at affliction" that lurks beneath the skin.



After the lecture, Krokowski heads out to the lobby. The residents follow him, crowding around him as though in a trance. Hans thinks he looks like the Pied Piper. Hans reminds himself that he's only a visitor at the sanatorium and has no use or interest in Krokowski's analysis. Hans wonders if Frau Chauchat lets Krokowski dissect her mind, too.

As usual, Hans remains ambivalent, torn between two opposing sides. On the one hand, Krokowski's invitation to release repressed passions appeals to him. On the other, he clings to his rational, bourgeois sensibilities. This is why he compares Krokowski to the Pied Piper, a folkloric villain who leads a village's children off a cliff to their deaths: he feels that acting on irrational passions will only lead to self-destruction, and he's not convinced this is the path he wants to go down.



Joachim finds Hans and asks him how his walk went. Hans admits that he walked a bit too far and that the walk might have harmed more than helped him. They do not discuss the lecture—and they never will.

Hans's comment that the walk hurt more than helped him could refer to the physical toll the walk took on his body, but it could also allude to the realization he made about the link between Clavdia and Hippe. Even at this early stage, Hans seems to register that Clavdia poses a threat to him.



PART 4, CHAPTER 7: DOUBTS AND CONSIDERATIONS

After Hans has been at the Berghof for one week, he gets a bill. It includes “medical treatment,” but Hans is fine with that, even though he didn't seek any—it's just part of the daily rate. He finds the fee reasonable.

That Hans is apparently fine with paying for “medical treatment” he didn't receive—especially after he's tried so hard this past week to convince himself that he is only visiting the Berghof, not receiving treatment as a patient—indicates his waning resistance to the allure of the sanatorium.



Later that day, Hans and Joachim discuss the management and structure of the Berghof. Director Behrens, it turns out, is not the owner of the institution—he is not an independent agent but merely acting on behalf of these more powerful forces. He came here by accident, when his sickly wife stayed here during the last few months of her life. It's rumored that Behrens became deeply depressed after her death and seemed to lose touch with reality. After her death, he stuck around, both because he wanted to be near her grave but also because he'd become sick himself—and thus “belonged here.” The narrator, at this point, contemplates whether it's possible for a doctor who is himself infected to be fully invested in curing others.

The detail of Behrens, the Berghof's “director,” coming to the sanatorium to visit his sickly wife, could be a comical reference to the book's author (and thus, its “director,” in a sense), Thomas Mann; Mann was inspired to write The Magic Mountain after visiting his wife at a sanatorium in the Swiss Alps. The detail that Behrens stuck around after getting sick himself following his wife's death suggests that there's something infectious about the Berghof, not only in terms of physical disease, but also the idle and decadent lifestyle the sanatorium offers.



As Hans listens to Joachim talk about Behrens's backstory, he expresses the same doubt about Behrens as the narrator has just voiced. Joachim counters that, while there's no way to know for sure whether Behrens is still a patient, it's likely that he's fully recovered by now. His children visit him sometimes, too. When his son, a university student, visited, it caused many of the women residents' temperatures to rise and led to many dissection appointments with Krokowski.

Joachim's remark about Behrens's son's visit causing the women residents' temperatures to rise (and necessitating many dissection appointments with Krokowski) is played for comedy, but it also reinforces the link between repressed emotions and physical illness.



Krokowski holds his consultations in a private room in a part of the sanatorium that people refer to as “the basement,” though the space is not actually underground, it just looks like it is. Hans glimpses the space once and notes how dark and mysterious it appears, as though stuck in a permanent dusk—so unlike the “clinical whiteness” of the rest of the facility.

It's fitting that Krokowski holds his “dissections” in the basement, given psychoanalysis's emphasis on unconscious, repressed drives. The darkness of the basement also creates a sense of foreboding. It doesn't seem like an atmosphere conducive to healing and enlightenment.



PART 4, CHAPTER 8: TABLE TALK

At meals in the dining hall, Hans realizes he's still experiencing the same tremor he first felt on his Sunday walk. He tries desperately to conceal his weakness but cannot. Hans realizes, much to his dismay and disgust, that this symptom is both the result of his new environment and “an inner excitement.” Madame Chauchat is always late to meals, and she always slams the door. Hans knows that each time this happens, he'll flinch and then his face will turn cold. Though at first he glares at her as she walks to the Good Russian table, eventually he stops, feeling ashamed that he ever felt he had a right to judge her.

Fräulein Engelhart, the schoolteacher and Hans's tablemate, realizes that the slamming of doors is creating a bond between Hans and Frau Chauchat—and that Hans's feigned indifference only strengthens that bond. In response, Fräulein Engelhart starts to bring up Chauchat in conversation as often as she can, urging Hans to go talk to her. She thinks everyone loves careless people, even if they want to think they don't. In fact, Frau Chauchat is quite charming, Engelhart insists.

Hans asks Fräulein Engelhart for more information about Frau Chauchat—is she really married? He's noticed that she doesn't wear a ring. Fräulein Engelhart assures Hans that Frau Chauchat is married but perhaps is just too liberal to feel it's necessary to wear a ring—all Russian women are quite liberated, Fräulein Engelhart assures Hans (Fräulein Engelhart is from a city near the Russian border and thus knows these things). Fräulein Engelhart explains that Frau Chauchat's husband is a civil servant with the Russian government and that he hasn't visited her at the Berghof even once. Fräulein Engelhart also tells Hans that this is Frau Chauchat's third time here. It's curious because while she's certainly ill, she's not quite ill enough to warrant staying at a sanatorium. She thinks maybe Frau Chauchat just doesn't like being around her husband.

The “inner excitement” Hans feels is a clear nod to Krokowski's lecture about repressed passions and a confirmation that his feelings toward sickly Clavdia have shifted from disgust to enchantment. This, in turn, symbolizes Hans's shifting attitude toward the sickly world of the Berghof, too, and the freedom that Hans believes he might find there.



Fräulein Engelhart's comment about everyone loving careless people, even if they want to convince themselves that they don't, gets at the heart of Hans's attraction to Clavdia. He wants to deny his feelings because Clavdia, on the surface, embodies everything his bourgeois sensibilities have taught him to reject: she is passionate, ill-mannered, and directionless. Yet his attraction to her suggests that he longs to embody these traits himself—a longing he conceals with indifference, perhaps out of shame.



Fräulein Engelhart's remark about “liberated” Russian women seems to be a veiled remark about their godless disregard for the sanctity of marriage. Not wearing a wedding ring, Fräulein Engelhart seems to suggest, indicates that Russian women might not remain faithful to their husbands. This detail links Clavdia (and by extension, the Eastern sensibilities she represents in the novel) with immorality and irrational passion.



Hans suggests that Fräulein Engelhart is being too generous toward Frau Chauchat—surely she’s not so pure. But though this is what he says aloud, inside he knows that Fräulein Engelhart’s high opinion of Frau Chauchat is valid. To hide his inner thoughts, though, he jokes that Fräulein Engelhart has a crush on Frau Chauchat and begins to refer to her as Fräulein Engelhart’s “Russian miss,” and “Lovely Minka.” Fräulein Engelhart scolds Hans, but both of them know the truth: Hans teases Fräulein Engelhart because he wants to hear about Frau Chauchat, and Fräulein Engelhart scolds Hans because she likes to be teased.

Eventually, Hans learns from Fräulein Engelhart that Frau Chauchat’s first name is Clavdia. Unlike before, Hans doesn’t try to hide his delight at learning more about Frau Chauchat. And as he walks around, he also starts to sing and hum love songs to himself. He scolds himself for being so foolish about his “relationship” with Frau Chauchat—maybe if he were a normal young man down in the flatlands such behavior would’ve been appropriate, but up here it makes no sense. Still, whereas before his beating heart had had no identifiable cause, now it’s clear that thoughts of Frau Chauchat make his heart pound.

Hans and Fräulein Engelhart’s joking banter implicitly reinforces some of the main focuses of Krokowski’s recent lecture. Their dialogue and actions are driven by unconscious (or at least unexpressed) desires: Hans projects his feelings for Frau Chauchat onto Fräulein Engelhart. Meanwhile, Fräulein Engelhart denies her desire to be teased.



Hans’s feelings for Clavdia reinforce the link between physical ailment and repressed inner feeling, with Hans’s pounding heart functioning as a physical symptom of his repressed, irrational passion for a woman it makes no sense for him to be attracted to. Now that Hans (and readers) know Madame Chauchat’s full name, it’s worth analyzing the full name’s symbolism. Clavdia (spelled “Clawdia” in some editions of the book) contains the word “claw,” perhaps alluding to her capacity to use her sensuality to trap Hans in her claws. Her last name, Chauchat, has a few possible interpretations. A Chauchat was a machine gun the French Army used during World War I, hinting at the self-destructive nature of Hans’s irrational attraction to Clavdia.



PART 4, CHAPTER 9: GROWING ANXIETY/TWO GRANDFATHERS AND A TWILIGHT BOAT RIDE

The lousy weather continues, making it difficult for Joachim and Hans to take another outing. Hans doesn’t mind the monotony though, since he’s only going to be here three weeks total. Curiously, though, Hans can’t help but feel regret that his stay at the Berghof seems to be flying by as his infatuation with Madame Chauchat grows. He stares at her in the dining hall but pretends not to, a bad performance meant for her to see right through—as she clearly does. One day she stares back at him, and their mutual shock at this causes her to drop her napkin. After this incident, however, she doesn’t look at him for another two days.

Hans longs to be in Madame Chauchat’s company, even though he also admits that she is beneath him, with her poor posture, bad manners, and bitten fingernails. One day, when he overhears her in the lobby struggling to speak German, he feels a sudden pride in his native language and feels superior to Madame Chauchat. In a sense, he regards his “relationship” with the odd woman as little more than a vacation fling and therefore not quite real, however much he continues to daydream about her.

This passage reinforces the notion that time is malleable and subjective. Before Hans developed feelings for Clavdia, his days were rather monotonous and so passed slowly. But now that Hans has a tempting reason to want to stay at the Berghof, time flies. Clavdia’s choice to stare back at Hans indicates that she knows he’s attracted to her and perhaps even reciprocates his feelings. Their unspoken, mostly unacted-upon romance is rather immature, underscoring Hans’s youth and inexperience at the start of his coming-of-age journey.



Hans continues to deny his obvious feelings for Madame Chauchat, desperately turning to “logic” (she is beneath him, it doesn’t make sense for him to be attracted to someone with such poor manners, etc.) to undermine his instinctive attraction to her. All the same, he continues to pine after her. Once more, Hans is torn between his rational, bourgeois sensibilities and the irrational passion that Clavdia and her Eastern influence evokes in him.



Nevertheless, Hans does make some effort to meet Madame Chauchat properly. Knowing that she arrives late to meals, he starts arriving late, too, and discreetly making sure to pass by her door around the time she usually leaves for the dining hall. On the days she emerges from her room just after Hans has passed by her door, Hans can feel her eyes on his back, and it makes the nerves in his legs twitch. On days he arrives at the dining hall before Madame Chauchat, he sometimes makes up an excuse to go back to his room, allowing himself and Madame Chauchat to encounter each other head-on in the hallway.

The second time this happens, Madame Chauchat stares directly at Hans, causing his blood to run cold. He stares at her face, which he finds “foreign,” strange, and distinct. Her face is both sharp and soft. Her “Kirghizshaped eyes,” which are so stern and dark from afar, look so much like Pribislav Hippe’s. The encounter simultaneously thrills and terrifies Hans.

Meanwhile, Joachim’s mood becomes increasingly gloomy and dejected as he continues to plead with Behrens to let him return to the “flatlands” below and resume his military duties. Joachim insists each night near the start of the social hour that he and Hans return to their rooms for their rest cure. Hans knows why—it’s because Marusya is there, laughing, and Joachim cannot bear his attraction to her. Hans wonders if Joachim feels as trapped here as he does.

In time, Hans becomes totally acclimated to life at the Berghof, even learning to swaddle himself in his two blankets as well as any other resident. He starts to think it odd that nobody “down there” knew anything about this “art” form, and his fixation on this thought bothers him. He longs to confide in someone who can help him make sense of these unusual and troubling thoughts. He thinks back to the advice Behrens gave him when he first arrived about living as a resident. Hans thinks of Behrens as something of a father figure, he realizes, and he also realizes that he wants some paternal advice. Despite this, he finds it hard to trust Behrens, uncertain that the doctor is truly cured of his long-ago illness.

Slowly but surely, Hans takes his pursuit of Clavdia to the next level. Though he still hasn’t spoken to her, he strategically places himself in situations that put him in close physical proximity to her. It’s also notable that he starts arriving late to meals, a display of poor manners he would have frowned upon (and, indeed, did frown upon) just days before. This shows that Clavdia’s dangerous and irrational influence is rubbing off on Hans and leading him astray.



Hans’s response to Clavdia’s stare reinforces the link between physical symptoms and repressed emotions. Meanwhile, his focus on her “foreign” face and his comparison of her face to Hippe’s underscores the irrational temptation that Eastern ideals pose to Hans.



As time progresses, Joachim’s and Hans’s feelings about the Berghof shift in opposite ways. Joachim, who has never felt at home there, becomes more restless and frustrated. Hans, meanwhile, feels more at ease at the Berghof the longer he’s there. The cousins’ opposite feelings toward the Berghof mirror their opposite feelings about their respective irrational passions. Joachim hates the way his attraction to Marusya undercuts his duty and his bourgeois sensibilities. Hans, meanwhile, seems increasingly willing to set aside his bourgeois sensibilities to act on his passion for Clavdia.



Hans’s adeptness at swaddling himself in the camel-hair blankets symbolizes his growing acclimation to life at the Berghof. Where once he thought the residents’ customs were strange and nonsensical, now he considers them “art” forms and thinks that the people “down there” (a community of which he seems to no longer consider himself a part) are strange for not knowing about or appreciating these art forms. Hans’s transformed relationship to Behrens, too, signals his acceptance of the Berghof as his new home. Behrens, in becoming something of a father figure to Hans, symbolically replaces the family Hans left behind “down there.”



Hans considers whether Settembrini could be a mentor to him. Though Settembrini had criticized Hans's idea that sickness and stupidity are opposites, he had also called himself a "pedagogue" and seems clearly interested in molding young minds.

Hans has previously rejected Settembrini's efforts to teach him, so it's curious that he seems to take an interest in Settembrini as a mentor now. Perhaps he recognizes, if only subconsciously, the danger that Clavdia (and the ideals she stands for, like irrationality, passion, and idleness) poses to him, and perhaps he wants somebody to guide him back to the right path.



One day, Settembrini stops by Hans's table in the dining hall and asks Frau Stöhr about her present condition. When she complains about being in poor health, Settembrini jokes that she must have a doppelgänger—last night, he saw Frau Stöhr's light on her balcony and thought she must be dutifully taking her rest cure. But just moments later, he saw her eating desserts, drinking wine, and seeing a film at the cinema. The accusation makes Frau Stöhr squirm in her seat, and her discomfort only grows when Settembrini reveals that she was doing these things in the company of Captain Miklosich from Bucharest. The other tablemates make eyes at each other—it's common knowledge that Frau Stöhr sneaks off to have fun in the English quarter of town (while her unknowing husband waits for her back home). Settembrini also implies that Frau Stöhr is having sex with Miklosich.

Settembrini's commitment to truth, knowledge, and social decorum make him unique among the Berghof's residents. Frau Stöhr, as he reveals here, is a hypocrite, claiming to be ill and helpless and yet engaging in antics and romantic trysts in town when she thinks nobody is watching. Settembrini, like Joachim, seems unsatisfied with the dishonorable and tedious lives that most patients at the Berghof lead. This scene, then, establishes that Settembrini could be a positive and worthy mentor to Hans, should Hans choose to listen to the older man's advice.



Of course, Frau Stöhr isn't the only resident to engage in such illicit behavior, Settembrini admits, noting Anton Schneermann's empty chair—apparently, the teenager's mother somehow found out that he'd been engaging in immoral (sexual) behavior and removed him from the facility immediately. Settembrini knows all the gossip, and everyone laughs at the insider details he shares.

Settembrini's love of gossip reveals that he's not quite as principled as he makes himself out to be—he can be just as frivolous about how he spends his time as any of the other residents. This complicates his character, somewhat: while Settembrini's ideals are generally noble, he doesn't always translate these ideals into action.



Settembrini also talks about his family in Italy. He regretfully compares the life he wastes away at the Berghof to his grandfather's revolutionary past—he conspired against Austria and the Holy Roman Empire and was a political revolutionary, a Carbanaro. He was a courageous man full of national pride who wished to see his country free. He supported freedom not only in his own country but in all places. After 10 years of exile, he was able to return to Italy and find work as a lawyer in Milan. He continued to call and write for freedom in his own country and in all lands.

This section contextualizes Settembrini's humanistic ideals of liberty and democracy within his rich family history.



One detail from Settembrini's story about his grandfather sticks out to Hans: he always wore black in public, out of "mourning" for his country. This reminds Hans of his own grandfather, who also wore black, though young Hans never knew why. Nevertheless, Hans ruminates now, both grandfathers built a wall between themselves and the "evil present" that surrounded them. But while his grandfather did so to honor the past, Settembrini's did so for the future—for progress.

Settembrini praises Hans's homeland of Germany for contributing two key inventions, both of which he believes contributed to progress and democracy: gunpowder and the printing press. Meanwhile, he praises Italy for its major role in pushing forward enlightenment ideals and culture. Settembrini preaches that technology and morality go hand in hand: he believes the world was born in immoral darkness but, through advancement and progress, has become more moral. Though Hans consistently takes issue with some ideas Settembrini puts forth in his many lectures, he tries to at least listen to the man with an open mind, much like a traveler who takes care to learn about a new culture.

Another of Settembrini's big ideas is that the world is governed by two opposing principles: "might and right, tyranny and freedom, superstition and knowledge," and so forth. Settembrini claims the former may be thought of as the "Asiatic principle," and the latter the "European principle." He has no doubt that enlightenment and progress—the European ideals—will always win out, though there's still much work to be done. To achieve complete enlightenment, however, Settembrini argues, it will be necessary to destroy the center of the Asiatic principle of tyranny: Vienna. Hans takes issue with this theory, and Joachim—the military man—does too.

Settembrini also lectures about his reverence for humanism (meaning, at its core, a love of humankind). He inherited this reverence from his father (the humanist philosopher) and grandfather (the freedom-driven political agitator). Settembrini, as a writer, believes that words and language are vessels for humanity's "dignity and self-respect." And he believes that politics play into this, too, since politicians are people putting dignified word into action.

As Hans contemplates the similarities and differences between the two grandfathers, he's once more caught between two opposing ideals: honoring the past or working toward the future. As usual, he remains ambivalent about which side to take. He is still early in his self-education and lacks the conviction to commit to his ideals.



This scene emphasizes Settembrini's humanist beliefs: he values rationality, human progress, and personal liberty most of all. Settembrini, having previously implied the responsibility that mentors have to mold the minds of the younger generation, is clearly trying to instill his own values in Hans. Hans remains characteristically ambivalent, though he tries to recast this ambivalence in a positive light, portraying his passive inability to take a side as having an open mind.



Settembrini's idea that the world is governed by two opposing principles is an important concept that will reverberate throughout the rest of the novel, especially as Hans has more firsthand experience with characters whom Settembrini would classify as proponents of his so-called "Asiatic principle"—characters such as Clavdia, whose sensuality and rationality, Settembrini might argue, inhibit human progress.



Settembrini's belief in the power of words and language to ensure "dignity and self-respect" is a good principle in the abstract, but it's notable that he, unlike his grandfather the political agitator, doesn't translate his humanist beliefs into concrete actions. While the book generally sides with Settembrini's politics and intellectual views, it is critical of his inability to act on his ideals.



The narrator observes that at first it might seem that the waking Hans is very different from the sleeping Hans. While the former listens to Settembrini with an open mind (even if he doesn't agree with everything he says), the sleeping Hans, in his dreams, dismisses the man as an "organ-grinder" preaching lofty, meaningless ideals. Yet as soon as Hans considers Settembrini's lectures alone, he finds himself drawn only toward views that oppose Settembrini's love of patriotism, literature, and human dignity. And what's more, Hans probably only listened to Settembrini in the first place to grant his troubled conscience permission to gravitate toward the opposite: toward "listless, worm-eaten, Kirghiz-eyed" Clavdia Chauchat.

Settembrini's lectures fail to secure Hans's full attention, perhaps because they are just that: lectures. The abstract ideals Settembrini preaches to Hans can hardly compete with the physical, sensuous presence of Clavdia Chauchat. And so, Hans increasingly finds himself drawn toward a harbinger of the "Asiatic principle" Settembrini has warned Hans against: the "listless, worm-eaten, Kirghiz-eyed" Clavdia Chauchat.



PART 4, CHAPTER 10: THE THERMOMETER

Hans's second week at the Berghof comes and goes, and he once more pays his weekly bill. Hans tallies up the expenses and still finds the cost to be quite reasonable, even if he's not making use of the medical facilities—though he has begun taking an evening rest cure, since that's what everyone else does. Time passes, and eventually Hans only has a few days left. He realizes it's true what everyone says—three weeks is hardly any time up here. Hans feels bad for Joachim, who clearly isn't looking forward to losing his companion. Worse still, Hans gets to return to the "flatlands" and do meaningful work in the transportation technology field while Joachim must waste away up here doing nothing.

The narration repeatedly draws attention to the malleable and tenuous nature of time, and its structure embodies those characteristics. While Hans's first week at the Berghof took up hundreds of pages, the narration uses only a fraction of that space to convey Hans's second week, indicating that time has started to pass more quickly for Hans now that he's gotten used to the Berghof.



As Hans prepares to leave, he observes that he may need a period of rest to recover from his vacation—indeed, he feels run down and even seems to have come down with a cold. It's probably from lying outside on his balcony during his evening rest cure, which he loves to do, listening to the sound of music coming from the valley in the distance. Hans reasons that Joachim must enjoy sitting on the balcony as much as he does, though he has no appreciation for music, unfortunately.

Hans's thought that he might need some rest to recover from his vacation is comical: resting is practically all he's done since arriving at the Berghof. More importantly, however, Hans's poor physical health suggests that the atmosphere of the Berghof, with its emphasis on rest and inaction, is harming him more than healing him.



Joachim agrees to put in a word with the "official channels" of the sanatorium and get some medical staff to examine Hans. That Friday, the head nurse, von Mylendonk (the one Settembrini doesn't like) comes to Hans's room to determine what's wrong with him. She asks him a lot of questions rather harshly. She identifies a catarrh and explains that it's not the result of a cold but of an infection—now, the task is to determine the seriousness of that infection. The nurse is shocked to learn that Hans hasn't checked his temperature since coming to the sanatorium. In fact, he doesn't even own a **thermometer**. She produces a bag with a few different thermometers for purchase for Hans to choose from.

The novel has established thermometers as a symbol of the Berghof's surreal environment and its alienation from the wider world. Thus far, Hans has resisted taking his temperature, symbolizing his resistance to losing touch with his life back home, however tempting he may find some parts of life at the Berghof to be. But his choice to buy a thermometer from Head Nurse von Mylendonk marks a major shift in his character, signifying that he is ready to leave his old life (and reality in general) behind and accept a new life as a Berghof patient.



After Head Nurse von Mylendonk leaves, Hans takes his temperature, waiting for seven minutes, as Joachim does. The time passes slowly, but after seven minutes are up, Hans discovers that he has a fever of 99.7—a bit too high. He relays this news to Joachim when he comes to fetch Hans for dinner. He also admits to feeling feverish practically the entire time he's been at the Berghof. Joachim insists that Hans get in bed, but Hans refuses, arguing that the fever isn't really that high.

Hans, despite Joachim's protests, goes down to dinner. After refusing a drink of beer, he casually explains to his tablemates that he has a slight fever. The news greatly amuses Frau Stöhr. Hans downplays his condition, but nobody believes him. Instead they laugh and tell him he should really make an appointment with the doctor. Frau Stöhr goes off on a tangent about the pleasant sensation of coughing.

After dinner, Joachim suggests to Hans that he accompany him to his monthly checkup with Behrens tomorrow—he can give Hans a quick look-over then. Hans agrees. They run into Behrens himself not long after and explain the situation to him, and he happily agrees to examine Hans during Joachim's appointment tomorrow. He even seems delighted to hear that Hans has a slight fever, remarking that Hans is "talented" for having that high a fever so early, especially for "a beginner."

The next day, Hans accompanies Joachim to his appointment and watches as Behrens taps on different parts of Joachim's body, ordering him to alternatively cough and take deep breaths. It's clear that Joachim is very used to this procedure. Behrens remarks on a deep rattle in Joachim's chest. Dr. Krokowski, meanwhile, sits in a corner and takes notes. Hans examines his cousin's body and notes his toned physique. It makes sense that he wanted to become a soldier—he was always more mindful of physical health than Hans. Hans, on the other hand, was more interested in the pleasures of good food and drink. It's ironic, then, that Joachim's body is the one that has failed him. Illness, Hans muses, "turns [people] into only a body."

When Behrens finishes, Joachim starts to ask him if he can go home soon, but Behrens sternly repeats what he told Joachim the other day—he'll be there for at least another six months.

Hans's temperature is higher than normal, but not worryingly so. In this way, it mirrors his ambivalence toward the Berghof and all the things he's been exposed to since coming there: he longs for a mentor and yet resists Settembrini's efforts to teach him, and Clavdia Chauchat both disgusts and attracts him.



Hans's attitude toward his sickness reinforces his characteristic ambivalence: he wants to write off his illness and return to his regular life as planned, but he also clearly wants his tablemates to acknowledge and congratulate him on his poor health.



Behrens's joy at learning about Hans's fever is ironic: as a doctor, Behrens should want patients to leave his institution healthier, not sicker, than when they arrived. His humorous remark about Hans being "talented" for getting a fever so early in his stay indicates how impressionable Hans is at this point. Hans arrived at the Berghof convinced that his health was robust and that he was eager to return to his life in normal society, and yet his health started taking a turn for the worse practically the minute he arrived, symbolizing his vulnerability to outside influences.



Joachim's mindfulness about physical health reflects his pragmatism and his ability to translate his ideals into action: he feels a sense of duty to serve his country, and so he ensures that he is physically fit to do so. Hans, on the other hand, lacks this sense of duty or direction, and he indulges in worldly pleasures instead. The irony of Joachim's carefully maintained body failing him while Hans's body has (for the most part) remained healthy speaks to the arbitrary nature of illness and suffering. Ultimately, Hans realizes, illness is only about the body: it has nothing to do with a person's ideals or intentions.



This scene reinforces Joachim's resistance to the Berghof: despite being there for months and despite his poor health, he still can't bring himself to feel at home there and can't lose sight of his responsibilities back home.



Hans gets up for his turn. Behrens spins him around as though he's a thing, not a person. He taps around on Hans' body. After he asks Hans to cough a few times, he steps back and tells Hans that, just as he's long suspected, Hans has been "secretly one of the locals" all along. Hans and Joachim freeze. Behrens taps a few spots on Hans' chest and points out a muffled sound—a clear indicator of a fresh, moist spot in the lungs. He tells Hans it would be no use for him to leave for the flatlands now, as he'd inevitably just wind up back here due to his illness. Before Hans can leave, Krokowski approaches him and, placing one hand on Hans's shoulder, presents his other hand for Hans to shake.

The physical and emotional symptoms Hans has experienced since he first arrived at the Berghof (the pounding heart, the propensity to philosophize, the increased need for sleep) culminate in this pivotal moment as he completes his transition from visitor to resident. When Behrens mischievously suggests that Hans has been "secretly one of the locals," he's suggesting that the ambivalence and unease that Hans's character have made him a good fit for the Berghof's atmosphere all along.



PART 5, CHAPTER 1: ETERNAL SOUP AND SUDDEN CLARITY

The narrator notes that the next three weeks of Hans's stay at the Berghof will require about as many lines or even words as his first three weeks required pages—this is just how "the laws of narrative," which play with the passage of time, work. Time passes quickly, after all, when one is a bedridden patient. And that's what Hans has been, per Behrens's orders.

Once more, the narration focuses on the malleable experience of time. Here, the narrator explicitly notes how "the laws of narrative"—that is, the genre conventions that dictate how one tells a story—are designed to mimic this malleable, subjective experience, spending more pages describing time that seems to drag on and fewer pages describing time that flies by.



Joachim leaves Hans alone for a day, but on Sunday he comes to his room to ask him about what they should do with the people who are expecting Hans back home. Hans says it's not a big deal—they're not expecting him on any particular day. Joachim feels bad—he fears Hans would never have gotten sick if he hadn't come to visit him. Hans thinks this is ridiculous. He came here for a vacation, and he clearly needed one. And he can't be the first person this has happened to who's come here. He thinks that illness probably even runs in the family. Anyway, Hans trusts Behrens, and there's no point in fearing the worst until he has his **X-rays** done. Hans is still convinced he'll be leaving here shortly.

Hans's reaction to his sudden change of plans is strangely—and, indeed, comically—casual. He was slated to start work when he returned home, after all. What's more, his sudden trust in Behrens is a far cry from the skepticism he expressed just days before in the doctor's ability to cure his patients. It's also curious that Hans, who has repeatedly encountered patients (including Joachim) whose release Behrens has pushed back by months, is so confident he'll be leaving the Berghof shortly. Whether Hans is in denial or simply woefully naïve about his situation remains unclear.



Hans takes his meals in bed on Sunday, and Joachim reports back to him about everything that happened that day, including Krokowski's bi-weekly lecture. Today, he talked about love again, but this time in terms of "basic chemistry"—about a living thing poisoning itself with substances it kept inside the body. Eventually it's Tuesday—the day Hans was originally supposed to leave. Behrens determines that Hans will have to stay longer and that he'll have more information as soon as possible. Hans writes a letter home to explain the situation and feels content, though still sick.

Krokowski's lecture reflects Hans's present situation: his repressed urges and desires, whether they be his self-indulgence or his irrational love for Clavdia, are poisoning him and manifesting as the physical symptoms of illness he's now experiencing. But Hans is either too naïve or too in denial to recognize this, and the similarity goes right over his head.



Each day now, an attendant knocks on Hans's door, addressing him by his room number (34) and rubbing him down with alcohol. His meals are the same elaborate feasts he enjoyed downstairs, though he now takes them in bed. Krokowski visits Hans during his regular afternoon rounds. This first happens on Monday, and it takes Hans by surprise. Krokowski addresses Hans as "comrade" and informs him that the moist spot in his lungs isn't merely an "organic" problem. Organic problems, the doctor explains, are always symptoms of different, deeper-seated problems. In time, Hans is no longer bothered by Krokowski's visits. Time, too, begins to pass more quickly for him, with afternoons seamlessly fading into evenings.

One day, around 10 or 12 days since Hans first became bedridden, Settembrini comes to visit. He turns on the overhead light as he steps into Hans's room and declares Hans a "poor fellow." Hans thinks this is rather arrogant—surely he'll be well and on his way out of here before Settembrini. He asks Hans how he's doing and then remarks with some amusement on Hans's choice to let them examine him just before he was set to leave. He also notes Hans's decision to start keeping track of his temperature before anyone ordered him to do so. Hans jokes along, recalling with some amusement the names by which Settembrini referred to Behrens and Krokowski on Hans's first day at the Berghof—Rhadamanthus and Minos, two judges of hell.

Settembrini jokes darkly about a patient whom the doctors made sicker than she was before she first arrived at the Berghof. Hans laughs this off but assures Settembrini that Behrens did indeed identify some cavities in Hans's lungs. Settembrini gleefully replies that sometimes spots that appear to be cavities are merely shadows, and other times real problems don't show up at all. Finally Hans convinces the man that he is, in fact, truly ill.

After Settembrini asks about his family back home who may be concerned for him, Hans initially speaks favorably of his homeland, but then he goes on a rambling tangent about the comparative crudeness of life "down there" compared to up at the Berghof. Settembrini lets Hans speak until he trails off, then he sighs and cautions Hans about how every young person who stays here for any extended period of time ultimately becomes "lost to life," unable to do anything but muck about and take their temperature. They become incapable of living any other sort of life.

When the attendant addresses Hans by his room number, it reflects the gradual loss of self he experiences as he gives in to illness and inaction and accepts his new identity as a resident of the Berghof. He's no longer Hans Castorp, the young engineer with the promising career ahead of him. Now, he's defined entirely by his illness. His willingness to sit through Krokowski's visits and the swiftness with which time passes underscore this transformation.



Here, Settembrini implicitly notes Hans's ambivalence about staying at the Berghof. Though Hans insists he'll recover and be on his way in no time, Settembrini points out that Hans chose to be examined right before he was supposed to leave and started keeping track of his temperature before anyone told him to do so. Hans's choices, Settembrini implies, suggest that Hans had wanted to stay at the Berghof and was looking for excuses to make that happen. Notably, Hans neither confirms nor denies this accusation. Once more, Hans's mentor tries to help Hans—in this situation, he seems to be trying to make Hans understand his behavior so he can get back on track and return to his life in ordinary society. But once more, Hans obstinately disregards Settembrini's genuine efforts to help him.



Settembrini tries again, this time through humor, to get through to Hans—to make him see that his illness might be more exaggerated and self-indulgent than he believes—and once again, Hans ignores Settembrini.



Settembrini, who has the benefit of age and experience, tries to get through to young and naïve Hans, warning him that he will waste his life if he remains at the Berghof for too long. The notion of becoming "lost to life" is an idea that recurs throughout the novel; ultimately, Hans's coming-of-age story centers on the question of whether he will become and remain "lost to life," or whether he will find his way back to the world, complete his self-education and self-awareness, and become a contributing member of society.



Settembrini remembers one man who got to go home. But upon his arrival, he immediately took to bed and did nothing but take his temperature all day. He claimed, to his frustrated family, that only people who'd lived "up there" would understand. His mother ordered him to go back "up there" then, and so he did—he returned to his "home." Hans only half listens to this story, though, and dismisses it as another of Settembrini's meaningless stories. He redirects the subject to his earlier idea about the harsh cruelty of life "down there" and rattles on about that some more, and about his illness. He decides it makes sense that he's ill now, as he has always felt rather weak. He also thinks that maybe his parents' early deaths made him more aware of the inherent cruelty of life than other people are.

Settembrini lets Hans speak until he trails off, then he gives him some advice, and this time he does so in a grave tone, offering Hans no opportunity to interject or joke. The only "religious" and dignified way to think of death, Settembrini cautions, is as continuous with life—not to separate it from life or think of it as "in opposition to life." He cites ancient religions who knew how to properly "honor" death. But once one separates death from life, it becomes "grotesque," a "depraved force" that can confuse impressionable minds. He compares this relationship to the earlier argument he and Hans had about the combination of sickness and stupidity, and he pleads with Hans to let him continue to instruct him and to correct some of Hans's flawed ideas about life.

Suddenly Joachim walks in, interrupting Hans and Settembrini. Hans laughs and explains that Settembrini has been helping him "pass the time." After Settembrini leaves, Hans remarks on what a "pedagogue" the man is. He's sure he'd never have understood a word of what Settembrini says if they'd met down below.

Settembrini tells this story as a warning to Hans about what his future might look like if he stays at the Berghof for too long. The parallels between this man's story and Hans's own situation should be clear, yet Hans disregards it as a silly story, further highlighting his youthful naivety and stubbornness. His idea that life "down there" in ordinary society is harsh and cruel reads as superficial and insincere, given the ease and comfort that characterized Hans's formative years in Germany. It almost seems that he's searching, desperately, for any argument to defend his choice to stay at the Berghof.



Settembrini senses that Hans has started to assign too much meaning to illness and suffering, acting as though his sudden and unexpected illness has led him to some special, higher grasp on the meaning of life. When Settembrini cautions Hans against thinking about death as being "in opposition to life," he means that Hans should stop turning to death and illness for answers about life. In Settembrini's view, the only way to achieve personal enlightenment is through a rational, affirmative embrace of life.



Hans's joke that Settembrini has been helping him to "pass the time" further highlights Hans's youthful stubbornness. Settembrini has made it clear that he's urgently trying to help Hans, whose ongoing attraction to death and illness is leading him down a dark path toward self-destruction and confusion. Yet, Hans disregards Settembrini's concern, apparently convinced that he can confidently make decisions for himself and so demonstrating his stubborn, youthful hubris.



Time passes. Hans didn't bring a calendar with him when he initially traveled to see Joachim, and so he has trouble keeping track of the exact date. Now, he has only the concerts that happen every other Sunday to mark the passage of time. Meanwhile, the weather turns summery once more, and Joachim expresses his remorse that Hans, still bedridden, is unable to join him outside to enjoy the sun. But then, toward the end of Behrens's recommended period of bedrest for Hans, the weather turns gloomy once more. When Behrens examines Hans to determine whether he's well enough to leave, Hans asks him if he's well enough to get up. Behrens seems surprised at the question but gives him permission to at least leave his bed going forward. It's unclear whether the doctor would have said so if Hans hadn't asked.

In seemingly no time at all, Hans has become just like any other resident of the Berghof, relying on Sunday concerts to gauge the passage of time and having no sense of urgency about leaving the sanatorium. On the other hand, Hans's suspicion that Behrens might not have given him permission to leave his bed if he hadn't asked suggests that he still has some lingering doubts about Behrens's interest in curing him of his illness. Behrens, Hans implies, would be content to let his patients remain sick and bedridden indefinitely: that his patients recover is not one of Behrens's immediate concerns. But Hans dismisses this suspicion without much thought, suggesting that he himself isn't in too great a hurry to get better.



PART 5, CHAPTER 2: "MY GOD, I SEE IT!"

The Berghof has been busy lately, recently receiving many new residents, and so it's a week before Head Nurse Mylendonk orders Hans to report for **X-rays**. Hans doesn't mind that it took so long—he knows there are many people here who are sicker than he is. And at the sanatorium, it's a matter of social etiquette to respect those with more severe illnesses. Hans finds that when he returns to his table in the dining hall for the first time following his three weeks of isolation, hardly anyone pays him any mind—as though he'd been gone for no time at all.

Once more, Hans exhibits a curiously laid-back attitude about his illness, hardly caring that it's taking an unreasonably long amount of time for Berghof staff to X-ray him to confirm that he's ill enough to justify his continued stay at the Berghof. He seems content to remain at the Berghof indefinitely and feels no great pull to return to his life in ordinary society. At the same time, he's not quite ready to admit that he wants to remain at the Berghof, and so he manufactures a story about Behrens being overly swamped with patients to justify his extended stay.



But Hans's crush on Madame Chauchat has only grown—all throughout his isolation, visions of her floated in front of his eyes. This, in truth, was how his time in bed managed to pass so swiftly. Hans reacted to these visions with a mixture of joy and horror. Joachim, meanwhile, doesn't talk about Marusya, and so Hans doesn't say anything to him about his infatuation with Clavdia Chauchat, limiting his conversations about her to his teasing interactions with Fräulein Engelhart.

That Hans's amorous thoughts about Madame Chauchat made his time in bed pass quickly further illustrates the malleable nature of time. Hans's and Joachim's opposite approaches to dealing with their crushes—Hans indulges his while Joachim resists thinking about Marusya—mirror their opposite approaches to being ill. Hans indulges his illness and is in no hurry to return to his normal life. Joachim, meanwhile, has never allowed himself to get off track. He remains as determined as ever to get better so he can return to his military service. While Hans has "become lost" to the world, as Settembrini cautioned he would, Joachim remains sharply focused on reality.



One day, Fräulein Engelhart gives Hans some unsettling news: Clavdia has been posing for Behrens in his private residence to have her portrait painted. Upon hearing this, Hans returns to his room to take his temperature and finds that it is 99.9 degrees. Hans has recently noticed something else that has disturbed him—a new patient, a young man from Manheim, has been ogling Clavdia, too, though Clavdia doesn't seem to pay him any mind. But, the narrator asserts, the narrative is straying too far from the most pressing issue: Hans's **X-ray** exam.

Hans "descend[s]" into the basement laboratory for his **X-rays**. Joachim accompanies him. It's busy downstairs, and lots of people are waiting. As Hans waits for his turn, he observes that the basement is cloaked in "a kind of artificial twilight," just like Dr. Krokowski's office is. Suddenly, Clavdia appears in the waiting area and takes a seat beside the entrance to the laboratory. Hans feels his blood freeze. She asks, in broken German, what time his appointment is at. Joachim and Clavdia complain about the doctor being behind schedule. Hans thinks about Behrens painting Clavdia's portrait—an interpretation of her exterior. Then he thinks about her being X-rayed, revealing her insides, and he must look away out of "respectability."

Luckily, the staff seem determined to speed things along, so eventually it's time for Joachim and Hans to head into the laboratory. To Hans, the room looks like "a photographer's studio, a darkroom, or an inventor's workshop and a sorcerer's laboratory." Behrens is there and greets them. Joachim immediately removes his clothes. Behrens tells Hans that seeing his insides should put some of his worries to rest. He shows Hans his "private gallery," presenting a series of black plates that display a series of **X-rayed** body parts. Then he gets to work with the exam.

Joachim goes first. Behrens turns off the lights and explains that they must wait for their eyes to adjust to the darkness. Hans like this and compares it to a moment of silent prayer. Finally, their eyes adjusted, Hans looks at Joachim's insides displayed upon the viewing apparatus. He sees Joachim's heart. Doing so—looking at Joachim's "gaunt *memento mori*"—both thrills and horrifies Hans.

Once more, the novel suggests a link between physical symptoms and repressed emotions, a nod to Krokowski's psychoanalytic lecture and to the titular "magic" of the Berghof. Here, Hans's agitation at the thought of his crush posing for Behrens manifests as a physical symptom: a raised fever. Hans's irrational obsession with the tempting and dangerous Clavdia is literally making him sick.



The "artificial twilight" of the basement gives it an ominous and uncertain quality. And twilight, an ambiguous time of day when it's neither light nor dark but somewhere in between, mirrors the ambiguity that characterizes the experience of the typical Berghof resident: their chronic illness leaves them in a meandering, restless state between life and death. Hans's impulse to look away from Clavdia's X-ray out of "respectability" suggests a perverse sexual or sensual attraction to her insides: to the organs that are making her ill. This, in turn, reinforces that Clavdia's illness—and the freedom Hans has decided it gives her—are what he's most attracted to.



Hans's description of the laboratory as "a photographer's studio, a darkroom, or an inventor's workshop and a sorcerer's laboratory" suggests that Hans sees Behrens as an artist and a visionary. In his inflated regard for Behrens and his work, then, Hans continues to attach great meaning and significance to illness and suffering.



Memento mori literally translates to "remember you must die." When Hans describes Joachim's heart as a "gaunt *memento mori*," then, he's suggesting that to realize one's physicality is to realize one's mortality. Hans's ambivalent reaction to seeing Joachim's heart indicates his growing obsession with death as the key to understanding life.



It's Hans's turn next, and when he looks at his own skeleton on the viewing apparatus, he sees something no mortal should ever see: "his own grave." Behrens, noting Hans's disturbed reaction, admits that the whole thing is a bit creepy. In no time, the exam is over, and Behrens switches the lights back on. In the end, Behrens had been able to see both the old, healed spots on Hans's lungs and the new ones. Hans confirms this, having seen the **X-ray** plates himself. And that settles it: he will take his rest cures, monitor his temperature, and wait until he gets better.

As odd as it is to accept Joachim's mortality, it's even more horrifying for Hans to look at his X-rayed body in the viewing apparatus and see "his own grave," looking at his internal organs and realizing that he will die. Hans's remark that no mortal should see "his own grave" drives at the idea of death anxiety, a concept present in Freudian psychoanalytic theory. Hans's remark that no mortal should see their own grave, points to the self-destructive nature of fixating on death—the very thing Hans has been doing ever since he arrived at the Berghof, though he fails to make the connection.



PART 5, CHAPTER 3: FREEDOM

Time passes, and eventually it's October, a fact Hans hears Hermine Kleefeld announce to some of the other residents, noting that this will be her second October at the Berghof. Depressed at having been "cheated out of life," she demands that Rasmussen, another resident, tell her a joke. Rasmussen knows some jokes but is too tired to tell them. Settembrini, having overheard this exchange too, laughs at Hermine's complaining—they all love the life of loafing they live here, Settembrini insists. He cautions Hans to be aware of all the irony that flourishes at the sanatorium.

Settembrini calls out Hermine Kleefeld's irony to warn Hans that Hans, like Hermine, will become aimless and in denial about it if he stays at the Berghof too long. Settembrini's warning about irony is itself a bit ironic, though, given that Settembrini isn't exactly setting a great example for Hans despite his claims to the contrary. For all of Settembrini's advice to leave the Berghof and live a productive life back in the real world, Settembrini doesn't seem all that motivated to leave the Berghof himself. He is a walking contradiction, preaching rationality yet behaving irrationally.



Hans is somewhat glad that Settembrini has continued to talk to and teach him, but he's increasingly resistant to the man's lessons and doubts the meaningfulness of everything he has to say. Now, he defends Hermine against Settembrini's criticisms—she's quite ill, Hans argues, and surely has every right to complain. Settembrini has no patience for "despair," though—it, and illness, are both forms of "depravity." Hans can't accept this—he's more convinced that illness is caused by depravity or can at least lead to it. All the same, Hans takes in what Settembrini has said—he thinks it's a bit similar to Krokowski's ideas about love.

Hans, ever the stubborn youth, continues to disregard Settembrini's well-intentioned advice. Settembrini's impatience for "despair" stems from its inherent self-indulgence. As Settembrini sees it, to despair (or rather, to suffer) is to attach meaning and significance to illness or misfortune. It's irrational to despair and wallow in self-pity over something like illness, over which is which a person has no control. Settembrini considers despair a "depravity" because its passive nature puts it at odds with his humanist ideals of progress and potential.



Settembrini voices his disapproval of Krokowski. While Settembrini isn't fully against analysis, he thinks it can be bad when people misuse it. He compares it to enlightenment ideals: it can disprove bad personal biases and liberate people, but it can also "prevent[] action, and damage[] life at its roots." In this way, concludes Settembrini, analysis is quite like death.

Settembrini condemns psychoanalysis for the same reason he condemns despair: both "prevent[] action, and damage[] life at its roots." He seems to suggest that psychoanalysis can be a good thing if people use its findings to realize their biases and improve their behavior, but people can also fail to translate these abstract findings about their inner selves into direct action. He also seems to take issue with psychoanalysis's central claim that humans are fundamentally ill: that they have mysterious, repressed urges that resist rational explanation.



Hans tells Settembrini about the nodules that Behrens saw on his **X-ray** the other day. Settembrini says something derogatory about the director, and Hans accuses him of being unfair to Behrens. After all, the man is working to alleviate suffering and help humankind. Settembrini merely chuckles and says it's time they take their rest cures. Settembrini takes his rest cure with others on the rooftop, and he mentions now that Russian residents—male and female—join him there. Hans, inwardly, wonders if Settembrini knows what's going on between him and Clavdia, and he gets upset at the older man for being so nosy.

Hans, still annoyed at Settembrini, returns to his room and writes a letter to his favorite of his uncles, James Tienappel, telling him to inform the consul that Hans will have to stay at the Berghof for longer than expected—perhaps through the winter—and to make arrangements for some of his personal effects to be sent there. As Hans writes the letter, he wonders why he put the task off for so long. After all, it has granted him his “freedom.”

Hans, in emphasizing Behrens's efforts to alleviate suffering and improve humankind, appeals to Settembrini's humanist sensibilities. He implies that Settembrini ought to like Behrens, since his work supports values that are important to Settembrini. Hans makes a valid point here, and this exchange also gestures toward one of Settembrini's flaws: he doesn't necessarily act on the abstract ideals he believes in. Settembrini, as a humanist, believes that humans should actively work to reach their full potential, and yet he remains at the Berghof, as passive as anyone else.



Hans's realization that confirming his stay at the Berghof has granted him is “freedom” gives insight into his main reason for wanting to remain there. Hans wants to live with the freedom he believes illness gives a person: the freedom to behave poorly and irrationally, behavior he's observed and envied in Herr Albin first and Clavdia Chauchat later.



PART 5, CHAPTER 4: MERCURY'S MOODS

The first few days of October are cold and gloomy, but then the weather turns summery again. Hans feels as though he has a whole summer ahead of him. He fails to notice the many trees that have already shed their leaves. But Hans's observations are just as capricious and fleeting as his body temperature, which is simultaneously “chilled and feverish.” These days he exists in a fog and can't imagine what it'd feel like to be “sober” again. He loves to look at Clavdia, not because she is particularly beautiful, but because she increases this foggy in him.

As Hans looks at Clavdia, he considers her poor manners and slovenly appearance, and he thinks about what Settembrini said about sickness and depravity being the same thing. Surely Clavdia is sick—she's here so often, after all—and so her illness must be “of a moral nature.”

The Berghof's indeterminate seasons reflect and add to the mysterious and inconsistent way that time passes there. They also mirror the directionless nature of life for many of the Berghof's residents as they remain stuck in a state of limbo between life and death. Hans's experience of being both “chilled and feverish,” meanwhile, represents the general ambivalence and passivity with which he approaches his life. He is neither saddened (“chilled”) nor angry (“feverish”) about his current situation. Instead, he exists in a “fog” somewhere in between.



Hans, drawing on what he's learned from listening to Settembrini and Krokowski, speculates that Clavdia's physical illness might be caused by some inner, “moral” flaw. Nevertheless, he continues to pursue her, suggesting that this illness “of a moral nature” may be what attracts him to her in the first place.



Yet Hans has started to feel less offended by Clavdia's brand of bad manners—now, it's Settembrini who most irritates him. Yes, the people at the Bad Russian table might not have great table manners, but what right has anyone to lay down a divide between good and bad? Gradually, Hans starts to experiment with poor manners himself. When he slumps over at meals, he finds that it actually feels quite good in his belly. And when he lets the door to the dining hall slam shut behind him without latching it properly, he finds that it's rather convenient. But all these changes really show, the narrator points out, is that Hans has fallen in love with Clavdia, falling into a “reckless and unpolished” type of love that confounds and “degrad[es]” Hans.

Hans feels a great thrill whenever Clavdia merely says “merci” when he lets her walk through a doorway before him. Another time, he adjusts a window in the dining hall so that the sun doesn't shine so brightly on Clavdia, who silently thanks him from across the hall once he has returned to his seat. These events might seem ordinary and inconsequential, but they convey a broader motion of “tension and of gratifying release of tension”—though it remains unclear if they affect Clavdia as deeply as they affect Hans.

One day, while Hans is sitting outside with Joachim, he sees Clavdia sitting across the way, smoking a cigarette. Wanting to make her jealous, he begins chatting with Hermine Kleefeld—but his plan backfires when Clavdia responds with defiant indifference. Flustered, Hans takes Joachim up on his suggestion that they retire to their rooms for a rest cure. After this, Clavdia ignores Hans for two whole days. On the third day, the weather is nice, and so Joachim and Hans go outside to take a stroll. During the walk, Hans sees Clavdia on the path ahead of them. Hans deliberately walks faster. When he reaches her, he says good morning, and she replies in her own language, with happy and receptive eyes.

Hans returns to Joachim, who didn't bother to run ahead with him. Joachim, looking annoyed, tells Hans he looks flushed and that his temperature is probably raised again. But Hans remains overjoyed, even when he returns to his room and finds that Joachim was right—his temperature is 100.4 degrees.

In the novel, Settembrini represents humanist ideals of personal liberty, progress, and rationality. Clavdia, meanwhile, with her Russian background, represents sensuality and irrational passion. Given all this, the fact that Hans is now gravitating away from Settembrini and toward Clavdia signals that Hans is also embracing her values, which the book frames as destructive. Though Hans is theoretically staying at the Berghof to get well, he ironically may leave there worse off than when he arrived.



Hans pursues Clavdia as passively and unproductively as he pursues just about everything else in life. The “tension and gratifying release of tension” that characterizes his attempts at flirtation mimics his confused and contradictory attitude toward life in general.



It's notable that this passage emphasizes Clavdia's eyes. Hans has repeatedly compared Clavdia's eyes to those of Hippe, the boy for whom he developed an irrational obsession as a child. Hans relates the distinct, slanted shape of both characters' eyes to their Eastern origins. When he focuses on Clavdia's eyes in this scene, then, it reinforces that Hans is most attracted to Clavdia's “Eastern” traits, which in the book amounts to her idleness, her decadence, and her irrationality, to name a few traits.



Joachim, unlike Hans, has maintained his composure, his sense of duty, and his rationality all throughout his time at the Berghof. He has not let his irrational crush on Marusya, for instance, lose sight of the responsibilities “down below” that he aspires to return to. Hans's irrational crush on Clavdia raises his temperature, and this reinforces the self-destructive nature of the romance.



PART 5, CHAPTER 5: ENCYCLOPEDIA

Hans is obvious about his crush on Clavdia, and soon everyone around the Berghof knows about it. There's not much to do at the sanatorium other than measure one's temperature, and so romances—and gossiping about romances—are common. It's difficult for Hans to find excuses to cross paths with Clavdia, so he looks forward to the mail distribution, which takes place every Sunday and which Hans looks forward to as a chance to socialize with her. However, he ultimately decides not to act on any opportunity, should it arise, limiting himself merely to fantasizing about it.

One Sunday, as Hans waits for Joachim, who has gone off to check whether there's mail waiting for either of them, he runs into Settembrini. Though in his dreams Settembrini often appears as a nuisance, in waking life Hans feels ashamed of his unconscious self's rudeness and is even grateful to run into the older man. Settembrini asks after Hans's health and then makes a few jokes about Russians, veiled allusions to Hans's crush. Hans laughs—something Settembrini never does. Settembrini then asks if Hans has received a copy of his **X-ray** yet, and Hans dutifully produces a picture from his wallet. Settembrini dubiously exams the image, which he calls Hans's "passport," suggesting that it's not unambiguous proof of Hans's illness.

Settembrini goes on, expressing disapproval that Hans is fine with wasting so much time here at the Berghof. He says such behavior is "foreign to [Hans's] nature" as a young person, indicating that it's unnatural to not want to seize life. He advises that Hans speak his own "civilized European" language and not let the "great deal of Asia" that dominates the atmosphere of the sanatorium influence his thoughts. He shouldn't be tempted by Asiatic values, especially their laziness. He thinks this carefree attitude toward life is what makes patients of this background feel so at home at the Berghof. Instead, Hans should embrace the humanist project of putting his time toward progress and the betterment of humanity. Hans finds Settembrini's moralizing rather annoying, but he keeps his thoughts to himself and lets Settembrini pull him out of the mail room to preach to him in private.

The book has established Hans's passivity as one of his defining traits. It's fitting, then, that he chooses not to act on his crush on Clavdia, limiting himself to dreams and fantasy.



The tension between Hans's dreams and his reality underscores his characteristic ambivalence, which goes hand in hand with his passivity. He feels torn between respecting and resenting Settembrini, and as a result he neither fully accepts nor rejects Settembrini as a mentor. It's also notable that Hans is now carrying his copy of his X-ray in his wallet, treating it almost as a surrogate ID card—Settembrini seems to acknowledge this, referring to the X-ray as Hans's "passport." This indicates that Hans now sees his illness as a core part of his identity, placing exaggerated significance on illness despite Settembrini's warnings against doing so.



Settembrini's language here is deliberate: he says it's "foreign to [Hans's] nature" to not want to seize life, implying that some "foreign" influence (i.e., someone who isn't a "civilized [Western] European" has corrupted Hans and caused him to become directionless and lazy. In effect, he's suggesting that Hans is letting his crush on Clavdia distract him from more important things. It could even be that Clavdia is motivating Hans's choice to stay at the Berghof more than Hans even realizes at the moment. Settembrini's advice to Hans not to waste his youth falls on deaf ears, however, as Hans disregards everything Settembrini tries to tell him. Hans's outright dismissal of Settembrini reflects his youthful obstinance and naivety.



Once they are out of the mail room, Settembrini pulls a package out of his jacket and hands Hans a flyer containing official letterhead for the “International League for the Organization of Progress,” of which Settembrini is a member. He tells Hans that this organization is “its own self-perfection.” It’s comprised of members from France, Italy, Spain, Turkey, and some from Germany. Members are invested in education, overcoming class struggle, and general social improvement. They have established local chapters across Europe and are in the process of writing *Sociological Pathology*, an encyclopedia that will catalogue different kinds of human suffering, the chemicals that cause them, and possible methods of eliminating such suffering. Settembrini’s job in all this is to write a separate volume about human suffering in literature.

Hans congratulates Settembrini on being chosen to do such important work. Settembrini says it’s especially fortunate that he can do so at the sanatorium—something that’s not an option for Hans, who is a physical laborer and can only do his work “in the world below.” Because of this, Settembrini cautions Hans, Hans “can be a European only in the flatlands.” He thinks that Hans should leave the Berghof. Hans, taken aback, says this is simply not possible anymore, given his illness. And it’s hypocritical of Settembrini to suggest this, given that he doesn’t dare disobey Behrens’s orders to stay at the sanatorium until he’s fully healed. Hans lashes out at Settembrini, demanding to know why Settembrini—a self-declared humanist—hates the body so much.

Settembrini, seemingly both amused and disappointed by Hans’s accusation, says that while he has nothing against the body in general, as a humanist and proponent of rationality, he has come to loathe the human mind’s necessary attachment to the debased physical body. To further illustrate his point, he brings up the 1755 Lisbon earthquake, of which Voltaire “rose up against,” meaning he “protested” the awesome force of nature that had brought so much destruction upon humanity. Nature is like the body, explains Settembrini: one must respect it when it perpetuates beauty, freedom, and happiness—but one must fight against it when it brings about illness, death, suffering, and base lust. Before Hans can respond to what Settembrini has said, Joachim appears with their mail, interrupting the exchange.

The encyclopedia Settembrini is working on aims to understand suffering in order to eradicate it. Yet there is a fundamental irony to his project, which takes the rational task of empirical research to such an extreme—is it rational to believe that all suffering can be eradicated?—that it becomes absurdly irrational. Although the novel decidedly casts Settembrini and his Western ideals in a more positive light than, say, Clavdia Chauchat, it also points out his shortcomings. Settembrini’s steadfast belief in rationality as a means toward enlightenment ironically causes him to misunderstand the world.



Settembrini has previously hinted that Hans needs to leave the Berghof, but he’s failed to get through to the stubborn youth. Now he directly orders Hans to leave the Berghof, re-enter “the flatlands” below, and do his part to improve society. Hans is justified in accusing Settembrini of hypocrisy: it does seem that Settembrini isn’t quite acting on the advice he gives Hans. One can hardly consider living at the Berghof and going on long, self-indulgent tangents about humanism to be a particularly productive, meaningful use of one’s time.



Hans’s accusation that Settembrini loathes the human body is either a deliberate or a misguided interpretation of Settembrini’s beliefs. As Settembrini clarifies here, he doesn’t hate the body for its sinful, debased nature. Nor does he hate the body all the time. Instead, he hates that the body’s physicality limits the human mind’s potential. If humans were not made of flesh—that is, if they were immortal—then they could theoretically go on living and learning and improving forever. But the body’s physicality—its vulnerability to pain and illness and decay—limits the mind’s capacity to progress and succeed.



PART 5, CHAPTER 6: HUMANIORA

After dinner one October afternoon, Hans and Joachim sit away from the others in the garden. Hans is a little annoyed that Joachim doesn't want to sit near the others, but he's smoking a **Maria Mancini**—he's since been able to enjoy the taste of them once more—so he's not too upset. Just then, Behrens approaches the cousins. He inquires about Hans's cigar, and then he and Hans exchange brands. They talk a bit about cigars and cigarettes, and then Hans asks Behrens about his occasional painting hobby. Behrens admit that he's painted a couple portraits. Hans says he'd like to see the doctor's work. Behrens happily offers to show Hans what he's done and invites Hans and Joachim over to see his paintings.

Behrens's quarters are furnished in the "Turkish" style. His paintings mostly consist of landscapes, though there are several portraits of his late wife. Finally, Hans finds what he's been looking for: Behrens's portrait of Clavdia. Hans casually mentions that he recognizes the portrait's subject. He and Joachim study the painting. Clavdia looks a bit older in the painting than she is in real life. Her coloring isn't quite right, and Behrens's rendition has also "coarsened" her features. They discuss Frau Chauchat and Behrens's inability to quite capture her character—while he's intimately familiar with her insides from examining her as a physician, her outside confounds him. Noting her "slanted and slit" eyes, Behrens declares her a "titillating little mystery." He also mentions that the beautiful, external female form is really made up of fat. Hans praises Behrens's ability to distinguish between the "medical" and the "lyrical."

Hans goes on a long tangent about all humanistic professions being about the beauty of the human form, when it comes down to it. He praises portraiture as a superior art form and suggests that the portrait of Clavdia might look better hung above Behrens's sofa. He's not at all self-conscious about his unprompted, long-winded spiel. After, Hans and Joachim follow Behrens into his kitchen, where the doctor brews Turkish coffee for the three of them.

Hans's renewed ability to enjoy his Maria Mancinis signals that he has fully adjusted to life as a Berghof resident. The cigars tasted awful his first days there because he was still adjusting to the place physically and mentally. Now, though, he's gotten used to the higher elevation and to the laid-back, aimless quality of life there, and the good taste of the cigar reflects that. Hans has a secret motive for asking Behrens about his painting hobby: he wants to see Behrens's portrait of Clavdia firsthand.



Behrens's "Turkish" furnishings signify his "Eastern" sensibilities. Given the book's portrayal of characters with Eastern backgrounds, the style of Behrens's living quarters evokes a sense of foreboding. Behrens's medical background affects the way he regards the human body. Though he can appreciate the aesthetic appeal of the female form, that appreciation is rooted in his knowledge about the biological matter—fat—that creates that beauty. His work as a doctor has given him a detached, frank attitude toward the body and toward life in a more general sense.



Despite Hans's frequent resentment of Settembrini, he often imitates his occasional mentor, going off on lofty (albeit naïve and underinformed) tangents about subjects that Settembrini has lectured about. This dissonance is yet another instance in which Hans's characteristic ambivalence is on full display.



Hans changes the subject, asking Behrens about human skin. He explains that he's very interested in the human body in general. In fact, he might have become a doctor or a clergyman, had his life circumstances not led him to become an engineer. Behrens, intrigued, describes the skin's primary function as dispelling danger. He talks about how a person's expanding blood vessels cause them to blush when they're embarrassed. On the other hand, when a person sees something physically beautiful, their blood vessels shrink, causing their skin to appear pale and feel cold. Behrens explains that scientists theorize that all psychological responses are geared toward protecting the body.

Hans eagerly asks Behrens to expand on his earlier mention of the lymphatic system, and Behrens obliges. Hans exclaims at how interesting he finds all this—"the formation of breast milk...the lymph of the legs." He pleads with Behrens to tell him what the body is made of. Behrens replies that Hans will be disappointed to know the body is mostly water—and the parts of it that aren't water are mostly "egg white, or protein," with a bit of fat and salt thrown in, too.

Behrens then talks about the protein that causes rigor mortis, a phenomenon Hans happily admits being familiar with. Hans then muses that a person interested in life is really interested in death. Behrens disagrees, though, noting that there is a difference: life is about "retain[ing]" a form, whereas death isn't. Behrens teases Hans for his exuberance today. Then he excuses himself, explaining that he's begun to feel rather melancholy. Once alone, Joachim admits that Hans's idea to talk to Behrens at least changed up their schedule a bit.

PART 5, CHAPTER 7: RESEARCH

Winter arrives, and its intensity alarms Hans even though he has sufficiently prepared for it—he now has a sleeping bag to shield him from the cold, just like all the other residents of the Berghof. Eventually Hans realizes that he'll be spending Christmas here, and the thought troubles him. Residents take Christmas very seriously, putting lots of thought into the communal gift they plan to give to Behrens on Christmas Eve. Settembrini suggests a book-in-progress called *Sociology of Suffering*, but nobody other than a bookseller resident agrees with him. As of yet, the residents haven't reached a consensus, with the Russian residents wanting to give Behrens a gift of their own.

Behrens suggests a direct link between bodily function and human emotion, similar to the relationship Krokowski described in his lecture earlier. The bodily functions that Behrens notes here match some of the symptoms Hans has experienced when he's around Clavdia, so when Behrens describes such responses as the body's attempt to protect itself, it perhaps foreshadows the danger that Hans's infatuation over Clavdia poses to Hans.



Hans's sudden interest in biology and human anatomy seems somewhat to contradict his earlier disapproval of Behrens's frank, detached attitude toward illness and dying—an attitude that Hans felt dishonored life and humanity. This scene thus further illustrates Hans's characteristic ambivalence, which in turn emphasizes his youth and naivety: he's still highly impressionable, and he doesn't have the conviction or experience to commit to any particular ideals, however enthusiastically he may latch on to them initially.



Hans here implies a connectedness between life and death, an opinion he seems to have formed from Settembrini, though at the time he disagreed with Settembrini's position. This scene further highlights Hans's inability to commit to any one way of looking at life, death, or the world in general. His attitude shifts depending on whose company he's in.



Hans's apprehension about spending Christmas at the Berghof further illustrates his characteristic ambivalence. Sometimes he seems in no hurry to leave and return to his real life "down below," but other times he seems guilty or anxious to be wasting so many months of his youth recovering at the Berghof. The detail of the Berghof's Russian population not cooperating with the other residents and opting to give Behrens a gift of their own reinforces the tension between Eastern culture and Western culture that the novel has established thus far.



Despite the toll the intense cold takes on his body, Hans stays out on his balcony late into the night, enjoying the winter night. During the day, Hans and Joachim take walks in the snow, and Hans is more prone to indulgent rambling than he was when he was down in the flatlands.

Lots of residents read at the Berghof, though it's mostly new or short-term residents, since people who've been there a long time have long since learned how to pass the time without intellectual stimulation. Currently, a pamphlet that Herr Albin introduced to the population, *The Art of Seduction*, is circulating among the residents. Magnus, the brewer resident, claims that the book gives women "immodest ideas," and this only makes the book more coveted. But other than Settembrini (who consumes himself with writing about how to eliminate suffering) and Joachim (who studies his Russian textbooks), most residents don't use their rest cures to exercise their brains.

Hans, having lost interest in *Ocean Steamships*, the only book he packed, acquires new books about anatomy and biology, his new primary interests. He spends hours reading about the mystery of life. Ultimately, the books teach Hans that nobody knows what life really is or where it comes from—it seems to be born of itself. But since that would be a "miracle," scientists hypothesize about organic matter originating from inorganic matter—the most basic and lifeless of all substances.

Life, Hans muses, is warmth: it is the warmth that happens as the physical body tries to "preserve form." This process, he reflects, is "existence in its lewd form." It is not the ideal, beautiful form found in works of visual art and poetry. Instead, it is that which comes from "substances awakened to lust via means unknown, by decomposing and composing organic matter itself, by reeking flesh." Hans thinks about all this as he sits on his balcony, wrapped tightly in his blankets, and gazes out upon the wintery night that lays before him.

Hans's choice to lie out on his balcony despite the cold's negative effects on his body is yet another instance in which he acts—and apparently consciously so—against his self-interest. If he's wary about spending the holidays at the Berghof, one wonders, then why would he do something he knows will take a toll on his health and almost certainly extend his recovery?



The fact that so few residents seek out intellectual stimulation reinforces the sanatorium's atmosphere of idleness and decadence. It also supports Settembrini's warning to Hans that an unhealthy fixation with death and illness is ultimately self-destructive, in this case leading to intellectual decay.



In this chapter, Hans begins his coming-of-age journey in earnest, absorbing himself in books to try to discover the meaning of life. Of course, the irony is that Hans's careful study of life replaces the lived experience of life.



Hans's idea that the physical body tries to "preserve form" isn't quite original: it's more or less what Behrens said to him in the previous chapter. While Hans seems to regard his research and his philosophical musings as serious intellectual work, he's really just parroting what other people have told him, shifting his views with each new idea he encounters. His inability to formulate original thought further illustrates his youth and inexperience.



Hans pores over textbooks about asexual and sexual reproduction, about the mysteries of certain anatomical processes, and about pathological anatomy. He reads about “parasitic cell fusion and infectious tumors,” and about how they take over formerly healthy, functioning bodies. Hans comes to wonder if life is merely “an infectious disease of matter” itself. “The first step toward evil, toward lust and death,” Hans muses, comes about when an outside source—a parasite—takes hold of the body. It happens when the inorganic becomes organic, which is really just “the sad progression of corporeality into consciousness.” And this, Hans notes, is no different than a disease taking hold of a living being and making it hyperaware of “its own corporeality.”

The weight of these heavy textbooks on Hans’s chest as he reads them makes it difficult for him to breathe. He imagines a personified version of his own life facing him while he reads, her arms parting to reveal the intricate anatomical systems hidden beneath her flesh. He smells her organic smell, and he feels a mixture of “lust and dismay” as she kisses him on his lips.

The more Hans reads about anatomy and biology, the less he is able to consider life apart from its relation to illness and death. In this way he devalues life, seeing it as pointless: as merely a rest stop on the way to corruption, illness, and death. When Hans describes the process by which a disease makes a sick being hyperaware of “its own corporeality,” he seems to embrace Settembrini’s understanding of illness. In that view, illness has no meaning or value in itself: it merely serves to reveal the tragic but inevitable limitations of the physical body.



The “lust” Hans feels toward this personified version of his own life before him, her organic smell suggesting the decay of flesh, indicates his growing attraction to death as the path toward understanding life. Yet the “dismay” he also feels suggests that he registers, at least on some level, the self-destructive nature of this pursuit.



PART 5, CHAPTER 8: DANSE MACABRE

Behrens’s son, Knut, comes to visit him over the holidays, and all the ladies dress well, each hoping to capture his attention. Hans and Joachim do what they can to avoid Knut and the university friends he brought with him. The holidays don’t alter the sanatorium’s daily schedule much, though a tree materializes inside the dining hall, and by Christmas Eve it has been decorated with tinsel and glass ornaments. People dress up for dinner that night, too, and even the perpetually casual Clavdia arrives dressed in a Russian-style gown. Settembrini dresses as he normally does.

After dinner, the residents present their gifts to Behrens. The Russians give him a monogrammed silver plate, the uselessness of which is obvious to everyone. The other residents give him a chaise longue, which is at least a functional piece of furniture. On Christmas Day, a local professional singer comes to the sanatorium and gives a performance followed by singing lessons. Clavdia sits in the front row but leaves during intermission and doesn’t return afterward. Hans struggles to focus after her departure. Settembrini attends but makes ironic, teasing remarks about the performance.

Clavdia’s “Russian” gown implicitly links her sensuality with her Eastern sensibilities. Settembrini’s choice to dress as he normally does despite it being a holiday, meanwhile, emphasizes his rationality and his rejection of decadence of frivolous, superficial acts of celebration.



The uselessness of the silver plate gestures toward the decadence and irrationality the book associates with Eastern culture. Of course, the irony is that the chaise longue the other residents have gifted Behrens is a decidedly ornamental, useless piece of furniture: it’s hardly more functional than the Russians’ silver plate. The uselessness of both gifts points to the pointless, decadence that characterizes life at the Berghof: residents are so unaccustomed to making productive, practical use of their time that they can’t even recognize the uselessness of their gifts.



The Austrian horseman dies shortly after Christmas. Hans is especially struck by the death because the horseman's cough was one of the first "signs of life" he heard when he first came to the Berghof. He required lots of costly treatment at the end of his life, the expense of which left his widow penniless. Joachim scoffs at this, feeling it was pointless of the man to try to stave off death in vain. Hans disagrees, feeling that Joachim—like Settembrini—is failing to honor suffering. When Hans tries to talk about the man's death with his tablemates, they respond with hostility, finding it inappropriate of him to discuss such a grim subject.

After the Austrian horseman dies, Hans and Joachim visit the man's room and find his widow there, disheveled and grieving, beside her late husband's corpse. Hans strikes up a conversation with the widow, attempting to showcase "both medical expertise and moral, religious sympathy," about her late husband's years of suffering and illness. The woman cries sporadically throughout the conversation. When the woman asks Hans what his profession is, he replies that he "had been" an engineer, prompting a shocked and upset look from Joachim.

After they leave the widow, Hans reflects on how the conversation affected him. He argues that talking about death requires a person to use Latin—the religious sort of Latin that's directly at odds with Settembrini's humanist intellectual tradition. Hans, citing the play *Don Carlos*, talks about King Philip's fear of God and his humility. He thinks these traits highlight a dignified form of humanity. At the same time, though, calling something "human" can also be bad in that it justifies laziness or weakness. Joachim, ever the disciplined military man, expresses his hatred of both traits. Hans agrees that the self-discipline, respect for authority, and acceptance of death are positive features of Joachim's profession. He thinks more civilians should have these traits—traits Hans himself lacks.

Hans takes the Austrian horseman's death poorly. His efforts to talk about the death with Joachim and his tablemates reveal that he still has lingering anxieties about illness and death despite his earlier attempts to form a detached, frank attitude toward illness, death, and the physical body in general. Hans seems to believe that a failure to honor suffering, death, and illness renders life itself meaningless, and he struggles to accept that his fellow residents don't feel the same.



Comically, Hans seems to be more focused showing off all the deep thinking he's recently done on the subjects of life, death, and morality than on grieving openly with the Austrian horseman's widow and honoring death. Also of importance here is Hans's use of the past tense—he "had been" an engineer—to describe his life in the lowlands. Though he's only been at the Berghof for several months now, he already seems to no longer relate to (or believe he'll return to) his old life.



Hans now turns to religion to understand death, marking a major shift in his earlier efforts to understand death through science. Hans's perpetually changing views emphasize his youth. Meanwhile, his praise of Joachim's self-discipline and acceptance of death seem to be genuine; and indeed, the book seems to portray these traits of Joachim's in a positive light, as well. Joachim, unlike most other residents at the Berghof, acts in accordance with his beliefs, not only talking about his duty to return to his military service but actually taking steps to make that happen, dutifully recording his temperature, resting, and studying Russian language textbooks in the meantime to ensure that he's prepared when (if) he's finally allowed to return to his service.



Hans shifts his focus to Settembrini, critiquing the man for believing his humanist understanding of humanity is the only dignified way to think about life. Just before Hans and Joachim part ways to retreat to their separate rooms, Hans condemns the sanatorium's practice of hiding death (staff will likely remove the Austrian horseman's body from the premises while everyone is eating supper) as "immoral." Hans decides that from this day forth he'll start being more attentive to the more severely ill residents of the Berghof, even if it means just saying hello or stopping to chat for a few moments. Joachim answers that this would be against the rules, though he doesn't have much of an issue with it. He also thinks Behrens would make an exception if Hans explained his idea to him.

Hans, in condemning the sanatorium's practice of removing dead bodies discreetly as "immoral," attaches great underlying meaning to a procedure that the sanatorium most likely has in place for practical reasons—it would be upsetting and disruptive to cart out corpses in the middle of the day when the facility is bustling with the goings-on of daily life. In this way, Hans shows that he's more concerned about abstract ideals than on concrete, practical reality. His new plan to visit severely ill patients, on the other hand, could function to match Hans's abstract ideals about dignifying death with the practical action of treating the dying with dignity, though it remains to be seen whether Hans's plan will achieve the results he wants it to or will become just another of his passing fancies.



Hans sets his sights on a young woman named Leila Gerngross, who is deathly ill and likely won't live until next spring. Her parents had arrived at the Berghof wanting to take Leila home, but Behrens told them it simply couldn't be done—she's too fragile. Hans walks into town and buys her a potted hydrangea and attaches a card to it, sending his and Joachim's regards. Leila is overjoyed to receive the gift and takes great care to keep it watered and healthy. The next day, Hans and Joachim visit Leila in her "chamber of suffering." The thin, blonde girl thanks them for her gift. Hans speaks to the girl gently and emotionally, making polite conversation with Leila's parents.

Hans project of visiting the Berghof's most seriously ill patients is an improvement from his earlier efforts at dignifying death. After all, instead of ignoring death, he is actually acknowledging it.



Hans and Joachim get up to leave after Leila shows signs of exhaustion, and Frau Gerngross follows them out. Beside herself, she laments being the one who made her daughter ill: she had a mild case of the disease when she was a young girl but was told she'd fully recovered. Apparently, she laments now, that was not the case. She thanks Hans and Joachim for acting as "a nice little flirt for [Leila]" to help her forget the suffering that otherwise characterizes her sickly existence. The mother's response to Hans's attempt at dignifying the sick leaves him feeling disappointed and a bit annoyed.

Frau Gerngross's description of Hans and Joachim's visit to Leila as flirtation annoys Hans because it devalues the serious work he was trying to do. Frau Gerngross is suggesting that the visit didn't dignify Leila's suffering but in fact distracted Leila from her impending death. Ironically, Hans's annoyance at hearing that he effectively cheered Leila up reveals that his supposed plan to dignify suffering is more for himself than it is for the dignity and welfare of those who suffer.



Hans's next target is a young man named Fritz Rotbein, to whom Hans and Joachim hand deliver a bouquet of roses. The young man actually weeps out of gratitude—before shifting the conversation's focus to the thriving European flower business, talking of wholesale markets throughout the continent. He was a businessman, he explains, and got sick during a trip to England to undergo training. By the time his illness received the correct diagnosis, the infection had progressed too far. Rotbein tells all this to Hans and Joachim in a calm, businesslike manner. Before Hans and Joachim leave, Rotbein begs for them to visit him again. They say they will, but Rotbein undergoes an unsuccessful operation and then dies before they get the chance.

Hans and Joachim's visit to Fritz Rotbein further suggests the self-indulgent nature of Hans's supposed efforts to dignify suffering. All their visit really does is allow Hans to feel self-satisfied about making Rotbein weep with gratitude—delivering flowers to a sick person is more a display of good manners than a revolutionary approach to dignifying sickness and death. And what's more, the visit doesn't alter the outcome of Rotbein's suffering: he dies anyway, regardless of how "dignified" Hans made him feel in his final days.



After Leila Gerngross dies, Hans happens upon Behrens in the hallway. Behrens tells Hans he's on his way to visit "Lady Overblown" and asks if Hans would like to accompany him. Hans follows Behrens into the room of a nervous-seeming woman who laughs uncontrollably at everything Behrens says. After Behrens leaves, the woman and Hans chat. She notes his new practice of "visiting high-ranking patients." She laughs at his "amusing and kind" act.

"Lady Overblown," rather justifiably, characterizes Hans's ongoing mission to dignify suffering as "amusing and kind" rather than revolutionary or particularly beneficial to anyone. Her description undermines the seriousness of Hans's project and gestures toward its underlying childishness.



Then the Overblown Woman (whose real name is Frau Zimmermann) tells Hans the origins of Behrens's nickname for her, assuring him that it is terribly funny and laughing nonstop as she tells it. She'd been only slightly ill when she first arrived at the Berghof. She had a pneumothorax, and the procedure was immediately successful. Then she took a trip to Zurich, just for fun, during which she realized she needed an oxygen refill—and the doctor who performed it "had overblown her!" This resulted in her heart constricting and caused her to experience shortness of breath. When Frau Zimmermann returned to the Berghof, her condition was grave, and Behrens shouted that she was "literally hovering between life and death."

The Overblown Woman's story likely horrifies Hans as it exemplifies two ways of thinking about death and suffering that he disdains: an overemphasis on the physical body and its lightheartedness. Hans believes that suffering is a dignified state of being that people should acknowledge and regard with the utmost seriousness, and yet the Overblown Woman's frank, humorous account of her own past experiences with suffering challenges that narrative.



Hans isn't sure what about Behrens's remark Frau Zimmermann finds so funny—is it that she doesn't believe him, or is that she simply finds the fact of her "hovering between life and death" funny? Hans sends her flowers later, but he never meets with her again—she dies before he can.

When suffering patients fail to take their suffering as seriously as Hans thinks they ought to, he abandons them. This reveals the self-indulgence at the heart of his supposed mission to dignify suffering.



Sometime later, Settembrini confronts Hans about his recent "deeds of mercy." He calls Hans "one of life's problem children, a fellow whom others must look after." He reminds Hans that Hans once gave Settembrini permission to do just that—look after Hans and guide him in the right direction. He advises Hans to "let the dead bury their dead." Hans disregards Settembrini's perspective but outwardly makes a show of heeding his advice.

Settembrini's advice to Hans to "let the dead bury their dead" is a quote that Jesus speaks in the Gospel of Luke. It means to let the spiritually "dead" (nonbelievers) go about their business so that believers can focus on the more important work of serving God. In this context, Settembrini seems to be urging Hans to not care so much about dignifying the dead and to instead focus his energy on living a good, meaningful life. But Hans, seemingly feeling that Settembrini is condescending to him when he describes Hans as "one of life's problem children," stubbornly rejects the older man's efforts to help him. It's clear that Hans hasn't matured all that much over the past several months.



Hans and Joachim also visit Tous-les-deux's son, Lauro, having first sent him flowers. But they find the young man's behavior gaudy, dramatic, and wholly unenjoyable, though they choose not to judge him for it. They do enjoy their visit with Anton Karlovitch Ferge, a Russian man recovering from a pneumothorax that almost killed him. During one visit, the young man recounts his grotesque experience of undergoing the procedure—the "filthy ordeal"—without anesthesia. He also tells them about his life in Russia prior to his stay at the Berghof. Overall, Hans and Joachim appreciate the man's frank, unaffected demeanor.

Hans also enjoys his visits to Karen Karstedt, one of Behrens's outpatients whom he recommended the cousins visit and go on outings with around Davos-Dorf, including bobsled races. They also see a performance at the Bioscope Theater in Platz, watching a performance of an obscene tale of lust that featured naked bodies and the portrayal of lewd, unadulterated desire. They also go to a cemetery on Dorfberg one day, despite Joachim's protests that they shield Karen from any reminders of her own mortality. They wander around the cemetery, noting the dates and names that adorn its various tombstones. Eventually they happen upon an unoccupied plot. When the cousins look at Karen, they find her smiling and looking "bashful and demure."

Hans's choice to continue visiting the Berghof's sickest residents confirms that he has disregarded Settembrini's advice, obstinately believing he knows better than his mentor. Meanwhile, Hans and Joachim's approval of Ferge's frank, casual attitude toward his horrific medical history reveals an almost morbid but delighted fascination with death. Increasingly, it seems more the case that Hans is paying visits to the sick to satisfy his own perverse curiosity than to perform any sort of public service to the dying.



The implication here is that Karen and the cousins have happened upon Karen's marked (and soon to be occupied, depending on how much longer she can stave off death) grave. Karen's "bashful and demure" smile, compared with the cousins' awkward, stunned silence suggests that, contrary to Hans's opinion, people who are suffering don't need his help to understand or come to terms with their own mortality: in fact, it's he who remains most perplexed and apprehensive about death.



PART 5, CHAPTER 9: WALPURGIS NIGHT

Time passes, and eventually Hans has been at the Berghof for seven months, and Joachim has been there for one year. Now, spring approaches—meaning it'll soon be time for Mardi Gras and Midsummer Night festivities. Settembrini, with satirical excitement, gushes about the festival's program, which features numerous "dances macabres." He laments the people who won't be able to join in on the late-night festivities, implying that they have rejected earthly pleasures. But Hans is genuinely looking forward to the festivities.

On Mardi Gras morning, the dining hall is filled with the sounds of toy instruments. People wear paper hats, and there's an overall festive air to the place. Most residents head to the Platz that afternoon to watch the carnival parade make its way down the streets. The festive mood continues into suppertime. People exchange notes with playful but cryptic little verses on them. Settembrini sends one to Hans that reads: "But bear in mind, the mountain's mad with spells tonight, / And should a will-o'-wisp decide your way to light, / Beware—its lead may prove deceptive."

Typically, midsummer, which has been observed since the Neolithic era, is held around the summer solstice and consists of feasting, dancing, and singing. Settembrini's mocking description of the festival's "dances macabres" comments on the irony of celebrating midsummer, which evokes ideas of rebirth and vitality, at a sanatorium full of dying patients. "Danse Macabre" refers to a medieval genre of art and literature that depicts the living and dead dancing together, representing the inevitable and equalizing force of death.



Mardi Gras is part of the Carnival celebration, which in the Western Christian tradition takes place before Lent. Carnival involves public feasts and parades and encourages participants to indulge in vices they'll have to give up during the impending Lenten season. The Berghof's Mardi Gras festivities will no doubt escalate the sanatorium's already indulgent, undisciplined atmosphere. Settembrini's note to Hans is playful, yet it also drives at his genuine concern for the impressionable, self-indulgent Hans.



Hans spots Clavdia from across the hall. She's wearing a sleeveless, silken black dress. Seeing Clavdia's fragile, pale arms against the black fabric causes Hans to involuntarily whimper to himself—the dress is somehow extremely revealing yet does not stir him. A bit later, another note appears for Hans, this one about lovesick bachelors and maids who want to marry. Later on, people start arriving in costumes: men dressed as women, and women dressed as men. Frau Stöhr, who wasn't initially wearing a costume, leaves the dining hall and reappears a short while later dressed as a cleaning woman, armed with a bucket and broom. Clavdia dons a paper hat, like the kind children make. Settembrini satirically warns Hans to beware of "Lilith," alluding to the first wife of Adam in the Bible. Hans, quite drunk at this point, laughs off Settembrini's warning.

Then Hans, made loose by lots of champagne and punch, addresses Settembrini with familiar pronouns and thanks him for all his guidance, apologizing for all the times he'd been a poor student—"one of life's problem children," as Settembrini once described him.

Meanwhile, Behrens and Krokowski also join in on the festivities. Across the dining hall, Behrens leads people in a parlor game in which participants are tasked with drawing a pig with their eyes closed. Of course, some of them wouldn't be able to do this even with their eyes open, and this results in the creation of truly horrendous creatures. Hans demands to join in on the fun and scowls with mock outrage when he's given only a stump of a pencil to draw with. The resultant "pig" is predictably awful, and he demands that someone give him a real pencil to draw with. From behind him, he hears a woman's voice call out in French, and he's suddenly transported back to the childhood schoolyard of his recurring dream.

Clavdia Chauchat appears behind Hans and tells him, in broken German, that he is "very ambitious [...] very...eager" before handing him a silver pencil-holder. Whereas the original pencil—the one Hippe handed him in elementary school—was practical and substantial, this device is useless and ornamental. Nevertheless, Hans thanks her, adding that he knew she'd have one. Clavdia and Hans bend their heads over the pencil and lean in toward each other, as though by a magnetic force. Hans abandons the parlor game and pulls up a seat next to Clavdia in one corner of the dining hall. They begin talking in German but switch to French, which Hans understands well enough.

The novel establishes Clavdia, dressed in a sensuous and revealing gown, as the temptation that Settembrini warned Hans about in his playful note and warns him about again with his allusion to the mythological figure of Lilith. Judaic and Mesopotamian mythology portrays Lilith, the first wife of Adam, as a demonic force of chaos and temptation. She's said to have been banished from the Garden of Eden after refusing to submit to Adam, though most conventional religious authorities reject her existence.



German (Hans's language and the language in which Thomas Mann wrote The Magic Mountain) differentiates between formal and familiar pronouns. Though contemporary German speakers don't place as much weight on formal vs. familiar pronoun usage, it would have been an offensive faux pas for Hans to address Settembrini, his elder, with familiar pronouns, so his usage of them here effectively shows Settembrini that he doesn't respect Settembrini or any of his advice.



The pig-drawing parlor game is little more than harmless, silly fun, yet it also drives home the pointlessness and superficiality of existence at the Berghof. Hans's mention of the childhood schoolyard of his recurring dream refers to his memory of borrowing the pencil from Hippe, the young boy of unspecified Eastern ancestry with whom Hans developed an irrational, extreme obsession. The woman's voice he hears now is likely Clavdia's.



Clavdia's pencil, which is decorative and impractical, underscores the irrationality of her character and of Hans's obsession with her. Like her pencil, Clavdia, with her dangerous Eastern sensibilities, cannot help Hans in any good, productive way. Nevertheless, he gravitates toward her as though under a spell—the spell of irrationality that the Berghof and the night's midsummer festivities have cast on him.



Clavdia notes that Joachim has since disappeared, and Hans remarks that Joachim is almost certainly in his room taking his rest cure. Clavdia thinks this is characteristic of Germans, who “love order more than liberty,” something she claims everyone in Europe knows to be true. Hans argues that Europe’s concept of “liberty” is in fact rather “bourgeois” compared to Germany’s love of order. Hans’s philosophizing amuses Clavdia.

Clavdia suggests that Hans’s bourgeois sensibilities—his love of law and order and pragmatism—are antithetical to personal liberty, which she implicitly links with indulgence and excess. She implies that obedient, duty-bound Joachim exemplifies these bourgeois sensibilities, though she considers his behavior characteristic of German people in general.



Clavdia and Hans try to dance, but there’s not quite enough room, so Hans suggests they just stand off to the side and watch, separate from everyone else as though they are in their own little dream. He admits that being here with Clavdia really is something of a dream to him. She calls him “a bourgeois, a humanist, and a poet,” which is “Germany all rolled into one.” They make a bit of small talk, but Hans can hardly speak French and struggles. Still, he prefers it this way—not speaking in his native tongue somehow makes this scene more dreamlike, less real.

Hans’s sense that he is in a dream suggests his ambivalence about his feelings for Clavdia. He seems to recognize his attraction to her as irrational and potentially self-destructive, and this is why he feels as if his present behavior is something out of a dream. Clavdia seems to recognize how out of character Hans’s boldness is, and this is why she mockingly teases him about his “bourgeois” sensibilities.



Hans suggests using informal pronouns with Clavdia—but just then Clavdia drops some big news—she’s leaving. Hans is shocked and taken aback. Clavdia clarifies: she’s leaving the Berghof tomorrow morning. She’s not fully cured, but Behrens doesn’t think there’s much more they can do for her here. Hans asks if she’ll be coming back, and she says she doesn’t know. She says she values freedom above all else, though—a feeling she doubts Hans can relate to. Anyway, Hans will likely be gone from here by the time she’d return, if things come to that.

Clavdia’s news about leaving the Berghof challenges Hans’s understanding of the relationship between freedom and illness. Before, he regarded Clavdia’s irrationality and disregard for social niceties as a form of freedom that her sickness afforded her, and his own decision to stay at the Berghof may have stemmed from a desire to achieve that sort of freedom himself. Now, though, he realizes that her freedom has nothing to do with her sickness.



Hans disagrees, insisting that he’s quite sick. He confirms that he has a “moist spot” in his lungs and had a fever of over 100 degrees this morning. Clavdia says her illness “is a little more complicated.” She then tells Hans that Joachim is more ill than he thinks. Hans asks if Joachim will die, but Clavdia merely responds that he likely will if he returns to his military service “on the plains.” Hans says death no longer scares him. And anyway, his own current condition—being in love—is just as severe as Joachim’s. Hans asks if he can see Clavdia’s “transparent portrait” (her **X-ray**), having already seen her “exterior portrait.” She says she keeps it locked away in her room.

Clavdia, in describing her illness as “a little more complicated” gestures toward the underlying, perhaps unconscious reasons why people stay at the Berghof—for a relief from the stresses of ordinary life, perhaps, or to find meaning or freedom they weren’t able to find elsewhere. Hans, in rather self-indulgently comparing his “illness” of being in love to Joachim’s physical illness, reveals that he still attaches inherent meaning and significance to physical illness. His request to see Clavdia’s X-ray underscores this point: he seems to believe that Clavdia’s “transparent portrait” will reveal some underlying excess of emotion and self-expression, when in reality it will just show the functionality of her lungs.



Then Hans changes the subject to morality and what Clavdia thinks about it. Clavdia replies that one learns nothing about morality from being virtuous or applying reason—instead, they must turn to sin and self-destruction. She thinks it's more moral to self-destruct "than to save oneself." She thinks that all history's great moralists have been quite sinful—meanwhile, they teach good Christians how to be miserable. She assumes her position shocks Hans.

Hans is silent a moment. The hall has mostly emptied by this point, with residents all returning to their rooms for the night. Hans reasserts his earlier pledge to use informal pronouns with Clavdia—to be formal is bourgeois, he insists. Then he tells Clavdia that nothing she's said about morality has alarmed him. He asks Clavdia what she thinks of him, and she replies, frankly, that he seems like an ordinary, well-mannered young man who comes from a respectable family. He'll soon leave the Berghof behind and return "to the flatlands" to live an honest life filled with honest work, and he'll forget all about the dream world he inhabited in the place up in the mountains.

Hans thinks Clavdia is oversimplifying things. If that's all there is to him, he asks, then where did his fever come from? Clavdia thinks Hans's illness is just a phase, but Hans insists it's more than that: he thinks that "love" has gotten him to where he is now. Beside himself with passion, Hans declares his deep and irrational love for Clavdia. Clavdia insists that he get ahold of himself—what would Settembrini say? But Hans insists that none of that matters. He could care less about time, or humanism, or progress, because he loves her.

Clavdia reaches out to touch the back of Hans's head, and he replies with a long declaration about the links between the physical body, love, and death: the body produces both love and death, both of which are "carnal," and both of which are simultaneously horrifying and beautiful. He declares physical passion to be "a festival of death with no weeping afterward," and he pleads with Clavdia to let him touch her arteries and tibia and inhale her pores' secretions. When he's finished, Clavdia pauses and tells him that he is "indeed a gallant suitor, one who knows how to woo in a very profound, German fashion." Then she places her paper hat on his head and bids him goodnight, predicting that he'll have a high fever when he checks his temperature tonight. Before she leaves, she tells him to remember to return her pencil.

Clavdia here establishes herself as the opposite of Settembrini: she does not find value in maximizing one's full potential, nor does she find value in reason. Her belief that it is better to sin and self-destruct "than to save oneself" gestures toward the type of freedom Hans associates with Clavdia and her supposedly Eastern sensibilities. Clavdia thinks that people should do things that bring them pleasure, even if this means sinning or breaking social norms.



Hans's insistence on using informal pronouns with Clavdia suggests his desperate attempts to shed his bourgeois sensibilities. He seems drawn toward Clavdia's rejection of conventional morality and social etiquette and the possibility of social freedom that comes with living this way—freedom his bourgeois sensibilities deny him. Despite Hans's efforts to seem open and unrepressed, though, Clavdia mockingly suggests that this is merely a phase—a side effect of the time he's spent at the Berghof. Once he leaves, he'll return home and resume the practical, virtuous life he led before coming to the sanatorium.



Clavdia—not incorrectly—implies that Hans's recently irrational, foolish behavior is merely a phase. Hans's rebuttal that his recent behavior is a side effect of love doesn't discredit Clavdia's point—lovesickness can indeed persuade people to behave irrationally and uncharacteristically.



Hans links desire with bodily function, noting the shared "carnal" nature of love and death to present love not as a beautiful expression of higher feeling but as intrinsically tied to the physical body. In so doing, he implicitly links being in love to being sick. A person cannot love—even chastely—without their physical body. Just as tuberculosis is an assault on the lungs, for instance, love is an assault on the parts of the body that inspire passion.



PART 6, CHAPTER 1: CHANGES

The narrator muses about the nature of time and change. Without time, there would be no change. But because we measure time as circular motion, then time's real change is "rest and stagnation," with what's happened in the past perpetually repeating into the future. These are the big ideas Hans considers, though he can't settle on any concrete answers.

Joachim, meanwhile, grows frustrated with his uncertain health, specifically the "Gaffky" scale used to measure residents' health and chances of recovery. Some patients who have come in horribly ill score an inconceivably low score, whereas others who seem hardly ill at all score high. Joachim himself was at a "two" two weeks ago, yet now he's a nine—and thus his chances of returning to the service are fading before his eyes. He declares that he's going to leave this place one way or another, even if it kills him. Joachim's obstinance makes Hans think about what Clavdia said about Joachim being sicker than he realizes, but he keeps these thoughts to himself. Ever since Mardi Gras, he's felt a bit guilty about not telling Joachim about his interaction with Clavdia, though he's sure Joachim knows the gist.

Now, it's been six weeks since Mardi Gras. Hans long ago returned Clavdia's pencil to her, though he asked for a personal effect in return. She gave him her **X-ray** image, which Hans now carries around in his wallet. She promised to return (or intended to, anyway), but she isn't sure when. Hans saw her step out of the sanatorium and into the carriage that was waiting for her. Like everyone else who leaves, she looked happy, just because leaving means that life will change—even if it's uncertain how. Though she is physically absent, she remains present in Hans's mind.

The narration continues to meditate on the tenuous and subjective nature of time, here reflecting on the challenges that humanity's organization of time into circular motion (the cycles of seasons) poses regarding change and the passage of time.



Joachim's frustration with the "Gaffky" scale gestures toward the meaningless and arbitrary nature of illness. He wants there to be some logic to his recovery—if he was a "two" two weeks ago, it should follow that he continues to improve, not suddenly shoot up to a "nine." But illness doesn't operate like a logical equation: it doesn't imbue a person's life with meaning, as Hans wants it to. And whether a person gets better has nothing to do with whether or not they actually get better, as Joachim wishes were the case. Hans hasn't told Joachim about his conversation with Clavdia, likely because he knows practical, driven Joachim would not approve. Hans's guilt at not telling Joachim illustrates Hans's characteristic ambivalence: he wants to be irrationally in love with Clavdia, yet he also seems to know that it's not good for him and that Joachim's judgment is warranted.



The fact that Hans carries Clavdia's X-ray image around in his wallet—the way a "normal" person might carry around a lover's normal, non-X-ray photo—reveals that his love for her is really a love for illness and a desire for freedom from social constraints.



As Clavdia sarcastically predicated, Hans's fever did indeed rise after their interaction. As a result, Behrens starts giving him injections. On one such occasion, Hans mentions to Behrens the foolish optimism of people who choose to leave the Berghof, casually citing Clavdia as an example. He doesn't know what the weather is like in Daghestan, where she said she was headed, but it can't be great for her health. Then he admits to becoming casually acquainted with her just before her departure, and how unfortunate it was that it had to happen then. He also admits that she had no interest in keeping in touch via letters. Behrens laughs, noting that Clavdia is surely too lazy to write. Anyway, Behrens reassures Hans, she'll surely be back—that's just how it goes with people who leave too soon. When Hans interjects to ask Behrens how long he'll be here, Behrens is evasive.

Alone, Hans thinks more about Clavdia's not wanting to write to him. He decides it probably shouldn't be that much of a big deal to him—after all, isn't keeping in touch rather bourgeois, anyway? Still, it bothers him. Another thing troubling him is that, ever since Settembrini stormed out of the room on Mardi Gras, things have been rather cold between Hans and him. Hans figures Settembrini probably thinks he's a lost cause.

Settembrini breaks the silence one day in passing, with a reference to classical mythology. He asks Hans if Hans "like[]d the pomegranate" and then cautions him that those who taste the fruit of the underworld belong to that realm forever. Then he continues on his way. Once alone, Hans scowls at the unsolicited advice, but he's also grateful that Settembrini has finally broken the ice.

Hans's raised temperature is played for comedy, but it also shows that his love for Clavdia is literally making him sick. That he continues to pine for her anyway suggests that he has embraced her view of morality, which holds that pleasure and freedom should take priority over virtue and adherence to bourgeois social norms, even (and perhaps especially) if such behavior leads to sin and self-destruction. Hans's raised temperature and generally declining health suggest that he is indeed headed down a path of self-destruction—and for someone who can't even be bothered to keep in touch with him.



Hans's choice to interpret Clavdia's refusal to write to him as a statement on her personal anti-bourgeois worldview rather than her indifference to him reveals his youthful naivety. It also illustrates the irrationality of his love: Clavdia is clearly not interested in him, yet he can't admit defeat and try to move on, even if it's alienating him from people like Settembrini who really do have his best interests at heart.



Settembrini's remark about the pomegranate alludes to the myth of Hades and Persephone. He's suggesting that Clavdia, like Hades, has used a pomegranate (her sensuality) to tempt Hans into the underworld, or to lead him astray. Hans's ambivalent response to Settembrini's (admittedly rather patronizing) bit of advice shows that he's not yet a lost cause: though Clavdia and all the pleasure and sin she represents have tempted him, he still respects the rational, virtuous values that Settembrini represents and wants Settembrini to continue to mentor him.



Several weeks later, at late breakfast on Easter, Settembrini asks Hans if he's ever traveled across the ocean before. He tells Hans that the Easter eggs and rabbits that have been placed at each table remind him of life on a luxury ship: of the creature comforts that make one forget the endless horizon beyond. Hans listens to Settembrini philosophize a bit more about the Easter holiday, and then he responds with great praise, hoping to tell Settembrini everything he thinks Settembrini wants to hear. Then Settembrini makes a huge announcement: he's leaving the sanatorium. Having been declared incurable, staying here is just the same as leaving, and so he has chosen to leave and to accept whatever consequences will entail. He's moving to Dorf, nearby, so it's likely their paths will still cross. After that, Settembrini goes to live in town with Lukačnek, the ladies' tailor.

Residents leave the Berghof against their best interests all the time. Frau Salomon, for example, who'd been there for a long time before Hans first arrived, left in a huff after Behrens declared that her condition had worsened and that she needed to stay for five more months. She returned to the damp, cold environment of her native Amsterdam—clearly a worse environment for her condition than the Berghof. Behrens is convinced that Frau Salomon will be back.

Meanwhile, Anton Karlovitch Ferge, whose condition was once so grave, takes over Settembrini's spot at Hans and Joachim's table, having made a remarkable and unexpected recovery. The cousins like the "simple martyr" and take to chatting and taking their constitutionals with him, though the melting snow makes the walking paths difficult to navigate. It's March now, and soon new plant growth replaces the snow that formerly blanketed the meadow. When Hans expresses an interest in botany, Joachim sarcastically asks if it was Krokowski who inspired this new interest. Lately, Krokowski's lectures have focused on botany. He has been talking about the link between love and death, citing as an example a type of morel mushroom that emits an odor of decay and is also an aphrodisiac.

Joachim's sarcastic tone has nothing to do with botany, though. Even if Joachim doesn't know why he's been on edge lately, Hans does—a while back, Hans was chatting with Krokowski when the doctor stopped by to record everyone's temperature, something that Joachim can surely make out through his room's thin walls, though he doesn't mention so to Hans. Joachim also made another discovery, which he has clearly decided is a betrayal: he saw Hans go into Krokowski's "analytical pit" for a psychoanalysis session. Since then, though, Hans has stopped doing this.

Settembrini's remark about the Easter place settings gestures toward the theme of time's tenuous and subjective nature: the place settings are there to get residents in a festive mood, as though celebrating the holiday will add variety and thus punctuate the otherwise monotonous, predictable stretch of days most residents have before them. Settembrini's announcement about leaving the sanatorium marks a major shift in his character, demonstrating his willingness not just to preach but also to act on his principles. Settembrini has been urging Hans to stop wasting his time at the Berghof and re-enter society. Now he makes good on his own advice, lending it greater validity.



This passage raises the question of what course of treatment really is best for chronically ill patients. If a patient shows no signs of improving, is staying in the stupefying, monotonous environment of the Berghof really preferable to re-entering society and living a more purposeful life?



There's no real reason why Ferge, one of the gravely ill residents Hans visited as part of his crusade to dignify suffering, has recovered and other residents he visited, like Leila Gerngross, have died. Ferge's recovery thus gestures toward the arbitrary and meaningless nature of illness and suffering, though Hans fails to recognize how this challenges his theory that suffering ennoble the suffering, apparently having already abandoned that old interest for a new one: botany. Hans's shifting, short-lived intellectual pursuits reflect his youth and naivety. His beliefs are superficial and tenuous, and his failure to recognize this only further highlights his youth and inexperience.



Hans was opposed to psychoanalysis (not to mention treatment of any kind) when he first arrived at the Berghof, so his decision to begin sessions with Krokowski indicates that he has had a change of heart and believes that Krokowski's theories about the link between repressed inner emotions and outer symptoms of physical illness. In a broader sense, then, Hans continues to reject Settembrini's advice not to attach deeper meaning to illness and suffering.



PART 6, CHAPTER 2: SOMEONE ELSE

With spring's arrival, flowers begin to appear in the meadow beyond the sanatorium. Hans picks bouquets of them to bring back to his room to study. He picks them apart, examining their structure and parts, comparing them against the charts he's seen in textbooks. At night, he studies the stars in the night sky. While walking through town one day, Hans prattles on about the zodiac and humanity, and Joachim accuses him of being just like Settembrini. Undeterred, Hans continues his spiel, describing "primitives" who hold midsummer festivities to impose meaning on and break up the endless cycle of "eternity."

Just then, Hans and Joachim encounter Settembrini on the street. He's engaged in conversation with a stranger. The cousins greet their old companion and pressure Settembrini to introduce his companion—something he initially seems reluctant to do. The man's name is Naphta, and the cousins learn that he's another man to whom Lukačnek, the women's tailor, is renting a room. Naphta is a well-dressed man with a "caustic" appearance and personality. Settembrini explains that Naphta is a professor of classical languages at the Fridericianum.

Settembrini and Naphta philosophize and argue back and forth. Naphta pokes fun at Settembrini for praising nature's "austerity" and for being a rationalist. Settembrini, in response, criticizes Naphta for dividing the world into realms of "God" and "nature" for his own amusement. They disagree about what the Spirit and religion brings to humanity. Naphta thinks religion brings freedom, but Settembrini responds that "freedom" is about the love of humankind, not the "nihilism and malice" that Naphta attributes to it. Naphta accuses Settembrini of simply being afraid of nihilism. Joachim and Hans exchange a glance.

Hans muses that Naphta must value the military life because of its "ascetic" qualities—it's much like serving the church, in this way. Naphta agrees with him. Settembrini, meanwhile, argues the profession holds no intellectual merit. The conversation's focus shifts to politics, specifically war. Much to Naphta's delight, Hans recalls all the times Settembrini has advocated for rebellion in the name of human progress—meaning he is pro-war, and therefore in contradiction with his self-proclaimed humanist bent. Naphta's stance on war and politics is more cynical. He sees them not as exercises in the democratic process, but rather an outlet for moral compromise. Naphta and Settembrini continue to argue back and forth, aggressively but playfully, until at last they reach their house.

Spring conventionally represents rebirth and renewal, but the monotonous, stagnant environment of the Berghof complicates this symbolism. Here, the seasons aren't so sharply defined—spring flowers can unexpectedly give way to snow and an overcast sky. Likewise, residents' health ebbs and flows, as do the passing fancies with which Hans occupies his time. With all his talk of the zodiac and humanity, he seems already to be moving on from botany.



Naphta's appearance just after Clavdia's departure is significant, suggesting that he may function as a replacement for her, embodying a set of traits and worldviews that contrast with Settembrini's—and thus serving as new competition for the impressionable and naïve Hans's loyalty.



Already, the novel makes clear the sharp contrast between Settembrini's and Naphta's values. Settembrini maintains his firmly held, humanist belief that humankind reaches its full potential on earth, through rational engagement with the surrounding world. Naphta, on the other hand, suggests that humankind cannot reach its full potential in the earthly realm. Rather, a person reaches their full potential only in the spiritual realm. Settembrini believes that such a worldview degrades humankind and life in general. He astutely points out its inherent contradiction, as well: despite Naphta's religious affiliation, his view of humanity is fundamentally nihilistic.



As Naphta and Settembrini argue, each pokes legitimate holes in the other's arguments revealing the contradiction and underlies their logic. This shows the limitations of rationality and abstract ideals. Ultimately, this is all very confusing for Hans as he struggles to complete his self-education.



Before parting ways, Naphta invites Hans and Joachim to come visit him. Once alone, the cousins discuss the small, unpleasant man. Joachim liked some of the things Naphta said but finds him to be a “dubious character.” Hans thinks they should take Naphta up on his offer to visit him—they might learn something. He admits that the more Naphta and Settembrini argued, the more confused he got. Joachim scoffs at Hans’s incessant “learning,” reminding him that they’re here to get well, not to learn. He says it’s better to go through life with “no opinions at all and just do your duty.” Hans thinks this is fine for Joachim as a soldier, but for Hans—a civilian, in charge of himself—thinking and understanding is vital. Plus, he thinks Joachim is wrong to assume that learning and getting well are mutually exclusive—Hans thinks they must be linked.

Hans’s eagerness to visit Naphta despite the fact that Naphta is unpleasant and even seems rather suspect (or “dubious,” as Joachim puts it) shows how naïve and undiscerning he is. He’s unable to differentiate good and helpful knowledge from “dubious” and harmful knowledge and takes everything he learns, whether from Settembrini or Krokowski or Clavdia Chauchat, at face value. When Joachim criticizes Hans for “learning” instead of focusing on getting better, he suggests that Hans’s intellectual curiosity is self-destructive. Implicitly, he’s suggesting that Hans’s intellectual pursuits—which remain unorganized, unformed, and abstract—do nothing to improve Hans’s quality of life. Instead, they distract him from what ought to matter: the practical pursuits of getting better and returning to the life and responsibilities he left behind when he came to the Berghof.



PART 6, CHAPTER 3: THE CITY OF GOD AND EVIL DELIVERANCE

Hans sits out on his balcony and looks at the columbine that has started to grow in the meadow now that summer has arrived. He frequently walks out to the same spot where he had his nosebleed and his vision of Pribislav Hippe one year ago—either to enjoy the columbine that grows there, or to marvel at the fact that he has been here a full year. These days, he doesn’t get nosebleeds, his **Maria Mancinis** have started to taste good again, and he no longer has visions of Pribislav Hippe, meaning that his “acclimatization [is] complete” and he’s now fully at home in the mountains.

Now that Hans’s “acclimatization [is] complete,” he has symbolically and practically committed himself to the directionless, unproductive lifestyle of the typical Berghof resident. He accepts that lifestyle as the default state—as the rational, right way to live—and can no longer justify or find value in the way that people in ordinary society live. Despite Settembrini’s (and to a lesser extent Joachim’s) efforts to keep Hans on track and tethered to reality, he seems to have become lost to the world, maybe forever.



Hans pulls out the **X-ray** image Clavdia gave him before she left the sanatorium—he carries it with him in his wallet—and holds it up to the sky. He feels his heart flutter as he looks at the image. Looking at it makes Hans consider big questions, lofty philosophical ideas that Joachim never bothers with, like “form and freedom, mind and body, honor and disgrace, time and eternity.” Hans refers to the thinking he does at this place on the hill as “playing king,” a term he got from games he played as a child.

The fact that Hans uses a childhood memory to describe his philosophical musings underscores their unseriousness. To be sure, there is value in unfettered, whimsical daydreaming, but that value is undercut by the fact that Hans isn’t translating his musings into practical action. Unless he returns to ordinary society, he cannot put all that he has learned into practice.



Hans feels obligated to visit Naphta—something Settembrini clearly disapproves of, having tried to delay Naphta’s introduction to Hans and Joachim. Hans grumbles to himself at Settembrini’s habit of talking down to him and gatekeeping knowledge—something all teachers do—and is grateful that he can’t actually prevent Hans from visiting Naphta.

Hans’s irritation at Settembrini, though understandable, reinforces his youth and inexperience: he can’t grasp that Settembrini is trying to help lead him back down the right path (that is, the path of rationality, productivity, and wellness).



Now, Hans and Joachim take the short walk from the Berghof to the tailor's house where Settembrini and Naphta live. Lukačnek, the tailor, answers the door and sends a page to ask if Naphta will receive Hans and Joachim. The page returns, announcing that Naphta will see Hans and Joachim now, and leads the cousins to Naphta's room. To the cousins' surprise, Naphta's room is luxuriously and elegantly decorated, with silk upholstery and tapestries covering nearly every surface. There's a pieta sculpture displayed in a corner—it, too, is draped in silk, giving it an "almost grotesque" appearance. Hans compliments the sculpture, and Naphta explains that good works of art "are always beautiful to the point of ugliness and ugly to the point of beauty." He says that only "inner beauty"—the sort one gets through religious experience—is real beauty.

Naphta explains that the sculpture is Gothic, from the late Middle Ages. He prattles on about the superiority of that era's art, which didn't "prettif[y]" its subjects, focusing solely on "suffering and the weakness of the flesh." Hans gushes over everything Naphta says, declaring it all incredibly interesting. Just then, a page arrives with their afternoon snack (slices of layer cake) and, much to Hans and Joachim's surprise, Settembrini enters behind him. Naphta's casual greeting makes it clear that, despite their opposite opinions, he and Settembrini visit with each other regularly.

Everyone eats their snack, and the conversation lingers on the pieta, which Settembrini clearly hates, though he tries not to say so overtly to be polite. Instead, he remarks on the sculpture's errors in proportion. Naphta explains that this was an intentional choice on the part of the sculptor to convey "the emancipation of the Spirit from the bonds of nature." Hans interjects to praise Gothic art's rejection of nature, arguing that it's just as "honorable" as Enlightenment thinkers like Voltaire refusing to submit to nature. Settembrini laughs at Hans's suggestion, then he reminds him that the only truly "honorable" protest against nature is one that does so to dignify humankind.

Naphta continues to defend religion, claiming that even Church-sanctioned acts of brutality, like the burning of people at the stake, were intended for good. Burning people at the stake, he argues, was supposed to spare their souls from eternal damnation. The same can't be said of the Jacobins' exterminations. Furthermore, he claims that the major contributions of the Renaissance and the Enlightenment have only minimized humanity's importance, with modern astronomy, for instance, turning the universe—which used to be the heavenly realm of God—into meaningless planets.

Naphta's living quarters reveal his hypocrisy: though he praises asceticism and religious devotion, he lives lavishly and decadently. This discord perhaps suggests that Naphta isn't the best role model or mentor for Hans to model. Naphta's praise for the statue's ugliness reveals his disregard for human life on earth, which he finds inferior to the eternal salvation that pious humans experience after death. He believes that religious experience is the only "real beauty" that humans can experience. Meanwhile, earthly concerns like life, liberty, and happiness—concerns that Settembrini values most of all—hold no value for Naphta.



The layer cake to which Naphta treats himself and his guests is another sign of his decadence and his hypocrisy: though he praises asceticism and human suffering in general, he doesn't seem too interested in suffering himself. Naphta is yet another character who advocates for abstract ideals and yet fails to adhere to them in his actual life.



Settembrini dislikes the pieta because its ugly appearance, which represents the ugliness of earthly concerns and thus human life in general. This view is at odds with Settembrini's humanist worldview, which holds that humankind reaches its full potential on earth, not in the spiritual realm.



Naphta's defense of religious violence only holds up if one accepts religious doctrine as truth: if one doesn't believe in the existence of hell or eternal damnation, then the act of burning people at the stake is nothing other than a brutal and senseless act of violence. Naphta criticizes acts of political violence as pointless because they are means to earthly ends rather than spiritual ends (like salvation). Ultimately, though, his appeals to religion merely conceal the underlying nihilism of his worldview.



Settembrini argues that pure knowledge is superior to religious knowledge, but Naphta counters that faith is the basis of all understanding. Further, he claims that there's no such thing as objective science, since bias is always present where voluntary will is involved. What's more, truth is always centered around humankind: truth is whatever "profits" humans. Because of this, abstract knowledge that has no bearing on "man's salvation" is uninteresting and useless. Naphta insists that it's incorrect and even "childish" to claim that the Church kept people in the dark while Enlightenment thinking brought people into the light—the Church did what was right. If anything has led people into darkness, it's the natural sciences. Settembrini thinks that this worldview sanctions all kinds of crimes and will do away with justice, truth, and democracy.

Naphta poses two possibilities. The first possibility is that Ptolemy and the scholastics are right that time and space are finite and only God transcends human experience. In this case, humanity's conflict lies between what humans can sense and what "transcends" human sensory experience. And this, in turn, would mean that all human, social issues are basically meaningless. This is the view Naphta embraces. The other possibility is that Settembrini's Renaissance astronomers are correct—the cosmos is infinite, meaning there is no duality—no world beyond that which humans can sense. In this case, all human conflict comes from a conflict between the individual and society. This would mean the state dictates what is moral, not god. Settembrini disagrees that the modern nation state imprisons people. To the contrary, he thinks modern democracy frees individuals from answering to more powerful forces.

Naphta and Settembrini also debate which economic systems imprison or dignify humanity, with Naphta arguing in favor of a Christian strain of communism, which condemns trade (making money off goods and services by merely exchanging them and placing arbitrary value on them rather than improving them) and lauds practical, physical labor. In fact, it's Settembrini's enlightened capitalism that enslaves humanity and stifles individualism. Settembrini disagrees, claiming that Naphta's "Christian communism" rejects technology and progress and therefore rejects freedom. It takes people back to the dark ages, back when all human relationships and even an individual's personality were "bound to the soil."

Naphta is correct that it's difficult to empirically observe the world without some degree of personal bias, but he completely ignores the degree to which his own bias—his faith—skews his embrace of religious knowledge and his rejection of scientific ("pure") knowledge. At its core, faith is about believing in something for which there is no proof. What's more, Naphta's appeal to logic to prove his point undercuts his attempts to argue for the superiority of religious feeling over rationality.



Naphta's view of human life is fundamentally different from Settembrini's because of his religious beliefs. He will always place the spiritual and pure realm of God above the physical and sinful realm of mortals. Next to the pursuit of eternal salvation, then, all human pursuits—even noble pursuits of liberty and happiness—are meaningless and unimportant. Naphta's criticism of the nation state's inherent bias is fair enough, but, once more, his claim that God alone possesses pure, unbiased knowledge only works if one accepts the existence of God. Though his arguments sound intellectually rigorous on the surface, their reliance on faith renders them irrational and illogical. What's more, he appeals to religion to conceal his underlying nihilism.



The narration uses Naphta and Settembrini's intellectual debates to develop their characters, with each new argument further establishing one man as the other's foil. This section elaborates on some of the central ideals that define either man. Settembrini's Enlightenment ideals of progress, personal liberty, and rationality clash with Naphta's spiritual beliefs.



Hans's enthusiastic interest in Naphta's viewpoint puts Settembrini on edge, and he abruptly announces that it's time for himself and the cousins to leave. Settembrini shows Hans and Joachim to his own living quarters, which are sparsely furnished but cozy, before walking them back to the Berghof. As they walk, Settembrini cautions the cousins against getting too close to Naphta, who sounds rational on the surface but in reality is quite confused. Settembrini explains that he engages with Naphta because it allows him to argue and defend his own opinions, and he needs this "friction" in his life. But this only works because Settembrini is firm in his opinions—Hans and Joachim are younger, more naïve, and more in danger of Naphta negatively influencing their bodies and souls.

Cautiously, Hans points out that for all Naphta's talk of the evils of capitalism and property, his living quarters were really quite lavishly furnished. Settembrini smiles as he explains that this is "very characteristic" of Naphta's people, who always take care of their own. Then Settembrini reveals a fact that shocks the cousins: Naphta is a Jesuit. He's not a priest, but only because his illness set him back.

Hans, Joachim, and Settembrini have reached the Berghof by this point. Before parting ways with the cousins, Settembrini repeats his grave warning to Hans and Joachim to be careful around Naphta. Settembrini states that Naphta's brand of intellect is dangerous because all his thoughts "stand under the aegis of death," which is by nature opposed to life, progress, and morality. With this, Settembrini departs. The narrator explains that this would be one of a few visits Hans and Joachim would make to Naphta, and each of these visits would give Hans lots to think about as he sat in his spot in the meadow and "played king."

Settembrini's abrupt decision to leave signals that he considers Naphta a threat: he sees that Hans's youth and inexperience leave him vulnerable to outside influences and unable to discern bad information from good information. Hans's characteristic ambivalence and short-lived intellectual pursuits suggest that Settembrini's wariness is justified. Yet Hans has demonstrated time and again that he doesn't respond well to Settembrini's moralizing, so it's unlikely that Settembrini's caution will do much to dissuade Hans from continuing to engage with Naphta—in fact, it might even encourage Hans to seek out Naphta's advice more eagerly than he would have otherwise.



Hans might be naïve, but he's not imperceptive: he correctly realized the dissonance between Naphta's proclaimed asceticism and his lavishly furnished living quarters. The Jesuit order is a religious order within the Catholic Church. Jesuits vow to live in poverty and to remain chaste and obedient to God. Naphta's status as a Jesuit associates him with traits that the novel has linked with Eastern sensibilities. When Settembrini wryly notes that Naphta's hypocrisy is "very characteristic" of Jesuits, he could be referring to some common criticisms of Jesuits. For instance, Jesuits participated in the Atlantic Slave Trade but justified their actions with the claim that enslaved people were easy targets for evangelization.



When Settembrini claims that all of Naphta's thoughts "stand under the aegis of death," he is referring to the way Naphta's religious belief inhibits ability to rationalize. All of Naphta's ideals are predicated on his belief that the earthly realm of humans is perpetually in conflict with the spiritual realm of God—and that the former is a perversion of the latter. Death, to Naphta, is the portal through which humans may shed their sinful physical forms and achieve their higher form in the afterlife. In this way, then, all Naphta's logic is skewed in favor of death over life. This is what Settembrini finds most dangerous about Naphta's logic: it is inherently self-destructive.



PART 6, CHAPTER 4: AN OUTBURST OF TEMPER/SOMETHING VERY EMBARRASSING

It's August now, and Hans's one-year anniversary of his arrival at the Berghof comes and goes without incident. It's an unspoken rule that nobody mentions arrival anniversaries—for long-term residents, it's more noble to not rely on measuring time. So, not even Joachim mentions the occasion to Hans.

Celebrating arrival anniversaries would suggest that the amount of time a resident spends at the Berghof correlates with their health, but this isn't necessarily the case, hence the tradition of ignoring arrival anniversaries altogether. It is a choice to believe that the accumulation of time automatically holds any significance.



One day in September, it inexplicably starts to snow, a turn of events that greatly upsets Joachim. Upsetting Joachim further is Hans's seeming acceptance of the premature winter weather—he accuses Hans of being so content at the sanatorium that he's even content when the weather is horrible. Then he storms out of the room. Joachim's outburst confuses Hans, and it forces him to consider an unsettling notion: Joachim clearly wants to leave this place, and he might even leave Hans behind there. And it's also possible that Joachim will die.

That afternoon, during an examination with Behrens, Joachim confirms Hans's fears, announcing with finality that he has decided to leave the Berghof one week from today. Behrens tries to argue with him, but Joachim has made up his mind. His stay here was only supposed to last three months, he complains, but Behrens has repeatedly pushed back his release date. Though his condition hasn't meaningfully improved, he's done waiting and will accept whatever consequences come his way.

Behrens assumes that Hans will accompany Joachim, but Hans replies that he'll only leave with Behrens's approval. Behrens tells Hans he can go—he's cured. This shocks Hans, who assumes the director is joking. Behrens erupts with rage, going off about how he doesn't "own anything here" and is only a doctor—anyone is free to leave whenever they like. Then he walks out of the room, slamming the door shut behind him.

Immediately, Joachim makes arrangements for his departure. Behrens gives him "semiapproval" for his exit, and Joachim stops tracking his temperature. Joachim arranges to take a train "down to the lowlands" and then live among people who have no sense of how life is at the Berghof—that is, he plans to live among "ignorant people." Overall, he's happy to leave. To Hans, such a situation is unfathomable. Gradually, Hans accepts that he'll go on living here without Joachim—he has to, he realizes, because he's waiting for Clavdia's return, though he doesn't know when or even if that'll happen.

This passage establishes just how much Hans has changed over the past year. When he first arrived at the Berghof, he couldn't fathom staying more than three weeks. Now, he struggles to understand Joachim's urgent desire to leave the sanatorium.



Joachim's choice to leave against Behrens's orders might be foolish, but it also demonstrates his admirable ability to translate his ideals into actions. Joachim values honor above all else, and so he behaves honorably, returning to his military service instead of hanging around the Berghof and waiting for Behrens to release him.

This is a major turning point in Hans's story. Behrens has plainly told him there is nothing about his condition that requires him to remain at the Berghof. He has effectively put the ball in Hans's court. Now, Hans must either choose to leave the Berghof or come to terms with the disturbing possibility that he wants to stay because he is drawn to its atmosphere of decadence and abandon.



Thermometers and the act of taking one's temperature symbolize residents' acclimation to the Berghof. The fact that Joachim no longer takes his temperature signals the finality of his decision to leave and return to ordinary society. Meanwhile, now that Hans can no longer pretend that he is staying at the Berghof out of concern for his health, he finally admits to himself the embarrassing truth that he has stuck around so long out of hope that Clavdia might return.



Finally, the day of Joachim's departure arrives. It's the first beautiful, sunny day in a while. Hans accompanies him to the train station and remarks, in awe, that this is where he arrived. Joachim acknowledges this fact casually, apparently not sharing Hans's sentimentality. The cousins shake hands. Hans tells Joachim to "swear that oath fervently," and Joachim assures him he will. Then Joachim takes Hans's hands firmly. Addressing him by his name (something the cousins rarely if ever do, normally using nicknames), Joachim orders Hans to "come soon." Then he boards the train, closing the door behind him. And Hans begins the walk back to the Berghof alone.

Joachim's choice to address Hans by name underscores the seriousness of his concern for Hans. He recognizes that the longer Hans stays at the Berghof, the harder it will be for him to re-enter society. Unlike Joachim, who has never abandoned his sense of duty, Hans is more vulnerable to the seductive allure of the Berghof.



PART 6, CHAPTER 5: AN ATTACK REPULSED

Time passes, and eventually it's October. Management assigns Hans a new seat in the dining hall after Joachim's departure, and he's now sitting at Settembrini's old table, opposite the empty chair reserved for Behrens. His new tablemates include an amateur photographer from Mexico, an old woman from Transylvania, and a Czech man whom people call "Herr Wenzel," since nobody can pronounce his name. The brewer Herr Magnus and his wife also sit at Hans's new table. Hans is friendliest with A. K. Ferge (the "martyr" from St. Petersburg) and Ferdinand Wehsal, a merchant from Mannheim who would constantly stare at Clavdia.

It's never clear exactly how much time has passed between chapters—the narration seems to purposely obscure the passage of time to mimic the experience of life at the Berghof. Yet the cycling in and out of new residents at Hans's table indicates that he has been there quite a long time.



Hans finds Wehsal rather pathetic. He poses inane questions to his dining companions, asking them, for instance, whether it's worth it to tell someone you love them even if they don't know you exist. Wehsal thinks so: while doing so might be embarrassing, it also creates a moment of intimacy between the object of one's affection and oneself, however fleeting.

It's ironic that Hans finds Wehsal's lovesickness pathetic, given its resemblance to Hans's own pathetic crush on Clavdia. Hans has matured in some ways, yet he remains largely stunted, and he is certainly lacking in self-awareness.



For the next few days, there's a guest at the table: Hans's uncle James Tienappel. It feels strange to Hans to have someone from his old life here in his new "upper world." But Hans has suspected that "a raid from the flatlands" would have to happen at some point, so when James Tienappel announced his plans to stop by while in Switzerland on a business trip, Hans calmly accepted the news and passed it along to Behrens.

That it feels strange to Hans to have someone "from the flatlands" signals how much Hans has changed since arriving at the Berghof. He used to think it was strange that Joachim differentiated between people from "the flatlands" and people from the "upper world," but now it makes sense to him, and he embraces his status as a citizen of the "upper world." Furthermore, when Hans describes his uncle's visit as "a raid from the flatlands," it signals his desire to defend his right to stay the Berghof. He perceives his uncle's visit as an attack meant to take him away from his new, preferred way of life.



After James arrives, he passes along Hans's other relatives' regards. He also updates Hans about Joachim, noting that he has joined his regiment and feels great about it. James seems on edge, but it's unclear why. He tells Hans that he only plans to stay a week at most. And, judging by Hans's healthy appearance, he assumes that Hans will leave with him. When Hans says he's not ready to leave yet, James can't believe it—life is short, and Hans has already been here for over a year. He promises to talk to Behrens about Hans's condition, and Hans encourages him to do so.

Joachim is flourishing since returning to his military service. Unlike Hans, who has yet to achieve self-actualization, Joachim has succeeded in identifying and then acting on his goals. He felt a duty to serve in the military, and now he has followed through with that duty. Meanwhile, Hans's inability to understand James's edginess shows how little he can relate to people from the flatlands: it's apparent that James is experiencing the same mixture of unease and intrigue that Hans felt when he first arrived at the Berghof, yet Hans is so removed from that experience that he can no longer relate to it.



On James's first night at the Berghof, Hans gets James situated in Joachim's old room, where he'll be staying, and then they head to the Berghof's restaurant for dinner. They don't talk about home or anything serious. James repeatedly mentions the cold weather. He has trouble breathing through his nose because of the altitude. When Hans casually mentions, in great and gross detail, the *gangraena pulmonum* from which one resident suffers, James unexpectedly erupts with laughter. After dinner, Hans introduces James to Dr. Krokowski, who greets him with happy enthusiasm. James, meanwhile, can sense without being told that he's "operating on foreign soil" at the Berghof, which has its own social norms and conventions.

James's introduction to the Berghof uncannily mirrors Hans's, right down to his uncomfortable laughter, his introduction to Behrens and Krokowski, and his complaints about the cold weather. Hans, meanwhile, has taken over Joachim's role, indicating the extreme transformation his time there has inspired.



The next day, James meets Behrens in the dining hall. Behrens enthusiastically tells James that it's great he's here—not just for Hans's sake, but for his own, too: apparently, he's quite anemic! Behrens then suggests that James try to live as a resident while he's here. Not long after this, James takes his first rest cure, and he enjoys it immensely. When he tries to make jokes about the odd activities he observes around him, Hans responds with the same calm smile that every resident wears on their face, and it makes James feel uneasy.

James's visit continues to mirror Hans's, right down to the unease he feels toward the calm, vacant smiles of the Berghof's residents. This raises the question of whether James will follow in Hans's footsteps and remain at the Berghof against his best interests or whether he will listen to his unease and leave the Berghof before he can succumb to its temptations.



Later, James meets the head nurse when she drops by his room to tell him that he'll have to wait his turn to meet with Behrens since he's not sick and therefore not a top priority. The nurse's aggressive behavior unsettles him—and so does Hans's apparent acceptance of it. Meanwhile, James is constantly cold, despite Hans's insistence that the residents are "never cold," a phrase he repeats like a mantra.

James's introduction to the Berghof continues to resemble Hans's to a comically high degree. Tension mounts as readers are left to wonder whether James will succumb to the Berghof's pull or flee while he still can.



On James's sixth day at the Berghof, he finally has his meeting with Behrens. He goes into it wanting to have a serious discussion about Hans, but he seems subdued and defeated when he returns to his room and doesn't mention anything he and the doctor talked about. At supper Monday night, Behrens sits at Hans's table and, in response to a question Hans has asked him about human decomposition, explains in gory detail how one's guts explode. James, disgusted, leaves the next morning without saying goodbye to Hans. Later, Hans receives telegram from his uncle explaining that he received word that he had an urgent business matter to attend to, but this is clearly a lie. He closes the telegram, "Best wishes for a continued pleasant stay," and Hans can't tell whether James is mocking him.

James experiences the same mixture of fascination and revulsion that Hans felt when he first arrived at the Berghof, yet James has the conviction and self-awareness to listen to his gut and leave while he still has the chance. James's experience suggests that there was never anything fundamentally flawed about Hans that made the Berghof's decadence appeal to him in the first place—James clearly recognized the appeal of the strange, otherworldly place. Yet Hans, perhaps due to his youth and inexperience at the time, lacked the initiative to recognize the potential harm that might come from staying there, and now he must suffer the consequences.



PART 6, CHAPTER 6: OPERATIONES SPIRITUALES

"Operationes Spirituales" opens with a summary of Naphta's background, as he explains it to Hans. Leo Naphta comes from a small town between Galicia and Volhynia. His father, Elia Naphta, is the village *shohet* (similar to a Christian butcher), responsible for slaughtering animals according to the rules of the Talmud. While Christian butchers typically hit the animal over the head before slaughtering them, which is supposed to allow for a more humane death, the rules of the Talmud require Elia to kill the animal while it's still fully conscious. Though religious, Elia also criticizes the Torah and frequently argues with the rabbi. The town regards him as someone special, someone unorthodox. Elia dies during a pogrom carried out in response to the unexplained deaths of two Christian children—he's found hanging outside his burning house, crucified to the door.

The tragic and unjust murder of Naphta's father may explain the nihilism he adopts as an adult. Witnessing such brutality hardly inspires one to believe in the fundamental goodness and rationality of humanity.



After Elia's death, Naphta's mother takes the children and flees to the small town of Vorarlberg, where her children attend grammar school. Naphta is a precocious child and an excellent student, and he catches the attention of the local rabbi, who starts to tutor him. But in time, Naphta's rebellious streak upsets the rabbi, who ultimately severs their relationship after Naphta makes friends with the son of a social-democratic member of the Reichsrat and starts caring more about social criticism than logic. Naphta's mother dies around this time, and not long after that, he meets Father Unterpertinger, the Jesuit priest who takes Naphta under his wing.

This passage marks a critical moment in Naphta's development, as it highlights his shift from caring about logic to caring about social criticism, as well as his embrace of social-democratic values.



Father Unterpertinger and Naphta talk about Marx, Hegel, and about the central role that politics plays in Catholicism. At the end of their first meeting, Father Unterpertinger invites Naphta to visit him at his school, the Stella Matutina, and Naphta finds that the Judaism he was brought up with is not so different from Catholicism, with both religions valuing practicality and possessing a “political spirituality.” Naphta becomes eager to convert, and he’s soon baptized, after which he starts attending the Jesuit school. Life at the school is full of both calm and intellectual rigor, and Naphta takes to it immediately. Eventually, he decides to study theology and would like to join the order.

This brief interlude on Naphta’s background functions as a coming-of-age story, albeit on a much smaller scaler. His interest in the simultaneous practicality and “political spirituality” of Catholicism lays the foundation for the dualism he will embrace later in life.



But Naphta’s health worsens over the years. His nights are occupied with operations, spirituals, or “examinations of conscience,” which he takes seriously and which fill him with lots of frustrations and uncertainties. He tries to tell this to his mentor, but the only advice he receives is to “pray for his soul to find peace.” When he does find this peace, he struggles with the realization that the process “dulls” him and can only be achieved “by way of physical ruin.” Still, his mentors don’t judge him for his doubts, and he eventually graduates and heads to the Jesuit college in Holland to begin his theology studies.

The “examinations of conscience” Naphta is forced to undergo as part of his training informs his view of the physical body and immaterial soul as separate, competing forces: the harder he works to “pray for his soul to find peace,” the closer his body gets to “physical ruin.”



But the climate of Holland and the intensity of Naphta’s studies destroys his health, forcing him to drop out. He returns to the boarding school, planning to resume his university studies after a few years. But due to his extremely poor health, his superiors decide it would be best for him not to return to Holland, instead teaching pupils someplace with a more favorable climate. That’s how he ended up at Davos-Dorf, where he’s beginning his sixth year teaching at a local school for tubercular boys.

Naphta’s earlier revelation that achieving peace in one’s soul requires “physical ruin” turns out to be truer than he could have known: ultimately the spiritual rigor of the process causes his body to turn on him, and he fails to complete his studies. Ultimately, this brief interlude serves to contextualize and rationalize the nihilistic glorification of suffering that characterizes Naphta’s worldview in the story’s present.



Hans learns Naphta’s backstory gradually during his visits to the man’s living quarters. He thinks Naphta’s backstory is honorable and encourages Ferge and Wehsal, who accompany him, to think so too, though Wehsal thinks it’s rather unfortunate that Naphta’s life seems to be in a rut at the moment. Hans thinks so too, and it makes him miss “honoring Joachim,” who managed to get out of his rut. Hans thinks that Naphta and Joachim are actually quite similar: both swore an oath to an organization that values “asceticism and hierarchy.” And both the Jesuits and the military value attacking the enemy for the betterment of the world rather than protecting oneself. But the most important similarity between Naphta’s and Joachim’s worlds, to Hans, is their willingness to kill. And this is something that Hans, as a pacifist, cannot understand.

Naphta might be a rather unpleasant man with a cynical view of humanity, but his backstory justifies or at least explains the nihilism he displays in the story’s present—he has consistently experienced tragedy and hardship that give him reason to view the world and its human inhabitants as morally flawed and fundamentally irrational. Hans’s comparison of Naphta to Joachim suggests his sympathy for Naphta and his past suffering.



One day around Christmas, Hans, Naphta, Settembrini, Ferge, and Wehsal are all walking through town when they start arguing about health and sickness. The conversation starts because a resident named Karen Karstedt has recently died. Hans expresses his regret at not being able to participate in her funeral (Hans loves funerals), and this prompts Settembrini to make a sarcastic remark about Hans's earlier practice of visiting the Berghof's most severe cases. When Hans notes that most of the people he visited are now dead, Settembrini mockingly asks whether Hans finds them "more respectable" that way. This sends Naphta on a spiel about religious fanatics' acts of excessive religious charity in the Middle Ages, describing women who would kiss the wounds of lepers and not get sick.

Settembrini cuts in to argue that the sick don't deserve sympathy from the healthy. Such sympathy derives from the misconception that a sick person is a healthy person dealing with undeserved illness. In reality, though, a sick person is just a sick person. Settembrini has little patience for sick people who demand others' sympathies. He also argues that "madness" is really just what happens when a person lets themselves go. Settembrini claims to have brought mad people back to sanity simply by confronting them with logic. Naphta laughs at this, but Hans believes Settembrini and can even imagine him healing the mad this way.

Naphta then contributes his opposing viewpoint, describing how in the Middle Ages the Church saw suffering as a form of "religious affirmation." Sore-covered flesh, he explains, would remind people of the soul's corrupt state. As they walk, Hans remains stuck between Settembrini and Naphta, the former praising the human body and the latter deeming it an obstacle between humans and eternal salvation. Hans finds himself physically turning back and forth, agreeing with one and then agreeing with the other.

Eventually the conversation drifts to more relevant, real-world subjects like the death penalty and torture. Settembrini condemns the use of torture. Naphta supports it, though, arguing that "true honor [i]s based in the Spirit" and that inflicting pain on the flesh is an effective way to show the soul that it should derive pleasure from the "spiritual realm" rather than the physical body.

Settembrini's remark about Hans finding the Berghof's patients "more respectable" in death is meant to mock Hans's earlier quest to dignify illness and suffering. Ultimately, his quest failed when none of the patients exhibited the seriousness or dignity Hans expected out of them. But in bringing up Hans's embarrassing failure in this context, Settembrini also seems to goad Naphta into an argument, since the drive to make suffering "respectable" forms the core of Naphta's personal philosophy. And indeed, right on cue, Naphta interjects with a rant about religious charity.



Settembrini's arguments against extending extra sympathy to the sick expands on the broader point he has argued from the beginning of the novel: the irrationality of glorifying suffering and of turning to death and suffering to understand life. But his appeal to rationality takes him to absurd, irrational heights when he (apparently seriously) claims to have cured mad people by confronting them with logic.



This passage expands on Naphta's advocacy for the glorification of suffering. He attaches special significance to the mortification or debasement of the physical body, arguing that a physical affliction like painful boils reveals the inner corruption of the soul. Note the similarity between this view and Krokowski's psychoanalytic theories.



Naphta appeals to religion to argue in favor of the death penalty, but this is only a crafty way to disguise his underlying nihilism: the logic that "true honor [i]s based in the Spirit" rather than the physical body effectively justifies any and all forms of violence and torture.



Gradually, the argument gets more heated as its focus shifts back toward matters of life, death, and illness. Settembrini reaffirms his position that there is nothing noble about illness because it reduces a human “to a mere body” and is therefore inhuman and ignoble. Naphta, on the other hand, replies that illness is in fact very human, since “man [i]s ill by nature” compared to God. Settembrini attacks Naphta for claiming that “illness and death are noble” whereas “health and life are sordid.” The more they argue and the more strange terms and phrases they toss back and forth, the more confused Hans gets—and the more Ferge and Wehsal lose interest. Eventually, they part ways with Settembrini and Naphta at their lodging house and return to the Berghof. Hans returns to his balcony and considers the two opposing viewpoints that have called him to “the confused tumult of battle.”

This passage reinforces the main points of Naphta’s and Settembrini’s respective attitudes toward illness, suffering, and the body. Settembrini disparages illness because it attacks the mind (or soul), which is fundamentally rational and good, by exposing the limitations of the physical body. Naphta, on the other hand, glorifies illness for exposing the fundamental truth of humankind: that it “[i]s ill by nature.” Again, Naphta’s logic bears notable similarities to Krokowski’s psychoanalytic theories, notably the underlying assumption that, at their core, all humans are fundamentally irrational.



PART 6, CHAPTER 7: SNOW

All the Berghof’s residents are unhappy that it’s not as sunny as it should be, which is vital to their health and one of the facility’s selling points. Everyone grumbles about not getting their money’s worth. Management tries to mitigate this by purchasing special lamps that create artificial sunlight, but they’re not the same as real sunlight. In place of sunlight, there’s an abundance of snow—far more than there was Hans’s first winter. Hans spends his afternoons bundled up in blankets on his balcony, gazing out at the winter scenery.

It’s ironic that the Berghof’s residents are complaining about not getting their money’s worth of sunlight instead of about how the lack of sunlight is affecting their health. It suggests that nobody there is particularly concerned about actually getting better.



Still, Hans loves the snow, finding it not unlike the sand all along the shore back home. And while the heavy accumulation of snow makes it difficult to move about the grounds—the snowplows simply can’t keep up—Hans doesn’t mind: all he really wants to do is “play king,” and he can do that from the stationary comfort of his balcony. But he does also want to be more active, so one day he decides to buy skis. If he were to tell Behrens about his plan, the doctor would surely reject it—athletic activity is prohibited due to the strain it puts on the heart. So Hans decides to go behind Behrens’s back.

Even though Behrens recently told Hans that he is well enough to leave if he wants to and that Behrens has no control over his (or any of the residents’) actions, Hans continues to act as though he is subject to Behrens’s orders, hence his decision to go behind Behrens’s back about the skis. Hans continues to deny that he is staying at the Berghof of his own accord, further demonstrating his stagnating path toward maturity and self-knowledge.



When Hans tells Settembrini about his plan, Settembrini enthusiastically encourages him, even offering to accompany Hans to the store to buy them. Hans takes him up on the offer and, on Settembrini's vocal (but completely uninformed) advice, buys a nice pair of skis at a shop in town. In the following days, Settembrini looks on from a distance and applauds Hans as he struggles to get the hang of them. In time, Hans becomes sufficiently competent, and he enjoys gliding about the grounds, gazing out at the beautiful wintery landscape and relishing the contemplative solitude his new hobby grants him. But the silence is also intimidating, forcing Hans to acknowledge the wild forces of nature that surround him. Still, doing so instills in him a new sense of courage and creating in him a sense of "sympathy" with the surrounding natural world.

Sometimes, Hans stabs the end of his ski pole into the snow and pulls it out rapidly, creating an optical illusion that makes it look like blue light is shining out of the hole. The light reminds him of Hippe's or Clavdia's eyes—eyes Settembrini offensively labeled "Tartar slits."

After dinner one day, Hans sets off on his skis and makes his way into the woods. He rests there for a while and smokes a cigarette. It's 3:00 p.m. now, and he continues on, even though it means he might get back to the sanatorium late: the "allure" of "this uncanny world that boded no good" is too strong to resist. At once, Hans realizes that he's been wanting to get lost this entire time. He senses a storm approaching and knows it would be wise not to let it overtake him, but he's tempted to let that happen. Then, without warning (or perhaps exactly as Hans wanted to happen), the wind picks up and the storm arrives. Hans isn't dressed for such extreme cold, and it chills him to the bone.

Hans struggles through the snow, feeling a mixture of fear and excitement. Eventually, much to Hans's relief, he spots a humanmade structure—a shed—and approaches it. Though the shed is locked, it at least offers some relief from the intense winds. It's now just half past four. Hans can hardly believe so little time has passed. Just then, he remembers that he bought a small bottle of beer on his way out of the Berghof and pocketed it before he ventured off into the snow. He removes it now and takes a few sips, but he immediately realizes what a mistake this was—the beer muddles his thoughts and just makes him want to sleep.

Hans's skiing may signal his growing impulses toward irrationality and self-destruction: he seems to find perverse pleasure in the wildness and unpredictability of nature.



Hans's comparison of the blue light to Clavdia's or Hippe's eyes links Clavdia's irrationality with the irrational realm of the natural world.



Yet again, Hans succumbs to "an allure" while recognizing its potential to do him great harm: he knows that it's highly probably he will get lost if he continues into the woods, yet he does so anyway. And suddenly, with the arrival of the winter storm, it seems that Hans's careless behavior will finally reap some serious consequences.



Hans has already acted foolishly, resulting in his getting lost in the middle of a snowstorm. Now he makes things even worse by drinking a beer. Hans continues to behave irrationally and self-destructively. It is as though he is trying, if only unconsciously, to act out his theory that experiencing death and suffering lead a person to higher insights about life, putting himself in increasingly dangerous situations to find clarity and further his journey toward self-knowledge.



Hans ventures forward and suddenly sees the sea emerge before him. Children run along the shore and into the sea. It's a delightful scene, and one that deeply charms and moves Hans. It feels criminal for him to look on this happy scene in his disheveled, miserable state.

The narration leaves it ambiguous, but readers can assume that Hans is either dreaming or hallucinating. Either way, the shame and misery Hans feels when he looks on this happy scene of children running along the shore—seemingly a callback to his childhood—seems to resonate with him in a meaningful way. Perhaps, in recognizing his own debasement, he might find it within himself to leave the Berghof.



Suddenly, Hans sees huge columns before him, and he realizes he's at the entrance to a temple. He walks up the stairs and toward the temple. He sees a statue of two women, one an older woman with a veil drawn over her hair and the other a young woman with a cloak draped around her. Hans suddenly feels anxious and afraid. He walks inside the temple and sees two half-naked elderly women dismembering a small, blond-haired child. Hans wants to run but can't seem to move. The women are intent to finish their task. When they see Hans they curse at him in German.

The sight of two women, apparently witches, dismembering a small, blond-haired child (perhaps a stand-in for Hans) cuts a sharp contrast to the earlier scene of children running along the beach. Hans, in this moment, seems to recognize the debasement he has subjected himself to since arriving at the Berghof. He has believed for so long that there is value in dignifying death and illness, yet he has struggled to identify where that value lies. Perhaps the solution to that conflict lies within this dream.



Hans loses consciousness. When he comes to, he's lying in the snow with his skis on. He knows he was dreaming but feels the lingering essence of the dream still within him. He muses to himself that his fixation with death and sickness is really just "an interest in life." He thinks that the ideas he's come up with are far better than anything he's heard from Settembrini and Naphta. He thinks that illness, death, and suffering really have more in common with one another than either man will admit. He thinks that the only force stronger than death is love—not reason, as Settembrini would argue. Eventually, after much wandering, he finds his way back to the Berghof and enjoys a sumptuous supper. By the time he goes to bed, he's forgotten the revelations he had in the snow earlier that day.

Hans comes to the realization that his interest in death and illness hasn't really been about death at all, but about "life." Importantly, he recognizes the limitations of rationality to assign meaning to life, death, or illness—after all, how can life have any meaning when there is so much suffering in the world, and when all life inevitably leads to death and decay? It is impossible to settle this incongruity using logic, Hans now realizes. The only thing that can lessen the pain and horror of death's inevitability is the comforting force of love and shared humanity. While this revelation might have marked a major development in Hans's journey toward maturity and self-knowledge, ultimately he is unable to sustain his newly achieved clarity upon his return to the dulling, anesthetizing atmosphere of the Berghof.



PART 6, CHAPTER 8: A GOOD SOLDIER

Joachim has been keeping in touch with Hans ever since he left. At first he writes with good news, detailing his rise through the ranks. By April, he's become a lieutenant. Joachim was made to serve in the military, and his postcards convey his happiness at his new life in the service. But in late spring, things take a turn for the worse: he's been put on a sick list and put on bed rest. Things improve by June, but then he's ordered to rest again. It's clear that he's worried he'll miss out on major tasks. At last, Hans receives a telegram from Joachim's mother telling him that the military has recommended Joachim return to the Alps and to reserve two rooms. Reading this, Hans is overcome with joy: Joachim will be back! He laments Joachim's bad luck, though, noting the misfortune that his body has turned on him.

When Hans relays the news to Behrens, Behrens isn't surprised at all. Hans spreads the news of Joachim's return to all the residents, and they receive this news with a mix of sadness and happiness. Soon, Joachim and his mother Luise Ziemssen arrive, and it's just like Hans's arrival, only the reverse. Hans is shocked to see Joachim dressed in civilian clothing—he'd been picturing Joachim in his uniform. Joachim calls him naïve. Luise greets Hans, trying to appear happy, but it's clear she's very worried about her son.

In the dining hall, Frau Ziemssen remembers that she recently met a young woman, a fellow patient, who wanted her to pass on her regards to Hans. Joachim confirms, quietly, that the woman is Frau Chauchat. Hans manages to conceal his emotions, feigning nonchalance. Frau Ziemssen explains that Clavdia plans to go to a sanatorium in Spain but wants to return to the Berghof that winter. Though Hans tries to conceal how Frau Ziemssen's news has affected him, it's made obvious by the ensuing awkward silence.

Joachim settles back into life at the Berghof, and Hans accepts it as his job to comfort and reassure his cousin. He insists that Joachim's time here will heal him and that he'll return to his service before he knows it. Settembrini stops by to welcome Joachim back, and Hans and Joachim resume their visits to Naphta, too. In short, things pick up where they were before Joachim left.

Joachim's post-Berghof life has followed the same grim trajectory as that of the typical residents who choose, against Behrens's advice, to re-enter society before they have fully recovered. Joachim accepted the risk involved in returning to his military service prematurely, and now he must accept the consequences that have come his way. Though Joachim, whose sense of duty has guided him all along, may still prefer facing these consequences to remaining at the Berghof and squandering his time and shirking his responsibilities.



Joachim's civilian clothes—and his remark about Hans being naïve—underscores his frank, practical personality. His uniform is useless to him now that he's too ill to serve in the military, and so wearing it would serve only as an empty, meaningless gesture. It would also convey a misguided optimism that he will improve enough to be able to return to his service. Joachim's civilian clothes, then, reflect what he has accepted (and what Hans has not): that if his condition changes at all, it will only be for the worse.



Hans's reaction to Frau Ziemssen's information about Clavdia reveals that he still has feelings for her. The detail of her asking Frau Ziemssen to pass on her regards to Hans, though deeply interesting to Hans, doesn't bode well for his future. Hans has remained at the Berghof so long at least partially out of hope that Clavdia will return. That she has communicated with him indirectly may reinvigorate his willingness to wait for her return, extending his stay at the Berghof even further.



Hans's eagerness to comfort and reassure Joachim reads as naïve and foolish. It illustrates his lingering immaturity. But it also suggests a shift in his character. Early in his stay at the Berghof, he resented residents and staff who ignored or denied the reality of death, illness, and suffering. Now, he foolishly promises Joachim that Joachim will be fully recovered in no time—an outcome that Hans can't possibly believe to be true.



On one of Hans's visits to Naphta, Naphta broaches the subject of freemasonry, noting that Settembrini belongs to the society. Naphta, of course, speaks critically of the organization, emphasizing the historical excesses of their rituals as well as its influence in world politics. When Hans later confronts Settembrini for his insider's perspective, Settembrini dismisses Naphta's criticism about the society being political, noting that "everything is politics." And, what's more, the task of the Freemason is a noble one: it's about governance and the improvement of humanity.

Naphta's attempt to discredit freemasonry by attacking its influence in world politics reflects his broader vision of reality, which divides the world into a physical or earthly realm and a spiritual realm. He is suggesting that freemasonry's involvement in earthly, political matters taints its higher spiritual aims. Settembrini's counterargument that "everything is politics" reinforces his own vision of reality, which contradicts Naphta's. To Settembrini, there is no difference between earthly, political concerns and higher, spiritual concerns. All spiritual aims have underlying human motivations.



Hans next asks if Settembrini or the Freemasons in general believe in God. While there is no unified group of Masons, Settembrini explains that if there were one, their motto would be *Écrasez l'infâme* ("crush the evil thing," meaning the Catholic Church). In general, Masons would maintain that metaphysical are evil, since they distract people from the important task of improving life on earth. When Hans muses that it's "terribly Catholic" to deny God in this way, Settembrini launches an attack on the Protestantism of Hans's native Germany, suggesting that Protestantism and Luther, its creator, possess dangerous "Eastern" traits.

Settembrini's disdain for metaphysics (which broadly encompasses philosophical concepts of an abstract nature, such as being, knowledge, and time) is somewhat ironic given that the humanism he practices in his own life is limited to abstraction and theorizing—his theoretical belief in humanity does not improve humanity in any practical, measurable way.



Settembrini continues, expressing his concern for the fate of modern Europe, which lies in Germany's hands. The country must choose between the Eastern and Western spheres it is trapped between. When Hans doesn't respond, Settembrini criticizes Hans and Germany's profound silence and rejection of "the articulate world," which he deems dangerous.

Settembrini's claim that Germany is trapped between Eastern and Western spheres seems to gesture toward the German Empire's alliance with the "Eastern" influence of the Ottoman Empire, which fought on the side of Germany and Central Powers in World War I, and Germany's historical embrace of "Western," Enlightenment ideals.



One day, Settembrini and Naphta engage in a very public altercation outside, which Hans, Joachim, Ferge, and Wehsal witness. The altercation takes place in front of the Kurhaus. The four Berghof boys are there having food and drinks when they run into Settembrini, and then Naphta stops by too. The conflict kicks off after Naphta criticizes Virgil, whom Settembrini values above all poets. Settembrini shoots back that the early Church would go out of its way to warn people against the lies of ancient poets and philosophers, but what they really feared was education. Ultimately, Settembrini concludes that his and Naphta's fight is a conflict "between literature and barbarism," and Settembrini is confident he knows which side the intelligent, impressionable youth will always take. Hans can't help but think this last comment is directed at him.

Naphta's critique of Virgil reinforces his disdain for the physical, earthly realm. Settembrini's retort criticizes the early Church's denouncement of ancient poets and philosophers, whose ideas underly Settembrini's humanist values of human progress. When Settembrini notes specifically that Naphta's position is rooted in a fear of education and that his fight is a conflict "between literature and barbarism," Settembrini is warning Hans not to be seduced by Naphta's logic, which is confused, illogical, and will compromise Hans's ability to reach intellectual maturity.



Settembrini and Naphta fight back and forth, with Settembrini asserting the voice of reason, progress, and humanism, and Naphta standing as the voice of “disciplined love” and religious experience. Hans is a bit distracted throughout the argument, though, noting how sickly Joachim appears. On the way home, Hans convinces Joachim to get his sore throat examined and get something to alleviate his suffering. The head nurse comes by Joachim’s room later, peers down his throat, and confirms that he’s come down with a cold. She leaves him with some medicine and bandages. After Behrens examines him, it’s clear that Joachim won’t be making another “fraudulent” exit from the Berghof. He needs to make a full recovery if he wants to return to his military service.

Hans starts seeing a fearful expression in Joachim’s eyes. Once, he sees this expression in the dining hall when Joachim chokes on something and coughs so hard he can’t catch his breath. He runs from the dining hall to finish his coughing in private. He returns a while later, smiling and apologetic.

Later, Behrens examines Joachim’s throat and determines that it will have to be painted every day. He sets to work preparing the cauterant. Later, Hans tries to comfort Joachim, insisting that Behrens knows what he’s doing and will cure him. Joachim doesn’t respond. Gradually, the “honor-loving” Joachim grows dismal and obstinate. He stops making eye contact and spends a lot of time alone out on his balcony.

After many failed attempts, Hans manages to get Behrens alone to interrogate him about Joachim’s health. Surely, Hans asks the doctor, Joachim’s condition is “harmless,” right? Behrens scoffs at Hans for always wanting everything to be “harmless.” He accuses Hans of asking him to sugarcoat the truth in order to comfort him—of not being able to accept struggle. Joachim, Behrens declares, is just the opposite: he sees things how they are, accepts them, and says nothing. He knew the possible consequences of his choice to return to the military, and now he’s accepting what’s come his way. In short, he’s a real man.

Earlier, Hans wanted to believe that suffering ennobles the sufferer. Now, he insists that Joachim receive treatment to alleviate his suffering. This dissonance reveals Hans’s naivety and inexperience, as well as the superficial, tenuous nature of his ideals. At the end of the day, he fails to translate his abstract, hypothetical ideals into tangible action. Joachim, on the other hand, will have the chance to prove his unwavering commitment to his own ideals: he made a “fraudulent” exit from the Berghof to honor his duty as a soldier, and now he may pay for that act with his life.



Joachim’s fearful expression indicates his growing awareness that he may soon die. Hans is the protagonist of this coming-of-age story, but it seems that Joachim will be the first young character to reach self-awareness.



Joachim’s condition worsens. While Hans seems to be in denial about the increasingly real possibility that Joachim will die, Joachim’s obstinance and dismal mood suggest that he has finally realized that his commitment to honor has sealed his fate. His premature return to his military service has caused his health to deteriorate, and now he must accept the consequences.



Hans’s foolish belief that Joachim’s condition is “harmless” illustrates his naivety. It also reveals that his earlier insistence on dignifying and accepting death was theoretical. When faced with the reality of Joachim’s imminent death, Hans’s ideals fall apart, and he reverts to denial. Joachim, on the other hand, who has never shared Hans’s philosophical interest in death, steadfastly and honorably accepts the reality of his own mortality. Whereas Joachim’s coming-of-age journey ends with self-acceptance, Hans’s self-education stagnates.



Hans realizes the implication and confirms that things don't look good for Joachim. Behrens explains that Joachim's larynx is rapidly deteriorating. He urges Hans to be good to Joachim these next six to eight weeks. From then on, Joachim has his throat painted daily. He can't eat normal foods anymore, for fear of choking, and he's served stew and porridges instead. Hans and Joachim continue to take daily walks together, but Joachim keeps his head down and doesn't speak much. His eyes look sad all the time. When Hans accidentally walks in on Joachim talking with Marusya—whom, out of honor, he never once dared to speak with in all the months they sat at the same table—Hans knows that all is lost.

Soon, Joachim is bedridden. It's clear from his eyes that he wants his mother there. Behrens signs off on this, and Frau Ziemssen arrives as soon as possible. When she looks in Joachim's eyes, it's clear to her and Hans that Joachim knows he's dying. After his mother arrives, it becomes difficult for Joachim to shave, and a week later he has a thick, black beard. His face changes too, and it seems to Hans that in Joachim's final hours of life, he becomes an old man.

Joachim dies at seven o'clock in the evening. Hans and Frau Ziemssen are in the room with him. When it happens, Luise Ziemssen runs from the room crying, so it falls to Hans to gently "close the eyelids of the motionless form that no longer breathed." A nurse notifies Behrens, who comes to the room and silently observes Joachim's corpse. Behrens remarks that Joachim's "honor was the death of him," or perhaps it's the opposite: "death did him the honor." Not long after, arrangements are made for Joachim's body to be transported home. Soon, the coffin arrives. Hans lifts the corpse from the bed and places it inside. Two days later, Joachim appears to smile under his beard, and Hans is glad the professionals will soon pick up the coffin and take it away.

PART 7, CHAPTER 1: A STROLL BY THE SHORE

The narrator laments the difficulty of narrating time. Stories don't accurately present time—rather, they "fill" it, creating significance and division within it. There's also not necessarily a correlation between the literal duration of time a story covers and how long the story ends up being—ultimately, a story aims to convey time as one *experiences* it. In this way, then, this novel both "deal[s]" with time and treats time as "its *subject*." Hans's experience of time changes drastically the longer he remains at the Berghof, and it's impossible for "principled flatlanders" to understand exactly what he's going through. Increasingly, he finds it possible to separate the past from the present and future.

Behrens's advice to Hans to be good to Joachim in the time Joachim has left is practical rather than philosophical. Joachim's attraction to Marusya conflicts with his ideals of honor and duty, so he always suppressed his feelings for her. That Joachim finally speaks to her now indicates to Hans that Joachim has abandoned his honor, an act he would never be able to live with under normal circumstances. This is why observing Joachim with Marusya is what finally makes Hans realize that Joachim will soon die.



Joachim's careful, regular grooming was another way he maintained his sense of honor. His beard is thus further evidence that he has accepted his imminent death. The beard, combined with the weathered appearance of his face, makes Joachim look older than his years. This symbolizes how his illness has forced him to grow up and achieve self-awareness prematurely.



The description of Joachim as a "motionless form" indicates Hans's acceptance of Joachim's death. He realizes that the figure on the bed is no longer Joachim: it's the body Joachim used to inhabit. Behrens's remark that Joachim's "honor was the death of him" implies that Joachim's commitment to honor was foolish and caused his untimely death. When he corrects himself, suggesting that "death did him the honor," he suggests that there's actually something noble about Joachim's death: it signifies that he lived and died by his principles, a level of commitment of which few people are capable.



The narrator once more distinguishes between the literal passage of time and a person's subjective experience of time, explaining how The Magic Mountain's narrative style attempts to mimic a person's actual experience of time. The opening passage of Part 7 thus reminds readers to consider the critical role time plays in how a person makes sense of their life. Hans's time at the Berghof results in his diminished ability to register or find meaning in the passing time, and this corresponds with his increasingly weak grip on reality. As he loses his sense of time, he loses his sense of self.



The narrator describes a situation to which flatlanders might relate: losing one's sense of time and space when one becomes immersed in a beautiful landscape. This is like what might happen when one goes for a pleasant walk along the beach. In this situation, "you are lost to time and it to you." One's mind empties, and one feels completely lost in the moment and at peace.

Of course, moral people quickly grow bored of such experiences. They know that in order to honor and give meaning to life, one must return to one's duties. Joachim knew this, but he was a "zealot" about it, and that's perhaps why he died. The narrator, giving Hans the benefit of the doubt, suggests that perhaps Hans recognized that Joachim's rigid commitment to duty was what killed him, and so he tried to go about things differently. Perhaps this is what motivated Hans in "his disgraceful management of time, his wicked dawdling with eternity[.]"

PART 7, CHAPTER 2: MYNHEER PEEPERKORN

Mynheer Peeperkorn, an old, colonial Dutchman from Java and recently retired from the coffee trade, arrives at the Berghof with Madame Clavdia Chauchat the night she returns, and they dine at the sanatorium's restaurant that evening. He takes all his meals sitting beside Clavdia at the Good Russian table. Behrens doesn't know where Clavdia found him, but he's heard that the two share all traveling expenses and that Peeperkorn is quite wealthy. He adds that Peeperkorn is at the Berghof as a resident—he has alcohol-induced mucus obstruction and suffers some sort of tropical fever. Peeperkorn is a tall, large man with a thin beard and "quite small and pale" eyes. Hans describes Peeperkorn as "robust and yet spare," a curious pair of traits that often don't go hand in hand. Behrens says Hans will have to get used to the idea of Peeperkorn—he's here to stay.

Peeperkorn has an entertaining, loud personality that attracts an attentive audience at his dining table, even if what he says comes out as "incomprehensible phrases." At other times, Peeperkorn seems to be on the verge of saying something grand and important, only to ultimately say nothing at all.

The scene the narrator describes here is idyllic and positive: it's likely that many readers can relate to the sense of relief and calm that results from witnessing something beautiful and uncomplicated, like a glorious landscape, and momentarily forgetting all the time-sensitive problems and anxieties that normally consume one's days.



Here, the narrator presents Hans and Joachim as embodying opposite ends of a spectrum of time management, with Joachim's careful time management at one end and Hans's "disgraceful management of time" at the other. The narrator suggests, somewhat ironically, that Joachim's careful time management—his eagerness to return to his military service at the cost of his health—was his downfall and that this justifies Hans's choice to stay at the Berghof and remain aimless.



Hans's hope to see Clavdia again has at least partially motivated his choice to remain at the Berghof. Now that she has returned, seemingly with a new lover, one might predict that Hans will realize how naïve and misguided his dream of resuming a romance with Clavdia has been all along. The narration introduces Mynheer Peeperkorn as Hans's opposite. While Hans is young, bourgeois, and only moderately ill, Peeperkorn is old, wealthy, and apparently quite ill. The detail of his illness being the result of excessive consumption of alcohol, meanwhile, suggests that he has a penchant for decadent vices. He embodies, in short, the irrational and sensual personality that Hans strives—and perpetually fails—to achieve.



Peeperkorn's captivating and bold personality conceals his inner emptiness: in fact, his thoughts are irrational, and he has nothing of substance to say. Given Hans's track record of gravitating toward superficially interesting personalities like Naphta and Clavdia, not recognizing that their outer gravitas obscures their vapid, destructive interiors, readers may predict that Hans will become similarly captivated by Peeperkorn.



Once, Peeperkorn approaches the serving woman in the dining hall (who has dwarfism) and exuberantly lets her know that he doesn't mind her smallness. In fact, he says, he thinks it's great and reflects her modest character, which is also great. He adds that he would like a small favor from her. He also asks her name (Emerentia), and this makes her blush with satisfaction.

Peeperkorn rambles on about various unrelated subjects before getting to the point and asking Emerentia for a glass of gin served neat. Emerentia obeys immediately, abandoning her other work to bring Peeperkorn his drink. Once she returns with his drink, he takes Clavdia's hand in his own and looks on at his fellow tablemates "with refreshed eyes."

Everyone at the Berghof is quite taken with Peeperkorn, and they all notice the expensive necklace around Clavdia's neck and look at Hans with pitying glances. And indeed, the unexpected circumstances surrounding Clavdia's return to the Berghof hit Hans hard. During mealtimes, Clavdia doesn't look at Hans, and she and Peeperkorn keep to themselves during social hours. Later, Hans learns that Behrens has diagnosed Peeperkorn as having "Quartan fever," since he falls ill with it every fourth day and suffers a fever and chills, as well as a swollen spleen.

PART 7, CHAPTER 3: VINGT ET UN

A few weeks or so pass, and one night the socializing in the lobby turns a bit more festive than usual—even Krokowski and Behrens join in. Hans, meanwhile, sits apart from the crowd in the reading room, scanning a newspaper. Suddenly, a voice behind him inquires about his cousin. Hans turns and sees Clavdia Chauchat. Hans slowly puts down his newspaper and assess Clavdia coldly before telling her that Joachim returned to his military service, got sick, came back to the Berghof, and then died. Clavdia expresses her condolences, calling Joachim a "much finer man than most—than certain people." She also reminds Hans that she predicted Joachim would die if he resumed his military service. Hans says he knows, addressing Clavdia with informal pronouns, and an awkward silence follows.

Peeperkorn's obnoxious flattering of Emerentia illustrates his tendency to ramble and lose focus—he has no sense of urgency or purpose, and by extension, no regard for time management. Further illustrating this point is Peeperkorn's choice to order a glass of straight gin despite having an alcohol-induced illness, which suggests that he's in no hurry to recover and leave the Berghof.



Peeperkorn's exuberance, wealth, and obvious romantic attachment to Clavdia give him an unsurmountable advantage over Hans in the competition for Clavdia's love. Of course, her refusal to directly interact with or even make eye contact with Hans suggests that no such competition exists: Clavdia is not interested in Hans, and yet Hans irrationally chooses to pine for her anyway.



Hans tries to conceal his heartbreak by giving Clavdia the cold shoulder and then intentionally addressing her with informal pronouns in an attempt to agitate her (recall how at the Walpurgis party the night before her departure, she scolded Hans for addressing her in this way). Clavdia's remarks about Joachim read as mocking or ironic—she's not really praising him for being a "much finer man than most," since it was, in her opinion, his honorable character and bourgeois sensibilities that ultimately (if indirectly) caused his death.



Gradually the conversation resumes, and Clavdia is shocked to discover that Hans has been here at the Berghof the entire time she's been gone—and waiting for her. He also says he's still sick: Behrens recently discovered a new “moist spot” in Hans's lungs, which is what's causing Hans's constant, albeit mild, fever. Hans asks Clavdia where she's been all this time, and she talks about her travels to Moscow, her stays at German spas, and a trip to Spain. When the subject of Peeperkorn comes up, Hans scowls and mockingly insults the man's tendency to ramble and never get his point across. Hans asks Clavdia if she still has his “interior portrait,” but her answer is vague. He replies that he still has hers—and carries it with him at all times.

Just then, Peeperkorn arrives, interrupting Hans and Clavdia's stilted conversation. Clavdia introduces the men to each other. It's clear to Hans that Peeperkorn likes him, though it's also clear that he has inferred the truth about Hans's past relations with Clavdia. Clavdia, taking a hint from Peeperkorn's friendly gestures, suggests that they stick around the reading room, assemble a group, and drink some wine and play a game. Peeperkorn orders Hans to go off and find some friends to join them. Hans goes upstairs and rounds up Ferge, Wehsal, and Herr Albin. He also gets Frau Stöhr, Fräulein Kleefeld, and the Magnuses. Clavdia and Peeperkorn gather their own guests, and in the end there are a dozen people gathered in the reading room. Peeperkorn orders Emerentia to get them three bottles of wine to start. Then everyone settles down to play *vingt et un*.

Some people play for low stakes, and other people play for high stakes. But to everyone, the gambling isn't the main attraction of the game: it's witnessing Mynheer Peeperkorn in his element, even if most everything he says is utter nonsense. Peeperkorn orders lots of food for the table. When it arrives, he takes a few bites and angrily deems it inedible, a move that's out of character for the normally jovial personality. Clavdia calms him, reassuring him that he can just order something else. Peeperkorn relents and kisses Clavdia's hand. He gives the serving staff money to convince them to return the food to the kitchen to be redone, and he's satisfied with the replacement meal.

As with most of Hans's intellectual pursuits and hobbies, his effort to conceal his feelings for Clavdia is short-lived. Within moments of their official reunion, he effectively admits to staying at the Berghof with the sole intention of seeing Clavdia again. His mention of the newly discovered “moist spot” in his lungs is a desperate and flimsy attempt to conceal the true reason for his extended stay at the Berghof—from Clavdia, and perhaps from himself. When Clavdia won't confirm that she has kept Hans's “interior portrait” (his X-ray image), Hans should take this as a hint that she's not interested in him, but he naively and irrationally disregards her disinterest and further embarrasses himself by admitting to carrying her X-ray image everywhere.



While Hans assumes a submissive role in his interactions with Clavdia, continuing to pine for her even as she toys with his emotions, Clavdia assumes a submissive role in her relationship with Peeperkorn. Feeling obligated to soothe any discomfort Peeperkorn might feel at being alone with Clavdia and Hans, given his knowledge of their romantic history (if what they had can even be called that), she goes out of her way to assemble a larger group and alleviate any social tension.



Peeperkorn's superficiality is on full display in this passage: he is a captivating speaker with nothing to say, and he indulges greedily in vices. His sudden anger over the supposedly subpar food reveals his lack of emotional restraint—he is essentially a moody and overgrown child, spouting nonsense and reacting indiscriminately and unpredictably. He is the embodiment of the sort of decadent, irrational personality that the atmosphere of the Berghof produces.



Hans smokes, and Clavdia joins him. Peeperkorn disapproves of smoking, deeming it an “over-refined pleasure[.]” that detracts from “the simpler gifts of life.” Then he goes off on an enthusiastic tangent praising the simple pleasures of life and lamenting the many people society has cast out for simply enjoying themselves—and also lamenting the great sin of turning to “over-refined pleasures” and overlooking life’s simple pleasures. Peeperkorn pauses. When nobody responds, Hans sees “a flicker of terror” in Peeperkorn’s eyes, and so Hans jumps in to voice his full and enthusiastic agreement with what Peeperkorn has just said.

Peeperkorn’s disapproval of smoking further illustrates his irrationality: he dismisses smoking as an “over-refined pleasure[.],” yet it’s unclear why he doesn’t extend that criticism to his own excessive eating and drinking. His distinction between “over-refined pleasures” and simple pleasures makes little sense, yet Hans chooses to humor him anyway. Hans’s sudden impulse to protect his competitor’s ego is irrational but not out of character for Hans, whose ambivalence is among his defining features and who has increasingly acted out of self-destruction rather than self-improvement.



Peeperkorn praises Hans’s response but admits that he isn’t yet ready to address Hans using informal pronouns. He might, someday, but it’s too soon right now. Hans gestures to show that he agrees. He also realizes that Peeperkorn is quite drunk—and that drunkenness does little to diminish Peeperkorn’s radiant character. Peeperkorn goes off on a tangent about life, emotion, and passion. He laments the “defeat of feeling in the face of life,” which he likens to “Doomsday,” and Hans considers how the word “Doomsday” perfectly encapsulates Peeperkorn’s character. Hans realizes that neither of his mentors has used the word before.

Though Hans initially resented Peeperkorn for Peeperkorn’s relationship with Clavdia, this passage indicates that Hans is already beginning to come around to the man, as his joy at Peeperkorn’s suggestion that he might one day address Hans using informal pronouns suggests. Peeperkorn’s garbled remarks about life defeating feeling and Doomsday underscore the decadence that underlies his character. He pursues passion and pleasure to the point of self-destruction with no regard for life or longevity. When Hans muses that “Doomsday” encapsulates Peeperkorn’s character, he acknowledges Peeperkorn’s self-destructive nature—but, notably, he does not condemn it.



When Peeperkorn pauses his speech, Hans interjects to argue that, perhaps, enjoying life’s “over-refined pleasures” signifies an embrace rather than a rejection of life. He continues incoherently for a bit before realizing how drunk he is and trails off. Peeperkorn listens in silence, and Hans senses anger building inside the large man. In response, Hans backtracks and praises the vice the group is presently enjoying—wine. He muses philosophically about “culture” really being about “enthusiasm” rather than “well-articulated sobriety.” Hans’s maneuver apparently works, and Peeperkorn’s anger appears to subside.

Hans’s hesitant yet eager desire to engage Peeperkorn in philosophical debate mirrors his earlier interactions with Settembrini and Naphta. It’s unclear whether Hans’s interest in Peeperkorn stems from his desire to win Peeperkorn’s favor, from his naïve failure to recognize Peeperkorn for the irrational fool he really is, or from his own compulsion toward self-destruction.



Clavdia interrupts to tell Peeperkorn that he isn’t paying enough attention to his guests, who are getting bored. She suggests they end the party now. Peeperkorn rouses himself and orders champagne and petits fours for the table. The card game is over by this point, and people stick around to make drunken small talk. The party is still in full swing at 1:00 in the morning. Peeperkorn flirts with Emerentia and Frau Stöhr, causing both women to blush. Women, Peeperkorn remarks, are “doomsday.”

When Peeperkorn refers to women (and earlier, to the familiarity of brotherhood) as “doomsday,” he’s saying something to the effect of “my weakness for women will be the death of me.” This reinforces his characteristic decadence. Peeperkorn’s self-destructive, irrational, and decadent personality make him a dubious and potentially dangerous mentor for Hans.



A bit later, word spreads that Behrens is heading their way to break up the party, and people begin to panic. Peeperkorn calls everyone “spineless slaves,” but he settles down after Clavdia and Hans remind him that his party has lasted six hours already and has to end eventually. He asks Clavdia and Hans to help him to his room, and they oblige. Hans declares what an honor it is to be allowed to escort such “a manifest personality” to his room. Peeperkorn brushes off Hans’s obnoxious praise. Then he orders Hans and Clavdia to kiss each other goodnight, but Hans refuses. As Hans retreats to his own room, Peeperkorn remains frozen in shock by Hans’s “act of insubordination.”

Peeperkorn's temper tantrum at being forced to end his party is ridiculous and played for comedy: a tuberculosis sanatorium is hardly an appropriate place for a party, and especially a late-night, drunken party. Hans continues to humor Peeperkorn when he declares it an honor to escort such “a manifest personality” to his room, yet he also seems to genuinely believe in what he says: when he refuses to kiss Clavdia goodnight, it seems to be out of respect for Peeperkorn, though his efforts backfire when Peeperkorn takes greater offense to this “act of insubordination.”



PART 7, CHAPTER 4: MYNHEER PEEPERKORN (CONTINUED)

Mynheer Peeperkorn stays at the Berghof into the spring. The longer Hans knows him, the more his two former mentors’ influence fades. In time, he starts to refer to Settembrini and Naphta as “little chatterboxes,” which is what Peeperkorn calls them. Hans makes it a point not to judge Peeperkorn unfairly simply because he’s Clavdia’s “traveling companion.” After all, Hans only borrowed a pencil from Clavdia at a holiday party—that’s all they are to each other.

Peeperkorn offers nothing of intellectual worth to Hans, and yet Hans eagerly lets Peeperkorn replace Settembrini and Naphta as his go-to mentor, nevertheless. In fact, he’s so determined to endear himself to Peeperkorn that he tries (unconvincingly) to minimize his own feelings toward Clavdia. Hans’s poor judgment reaffirms his youth and naivety as well as his increasing push toward self-destruction.



The day after Peeperkorn’s grand party, all the residents who attended feel quite ill, Peeperkorn included. Hans goes to visit Peeperkorn in his room, which is separated from Clavdia’s by a parlor, and he notices that Peeperkorn’s room is much more elaborately decorated than most rooms at the sanatorium. He finds Peeperkorn lying in bed, wearing a long wool shirt with an open collar. Strikingly, the clothing makes him look less bourgeois and more working class. Peeperkorn, in his characteristically rambling manner, apologizes for overdoing it last night.

Peeperkorn's well-decorated room reflects his decadence. His plain wool shirt, set in contrast to the elaborate décor of his room, might symbolize the empty interior that his bold, obnoxious exterior conceals.



Peeperkorn offers Hans some of the leftover sparkling wine—it’s the best thing for a swift recovery. Hans accepts, and they clink glasses. Clavdia appears and urges Peeperkorn to take some brown, syrupy medicine on his counter. Peeperkorn offers Hans some, too, explaining that it revitalizes the system. Hans accepts and soon finds that the cordial, “china-bark,” also has quite the intoxicating effect. Peeperkorn talks of “medicines and poisons” and of love potions that “primitive peoples” on the islands of New Guinea would make from various barks, leaves, and herbs.

Peeperkorn's overindulgence has left him incapacitated, yet he continues to indulge, nonetheless. This illustrates his self-destructive and irrational personality. Hans's willingness to indulge alongside Peeperkorn indicates his interest in such self-destructive behavior—he finds it liberating, just as he found Herr Albin's antagonistic behavior and Clavdia's poor manners liberating. The detail that the cordial Peeperkorn offers Hans is made of “china-bark” signals Peeperkorn's association with Eastern culture.



From that point forward, Hans sits and listens to Peeperkorn talk. Sometimes, Wehsal and Ferge accompany him to Peeperkorn's room, as do Settembrini and Naphta. Hans is glad to introduce everyone to Peeperkorn, and to Clavdia, as well. As Hans expected, his friends all get used to each other, though there's a lot of lingering tension among them. But, perhaps due to his "life-affirming [...] nature, which allowed him to find everything 'worth listening to,'" Hans manages to keep the group together. Hans remains foolishly in love with Clavdia, though this love is tempered by a caution of "what his devotion was worth [...] to the slinking patient with the enchanting 'Tartar slits[.]'"

In his bedroom, Mynheer Peeperkorn doesn't seem quite as grand as he does in an open space. He seems smaller and more "compressed," though he's still a great deal larger than Naphta or Settembrini. One day, Settembrini confronts Hans about his apparent worship of Peeperkorn, who is "just a stupid old man." Settembrini could understand if Hans were just using Peeperkorn to get close to Clavdia, but it's clear that Hans is far more interested in Peeperkorn. Settembrini mockingly mimics Peeperkorn's exaggerated, "cultured" gestures. Hans merely laughs and replies that Peeperkorn may be stupid, but "cleverness" is a kind of stupidity, too. Settembrini tells Hans that what he's most concerned about is Hans's fixation with Peeperkorn's "personality." He thinks it's a grave mistake to "turn[] personality into an enigma," which quickly turns into "idol-worship." Settembrini lectures Hans a bit, but they part on mostly good terms.

Meanwhile, Naphta and Settembrini continue to engage in impassioned intellectual debates. In one, Settembrini condemns the Church as antidemocratic and disrespecting of human individuality. Naphta retorts that canon law (unlike earthly law) requires of members "orthodoxy and membership in the ecclesiastical community." One can't say the same of Roman law, or Germanic law. The argument continues as all their arguments do, with either side debating the superior nobility of their position and the inferiority of the other's.

Hans seems to accept Peeperkorn as his latest unofficial mentor, carrying out the ritual by which he accepted his earlier mentors, admiring him on his own at first and then inviting his peers to listen to them speak after that. The narrator's remark about Hans "find[ing] everything 'worth listening to'" reads as ironic: nothing that Peeperkorn says is worth listening to, yet Hans seems unaware of this.



That Peeperkorn's size changes based on his surroundings reveals a key limitation of his bold personality: he can only flourish when he has a captive audience to listen to him and approve of his incoherent ramblings. But Hans seems not to notice this, as his interest in Peeperkorn, whom Settembrini correctly describes as "just a stupid old man," makes clear. Hans defends Peeperkorn's irrationality even when doing so requires Hans himself to resort to irrationality, paradoxically reasoning that Peeperkorn's stupidity is no more stupid than "cleverness." Hans, it seems, is no longer trying to minimize or conceal his irrational or self-destructive behavior.



In this debate, Settembrini and Naphta continue to debate beliefs central to their characters. This passage reinforces Settembrini as an impassioned supporter of democracy and personal liberty—forces geared toward improving the quality of life of humans on earth. Naphta, meanwhile, argues that earthly institutions of power are inferior to spiritual institutions of power. His stance elevates spiritual law at the expense of laws designed to improve humankind's quality of life on earth. In this way, then, he demonstrates a disregard for life. Just as Hans has tried to find honor and dignity in human suffering, Naphta believes that the promise of eternal salvation validates any earthly form of suffering. In fact, it justifies the glorification of suffering.



The narrator notes how Peeperkorn's presence has a "neutraliz[ing]" effect on Settembrini and Naphta's intellectualism. While Naphta and Settembrini flourish when arguing about abstract, theoretical concepts, they wither when forced to confront "earthy, practical affairs"—the practical realm is all Peeperkorn's. On one occasion, he brushes aside their talk of "asceticism" and "indulgence" and enthusiastically redirects their focus upward, toward an eagle he has just spotted in the sky.

One night, the lobby has mostly emptied, with most residents having retired to their rooms to take their final rest cure. But Clavdia has lingered behind in the reading room, and so Hans lingers in the lobby. She approaches him from behind wearing a dark silk gown. She explains that the concierge is gone and asks Hans if he'll lend her a postage stamp, but he doesn't have any. In reply, she sits down next to him and asks if she can at least have a cigarette. Hans offers her one, explaining that he always has them. He's not a passionate man, he admits, but he does allow for some "detached passions," like smoking. Clavdia says she wouldn't expect Hans to be passionate—the Germans, after all, believe that life is about "experience," whereas passion is about "forget[ting] oneself." She thinks this perspective makes Hans "the enemy of humankind."

Clavdia's observation upsets Hans, who gets up to leave. She begs him to stay, mockingly lamenting not being able to rely on an unpassionate man such as Hans. Hans and Clavdia have a strained conversation. Clavdia criticizes Hans for sticking around the Berghof and waiting for her. Hans defends his choice, explaining that he's a civilian, unlike Joachim, and that it would be an act of desert[ion] to return to the flatlands prematurely. Hans admits that he now feels confident that "the love of death leads to the love of life and humanity." Clavdia listens to his philosophical musings and mockingly deems him a "genius."

This passage contrasts Peeperkorn with Settembrini and Naphta. Peeperkorn is only concerned with the external, sensual world and has no interest in abstract concepts or intellectual debate. Settembrini and Naphta, on the other and, cannot translate their abstract ideals into meaningful action.



Hans's remark about allowing himself some "detached passions" seems to be his attempt to show Clavdia that he can give in to Peeperkorn, yet Clavdia correctly identifies Hans's practice of self-indulgence as carefully calculated and moderated—to be passionate is to "experience" things in the moment and to "forget oneself." Hans might be lazy and directionless, but he's consistently too stuck inside his own head, torn between his impulse to be passionate and irrational and the rigid commitment to honorable social norms he grew up with. When Clavdia calls Hans's German sensibilities "the enemy of humankind," she is suggesting that suppressing one's passions negatively affects one's quality of life.



The irony of Hans's choice to act passionately and irrationally, remaining at the Berghof and awaiting Clavdia's return, is that his behavior has in fact denied him the chance to fully experience life. His passion is inactive and theoretical, based not on reality but on the false, hopeful belief that Clavdia might one day return his affections. Hans's conclusion that loving death teaches one to love life is similarly flimsy. If his theory were true—if seeing so much death and suffering instilled in him a new appreciation for life—would he not leave the Berghof immediately and vow to take full advantage of all the time he has left on earth? Instead, he stays at the Berghof, wallowing in self-pity over a seemingly nonexistent illness and justifying his actions with half-baked philosophical musings.



Hans talks about how difficult it has been to see Clavdia in the company of Peeperkorn. He tells Clavdia he can understand why she loves a “personality” like Peeperkorn and asks her to confirm that this is so—that she loves him. Clavdia playfully refuses to answer, but then she admits that Peeperkorn’s love for her is what makes her “proud and grateful and devoted to him.” She thinks this is a human thing, this not being able “to disregard his feelings[.]” She adds that there is something “fearful” about his love for her. She thinks it’s an innately feminine trait to “risk being demeaned for the sake of a man,” and Hans agrees that there’s a sort of nobility in “being demeaned.”

Clavdia admits that she finds Hans’s “detach[ment]” frustrating, and thus in contrast to Peeperkorn’s effusive passion. Even so, she’s glad that Hans has been respectful toward Peeperkorn rather than hating him for being with Clavdia. At this point, Clavdia turns to Hans, looks him in the eye, and asks if they might begin a friendship. She’s a bit wary of giving all her emotions to Peeperkorn. She would “love to have some good person on [her] side,” she explains, and perhaps this is why she returned to the Berghof. Hans starts to protest, but then Clavdia moves in and kisses him on the mouth, with the great emotion of “one of those Russian kisses.” The narrator can’t help but compare this kiss to one of Krokowski’s lectures about love, in which it’s never clear whether he’s talking about spiritual love or earthly, lustful love.

Sometime later, Hans pays Peeperkorn a visit at his bedside, effusively proclaiming what an honor it is that Peeperkorn allows Hans to be in his company. They talk about their trip to town yesterday and about the lavish food they ate. Settembrini was there too, and Peeperkorn notes Settembrini and Clavdia’s mutual disdain for each other. Hans changes the subject to talk about love, musing about how naturally a woman, when asked if she loves a man, speaks of the man in question’s love for her. He thinks it would be ludicrous to imagine such an exchange if the genders were reversed. Peeperkorn agrees.

It’s unclear whether Clavdia genuinely loves Peeperkorn. What attracts her to him most is his love for her—the way its “fearful” intensity compels her to submit to him. Clavdia describes her submissiveness as a feminine trait. Given that the book positions Clavdia as a stand-in for Eastern sensibilities in a general sense, then, the power dynamics at play in her and Peeperkorn’s relationship symbolizes what the novel presents as the submissive, weak (in the book’s reductive and overgeneralized view of femininity) traits of antidemocratic Eastern nations.



Clavdia’s description of Hans as “detach[ed]” is on point. Though he has made it his goal to find personal freedom by exiting the constraints of ordinary society and rejecting social norms, he has not found any real pursuit to replace his former participation in society, and as a result he has become lost and aimless, neither acting solely in pursuit of pleasure nor for the betterment of society. Clavdia’s proposal that she and Hans be friends—followed by a kiss that sends Hans mixed messages about her real intentions—further cements Hans’s existence in his confused, aimless state of limbo. He can neither act on his passion for Clavdia nor abandon that passion altogether.



Hans continues to flatter Peeperkorn, doing all he can to boost the man’s ego. He assumes a submissive role not unlike Clavdia’s. At the same time, Hans’s musings about love, which are clearly inspired by his earlier conversation with Clavdia, seem geared toward agitating Peeperkorn—Hans seems to want Peeperkorn to know (or at least suspect) that he and Clavdia are confidants, perhaps hoping to make Peeperkorn jealous. Hans’s ambivalence toward Peeperkorn—he can’t seem to decide whether he wants the man to respect or feel threatened by him—reflects his youth. He remains just as confused about what he wants and what he believes in as ever before. In choosing to stay at the Berghof and becoming lost to the world, he has become lost to himself, as well.



Suddenly, Peeperkorn turns to Hans and asks if Hans loves Clavdia. The question flusters Hans, but Peeperkorn remains calm. He acknowledges that Hans has a history with Clavdia. He also knows that while Clavdia is a young, charming woman, he himself is merely a sick, old man. Hans tries to respond honestly but respectfully. Peeperkorn grows increasingly upset as he wonders whether Clavdia returns Hans's love, suspecting that Clavdia has "followed her feelings" back to the Berghof. He admits that he knew the truth about Hans and Clavdia's history the moment Hans very purposefully chose not to kiss Clavdia on the brow the night of Peeperkorn's party.

Hans's flustered response to Peeperkorn's accusation shows just how haphazard and confused his interactions with Peeperkorn have been. It was Hans who brought up the subject of love, specifically alluding to the type of love Clavdia and Peeperkorn's relationship has embodied. And it was Hans who very strangely and obviously refused to kiss Clavdia in front of Peeperkorn after the party. Given this, it would seem that Hans has wanted, if only subconsciously, for Peeperkorn to sense Hans's feelings for Clavdia. Yet when Peeperkorn does so, Hans reacts as though he had no expectation or hope that it would happen. Hans continues to act irrationally and self-destructively, and this emphasizes his continued downward spiral.



Hans backtracks and asks Peeperkorn if he may take a moment to complain about his "life and fate." Peeperkorn agrees and gestures for Hans to speak. Hans begins, explaining that he's been at the Berghof for years now. He describes the onset of his gradual fixation with Clavdia, and of his eternal refusal to address her with formal pronouns. He also explains how, despite Settembrini's warnings, he became obsessed with "irrationality," all out of his love for Clavdia. When Clavdia left, Hans remained at the Berghof, waiting for her to return. He waited so long, in fact, that he no longer writes home, and "the flatlands is entirely lost to [him] now, and in its eyes [he is] as good as dead."

In Hans's account, his passion—his obsession with "irrationality," as he puts it—has not let to his personal freedom, as he initially hoped it would. It has not been a pleasurable experience that has improved his quality of life. Instead, it has figuratively lead to his death: consumed by unrequited passion, he becomes detached from reality, "the flatlands is entirely lost to [him] now, and in its eyes [he is] as good as dead." What Hans fails to acknowledge, though, is that it's not too late to resurrect himself, so to speak: he is free to leave the Berghof and re-enter society, just as he always has been.



Hans finishes his speech. Peeperkorn looks at Hans meaningfully and expresses regret for the pain that his and Clavdia's arrival has caused Hans. Then he asks Hans to recall the moment, early in their acquaintanceship, when he told Hans that he wasn't yet ready to use informal pronouns with each other. Now, Peeperkorn declares, that time has passed: they will address each other informally, as brothers. Hans is beyond elated and tells Peeperkorn it's an honor. They drink together, and then Peeperkorn urges Hans to get going—"our beloved" may return soon, and it would probably be a bit awkward for them to all be together just now.

Peeperkorn, in declaring that he and Hans will now address each other with informal pronouns, as brothers, invites Hans to remain lost to the world. When Peeperkorn refers to Clavdia as "our beloved," he acknowledges their passion for her as the source of their mutual entrapment. Hans, in excitedly accepting Peeperkorn's offer, volunteers to stay at the Berghof and to remain lost to the world, wallowing in self-pity over his unrequited passion for Clavdia. Hans's decision is self-destructive and irrational. Though he acknowledges how much his passion for Clavdia has cost him, he fails to act on that knowledge, and this underscores his failure to learn from his mistakes and translate his abstract thoughts into real actions.



PART 7, CHAPTER 5: MYNHEER PEEPERKORN (CONCLUSION)

It's May now, and lately Peeperkorn's sickness has considerably limited his activities. He hasn't hosted many social gatherings, and his and Hans's walks have been limited to short, casual strolls around the Berghof's grounds. But one day Peeperkorn arranges an outing to a waterfall in the forests of the Flüela Valley, located about an hour's drive away. Wehsal and Ferge join Hans, Peeperkorn, and Clavdia, and the group takes two carriages. Clavdia, Ferge, and Peeperkorn climb into one carriage, and Hans and Wehsal take the other.

Clavdia, as she climbs into the first carriage, flashes a pitying smile at Hans, which Wehsal notices and teases Hans about. Hans accuses Wehsal of being cruel because of his own lovesickness over Clavdia. Wehsal admits this is true. Though he tried to forget Clavdia while she was away, it proved impossible: "because life is desire, and desire is life[.]" But it's not just Clavdia's body he desires—it's her face, specifically. And once a person desires another's face, that's when lust becomes love. This is when a person loves not just the flesh, but the "soul." He curses Clavdia for having a body and a soul, and for her soul having no interest in his. Wehsal goes on and on, despite Hans's warnings that the driver can hear and understand everything he says. Eventually Wehsal quiets down.

The carriages arrive in town to pick up Settembrini and Naphta at their lodging house. Naphta joins Clavdia, Ferge, and Peeperkorn's carriage while Settembrini joins Hans and Wehsal's, and then the party continues on its way. The drive into the mountain forests is beautiful, with great views of new grass and wildflowers. As they get closer to their destination, the woods take on a "picturesque, indeed exotic, eerie" character. There are hardly any pine needles on the trees, which are instead covered with moss, as though "cast under a sickly spell." As the carriages continue onward, the sound of the waterfall grows louder and louder.

While Hans's illness seems mild at worst, Peeperkorn's is serious enough to significantly affect his daily life. Once more, the novel emphasizes the pointless and confused nature of Hans's behavior. It is irrational and unnecessary for him to remain at the Berghof. On top of this, he's not getting much out of staying there: waiting for Clavdia hasn't led her to reciprocate his love, and he hasn't grown much as a person in his own right. The trip to the waterfall will be important to Peeperkorn, given that his illness has lately barred him from hosting social gatherings—something he desperately needs to validate his fragile, tenuous ego.



Hans's impatience for Wehsal's self-pity betrays Hans's own self-denial. He fails to recognize the many ways in which his own lovesickness over Clavdia is just as pointless as Wehsal's: Hans, after all, has voluntarily wasted years of his life to remain at a sanatorium, awaiting the possible return of a woman who clearly does not reciprocate his intense feelings for her. Hans's lack of self-awareness in this passage underscores how little he has matured in all his years at the Berghof.



The "exotic, eerie" appearance of the beautiful, natural landscape—in particular the moss, which appears as though "cast under a sickly spell"—emphasizes the party's warped, unnatural grasp on reality. The controlled, surreal atmosphere of the Berghof, combined with the perpetual presence of death, leaves residents unaccustomed to the life-affirming display of natural beauty they see before them now. The ominous atmosphere of the waterfall also foreshadows that something dangerous or unsettling might happen on today's outing.



Eventually, they arrive, and everyone hops out of the carriages and stands behind Peeperkorn to admire the majestic intensity of the waterfall. After a while, they retreat from the water to set up the picnic they've brought with them, which includes plenty of wine, pastries, and cakes. They take their feast to some rocks beside the loud, rushing waters. Peeperkorn drinks heavily and begins to talk effusively about his usual subjects. Nobody can hear him over the waterfall, though, so everyone just nods and smiles, pretending to understand. When he finishes, a look of "ragged bitterness" passes across his lips, and not long after that, he tells everyone it's time to go.

Peeperkorn previously condemned people who indulge in "over-refined pleasures" like smoking, fancying himself a natural, unrepressed man who enjoys the simple pleasures of a human in their natural state, unburdened by the constraints of society. Yet Peeperkorn cannot compete with the natural intensity of the waterfall: nobody can hear him over the fierce roar of its waters. His look of "ragged bitterness" implies that he has realized a troubling truth about himself: crushed by the absence of praise, he realizes that he needs others' approval to thrive and is not as natural or free as he once thought.



Back at the Berghof, Hans hears a knock on his door in the middle of the night. He opens the door and greets one of the nurses, who tells him Clavdia has asked that he come at once. Hans hurries to Clavdia and Peeperkorn's living quarters and finds the door to Peeperkorn's parlor wide open. The head nurse, Krokowski, and Behrens are all gathered around Peeperkorn's bed. Clavdia is there, too, but her back is turned to Peeperkorn. Behrens says Peeperkorn is beyond saving, and Hans sees that Peeperkorn's eyes are closed, and his body has begun to turn black and blue. Hans follows Behrens out of the room and asks if Peeperkorn's death was a suicide. Behrens confirms that it was and shows Hans the small, curious syringe Peeperkorn used to do it.

The timing of Peeperkorn's demise portrays his death by suicide as a response to the earlier disillusionment he experienced when nobody praised his speech at the waterfall. Peeperkorn, it seems, lost the will to live after the performance of his personality failed to elicit a response from its audience. His demise reflects critically on the empty promise of personality. Peeperkorn was all personality and lacked an inner life, and so his existence relied on the validation of others. Without that validation, his personality crumbles, revealing his inner hollowness.



Behrens and others exit, and finally only Hans, Clavdia, and a Malayan guard remain. Clavdia tells Hans that he had a right to be informed, and Hans agrees, noting Peeperkorn's having extended him "the brotherhood of informal pronouns." Now, he feels horrible that he was too embarrassed to use them in front of the others at the picnic and so avoided addressing Peeperkorn by "you" altogether. Clavdia asks if Peeperkorn knew about their history, and Hans confirms that he did—he guessed it the night Hans refused to kiss Clavdia's forehead. Now, in honor of Peeperkorn, Hans asks if he can do so now. Clavdia bends forward and offers her forehead to Hans. The Malayan guard makes a big show of not watching the intimate exchange.

Hans seems to believe that his failure to address Peeperkorn by informal pronouns may have insulted Peeperkorn and fueled the negative feelings that compelled Peeperkorn to die by suicide. That Hans was too embarrassed to use the pronouns in front of others suggests that he has always recognized, at least on some level, that Peeperkorn was a vapid fool. Yet he ignored Settembrini's advice to be wary of bold personalities and accepted Peeperkorn as his mentor anyway. Hans's kiss on Clavdia's forehead is unsatisfying and unremarkable. It reads more as an anticlimactic farewell than the hint of a future romance.



PART 7, CHAPTER 6: THE GREAT STUPOR

Sometime after Peeperkorn's death, Behrens approaches Hans, noting how "bored" and "jaded" Hans seems. He explains that something is odd about Hans's case—his improving "localized condition" doesn't quite match his ongoing "symptoms of intoxication." The narrator adds that Behrens is quite right about Hans's apparent boredom. Indeed, Hans has been out of sorts ever since Peeperkorn's death and Clavdia's subsequent departure. In her place, Hans has been gripped by a demonic force—and its "name [i]s Stupor."

With Clavdia gone, Hans no longer has even a flimsy reason to stay at the Berghof, and he becomes "bored," "jaded," and indifferent to existence altogether. At the same time, he is too "intoxicat[ed]," or emotionally sedated, to remove himself from the Berghof and all the destructive effects it has on his emotional wellbeing. Hans continues to demonstrate his irrationality and his inability to learn from his mistakes and pull himself out of his "Stupor," staying in a place that is clearly not good for him, even when his improving "localized condition" gives him the justification he needs to leave the Berghof and return to ordinary society.



Meanwhile, Hans isn't the only one bored at the Berghof. Many other residents, as is customary, take up tedious little hobbies to help pass the time. Some of them turn to amateur photography, others collect stamps, and quite a few take to sampling exquisite chocolates. Watching the sanatorium's many solitaire players makes Hans feel especially sad, but he nevertheless begins to play it all the time.

That other residents take up tedious little hobbies shows that Hans's "Stupor" isn't all his fault—it's a side effect of living in the dulling, intoxicating atmosphere of the Berghof for so long. Yet although Hans acknowledges the deep sadness of the place and its people, he still refuses to act on that knowledge, begrudgingly playing tedious, stupid games as though someone is forcing his hand—when in fact he has (and always has had) the liberty to leave if he feels like it.



One day, Settembrini stops by the sanatorium and pays Hans a visit. Hans, characteristically, is in the middle of a game of solitaire. Settembrini looks at Hans, a mournful expression in his eyes, and tells Hans it's clear Hans is in denial about his inner malaise. Settembrini walks away then, but Hans can't manage to pick up his card game again—he is at once gripped by the presence of "the grinning demon" that rules over his world: "The Great Stupor."

This is one of the rare occasions in which Settembrini manages to get through to Hans: it seems that Settembrini's mournful expression has triggered Hans's awareness of "the grinning Demon" that controls him. Of course, while Hans's "Great Stupor" may have risen to new heights after Clavdia's departure, what Hans doesn't seem to realize is that he has been in a crippling state of malaise for quite some time now—for at least as long as Settembrini has urged Hans, in vain, to leave the Berghof and return to his life in the flatlands.



Sometime later, Behrens takes samples from Hans's blood to see if any cocci—the possible cause of Hans's lingering temperature—will grow. Some cocci do appear on one of the petri dishes, but not that much. Eventually, though, a lot more cocci develop, and Behrens decides to start Hans on a course of Strepto-vaccine therapy, which comes with no risks (the serum is developed from Hans's own blood). In the worst case, the therapy will do no harm. And so, it's decided that Hans will remain at the Berghof awhile longer. Hans undergoes treatment for several weeks, and nothing happens. Hans remains at the Berghof and continues to play solitaire. Meanwhile, he feels a creeping dread that "the demon" will soon "come to some horrible end."

It's likely that Behrens only performs the cocci experiment to humor Hans—in truth, this strain of bacteria exists in all humans, so it's really not indicative of any serious, underlying problem that the cocci develop in the petri dishes. Yet Behrens, apparently sensing that Hans wants some reason to justify his indefinite stay at the Berghof, goes along with the test and orders Hans to remain at the sanatorium. Hans's willingness to go along with this phony prescription despite his new awareness that his inner malaise ("the demon") is slowly destroying him signals his continued resistance to learn from his mistakes. He knows that staying at the Berghof is slowly destroying him, yet he can't translate that knowledge into practical action.



PART 7, CHAPTER 8: FULLNESS OF HARMONY

Eventually the Berghof adds a gramophone to the collection of optical toys and other gadgets in the main social room, and this propels Hans out of his "mania for solitaire," which by this point has lasted multiple years. The gramophone isn't some old antique: it's modern, beautiful, and of the highest quality, according to Behrens. And it's German-made, to boot. All the residents listen in awe as the gramophone plays an energetic Offenbach overture. It's as though a real orchestra is performing for them.

The passing detail of Hans's solitaire obsession lasting for years signals that considerable time has passed between this chapter and the previous chapter. This sudden shift forward reflects how time passes differently for Hans now that he has, it seems, fully succumbed to his inner malaise. Whereas it took hundreds of pages for the narration to convey Hans's first three weeks at the Berghof, it now represents full years with a single sentence. The gramophone, though modern and flashy, functions as yet another source of distraction for patients who, like Hans, have succumbed to their inner malaise.



Hans waits in the background until everyone else retires for the evening, and then he approaches the gramophone and familiarizes himself with it, playing dozens of disks. He plays a lot of symphonies and overtures, but he also finds some disks of songs too. Hans is completely immersed in the music and stays up listening to it late into the night. The next day, people return to the social room to listen to the gramophone, and they let Hans choose which disks to play. Hans enjoys this responsibility, but he much prefers to listen to music late at night, after everyone has gone to bed for the evening. One night, he listens to some songs from the opera *Aida*, entranced by the tragic fate of Aida, Radames, and Amneris. He thinks it's beautiful how Aida went to the doomed Radames "to share his fate in the crypt for all eternity."

*Hans's late-night session with the gramophone could read as positive or negative. On the one hand, his renewed interest in technology could suggest that he hasn't fully succumbed to his malaise—he was an engineer in his former life in the flatlands, after all, and perhaps there's still a chance he can return to that life. On the other hand, his interest in music could also be yet another passing fancy he engages with to distract himself from reality and so perpetuate the state of malaise and inaction he's existed in for years. What's more, Hans's romanticization of the tragedy of *Aida* signals that he still believes there is nobility and honor in suffering. In this reading, Hans's interest in the gramophone only confirms that he is still in a state of self-denial, unable or unwilling to learn from his mistakes.*



Hans also listens to the opera *Carmen*, in which the cruel and flirtatious “Gypsy” woman Carmen teases José, who loves her, without realizing the pain she causes him.

Hans very likely relates to José: Clavdia teased and hurt him just as the titular Carmen of Bizet's opera teases and hurts José. Of course, while José's unrequited love for Carmen leads him down a path of self-destruction until he eventually murders her, Hans still has a chance to regain his senses and start anew. Instead, he wallows in self-pity and continues to stagnate.



Another of Hans's favorites is Schubert's song “Lindenbaum.” In this recording, a tenor sings the song, accompanied by piano. The last verse repeats the line, “You *could* have found rest here,” and the words “could have” convey a sad “yearning.” Long ago, Settembrini critically deemed Hans's “backsliding” (his getting used to life up at the Berghof) a sickness. But is Hans's love of the “emotional world”—to which this song belongs—really so unhealthy? On the contrary, isn't it actually quite healthy?

Schubert's “Lindenbaum” is the song Hans sang when he first hiked up to the meadow where he would later spend so many days “playing king.” The song, which is set to text by the German poet Wilhelm Müller, is about a traveler who walks past a linden tree on a cold, winter night. The tree makes the traveler long for happier days, and he mournfully imagines that he “could have found rest” under the tree. Hans misunderstands the poem, interpreting it as validation of the “rest” he has found at the Berghof. In fact, the poem more accurately captures the bittersweet feeling of nostalgia, which can only be felt in retrospect. In reality, had the traveler stopped at the tree and sought refuge in his memories, he would perish of cold. The intensity of his emotion derives not from that happier time but from his longing for it. Hans, in remaining permanently at rest, denies himself the ability to experience this depth of emotion.



PART 7, CHAPTER 9: HIGHLY QUESTIONABLE

Over the years, Krokowski's lectures have shifted from “physic dissections” to “magical, arcane matters.” His main focus remains the subconscious mind, but now, instead of talking about love and illness, he focuses on hypnosis, telepathy, and other mystical matters. To Krokowski, if one believes in the link between bodily illness and repressed emotions, it's not such a great leap to see how repressed emotions can manifest changes in the external world. And it's worth noting, the narrator adds, that Krokowski was talking about such manners long before Ellen Brand entered the picture.

Here, with Krokowski's new interest in telepathy and other mystical subjects, the “magic” of The Magic Mountain manifests somewhat more literally. Krokowski, it seems, has taken his psychoanalytic theories to the extreme, positing that repressed emotions can effect change. This attitude is dangerous to someone like Hans, as it absolves Hans of the responsibility to actually act on his theories, emotions, and beliefs.



Ellen Brand, whom everyone calls Elly, is a sweet, 19-year-old patient from Copenhagen. She appears childish and innocent on the outside, but in time it becomes clear that she possesses hidden, strange talents. And Krokowski takes it upon himself to get to the bottom of them. Elly's hidden talents first appear when residents are playing some parlor games during a social hour one night. One game begins with one person leaving the room, at which point the others will decide on some task for the person who left the room to perform. Upon the person's return, they must guess what the task is. Everyone is unsettled when Elly correctly guesses each of her complicated tasks, such as taking some salt from the dining hall and sprinkling it on another resident's head and then leading him to the piano and pounding out "Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star."

Everyone accuses Elly of cheating, and she apologizes. Though she hadn't been listening outside the door, she can't help but listening "in the room, after she came in." At first everyone is puzzled, then they immediately call for Krokowski, informing him that Elly can apparently hear voices. Krokowski is immediately intrigued and sends everyone to their room to take a rest cure. He asks Elly to stay behind, though, so he can "chat" with her. This chills everyone to their core, including Hans, who feels full of terror as he witnesses Elly's powers. Hans, like most everyone else, grew up hearing vague stories about the supernatural, but he's never witnessed anything paranormal firsthand.

From that night on, Krokowski forbids anyone from performing any unofficial experiments on Elly. Meanwhile, he starts inviting her for sessions in his "analytical dungeon" in the basement. Hermine Kleefeld, who has assumed the role of young Elly's surrogate mother during her time at the Berghof, learns snippets about Elly's psychic life through her close relationship with Elly and then passes that information on to the others.

Everyone learns, through Hermine, that the "voice" who whispered things to Elly that night in the lounge was a boy named Holger, who is something of a guardian angel to Elly. They also learn that Elly has been hearing these voices since she was a young girl, and it hasn't always been harmless fun. Once, she saw a vision of her older sister Sophie, who was living in America then, dressed in an odd white gown. The next morning, she learned that it was that very night that Sophie died of inflammation of the heart.

The "magic" of The Magic Mountain continues to intensify with Elly Brand's arrival. Elly's unbelievable ability to correctly guess the complicated tasks the other players assigned her suggests that she has genuine psychic abilities. Elly's status as something of a gifted child reinforces Hans's naïve drive to believe that illness and suffering imbue a person with honor and nobility. It's as though Elly's unfortunate illness has given her this special, supernatural gift to make up for everything else it's taken from her.



Though Elly insists that she didn't cheat by listening outside the door, there's really no evidence to prove she isn't lying. She could be making the claim about listening "in the room, after she came in" (i.e., reading people's minds) to mess with everyone. Hans's terror as he witnesses Elly's supposed supernatural powers could read as yet another example of his ambivalence. He has tried for so long to find greater meaning and value in illness, suffering, and death. But now that he has encountered evidence that seems to support his theory (Elly's supernatural ability suggests that suffering gives people higher powers and perhaps even offers proof of an afterlife), he falters, apparently realizing that he might not be as committed to his ideals and beliefs as he once thought.



Krokowski's prohibition of any unofficial experiments on Elly simultaneously confirms and raises suspicion about the authenticity of Elly's supernatural abilities. On the one hand, he could recognize her genuine talent and want to keep it to himself for research purposes. But it could also be that he recognizes Elly as a fraud and doesn't want a nosy resident to catch wind of this for some reason. Either way, Krokowski's willingness to entertain this incredulous notion reinforces the irrationality of his character.



Elly's story seems to validate the authenticity of her supernatural abilities, though, of course, nobody can know whether the story about seeing her sister's spirit is real, imagined, or patently false. Once more, Elly's supernatural ability links suffering, illness, and death with extraordinary ability, suggesting that Sophie's death somehow gave her the special power to communicate one last time with her younger sister.



Hans agrees to participate in a séance the others are holding with Elly. It will be a secret from Krokowski, of course. On the night of the séance, everyone gathers in Hermine Kleefeld's room. There's a table at the center of the room with an upside-down wineglass placed upon it. There are also lettered tokens on the table, which the spirit, should one appear, will use to communicate. After everyone has some tea, they all gather around the table, and Hermine dims the lights. Everyone places a finger on the wineglass and waits for it to move. Twenty or so minutes pass without anything happening, and people are getting restless. But suddenly, the glass tips and flies out from under everyone's fingers before eventually settling back at the center of the table. Everyone is equally intrigued and terrified.

Herr Albin asks if a spirit is in the room, and eventually the glass spells out H-O-L-G-E-R, confirming the presence of Holger, Elly's supposed guardian angel. The group uses the wineglass to ask him questions, but he doesn't seem too interested in giving specific answers. When they ask what his profession was (when he was alive), he replies "POT." They guess this means he may have been a poet but simply forgot the "E." One of the women asks Holger if he'd been handsome, and he replies, "Beautiful brown, brown locks," much to everyone's delight. Someone asks if Holger can recite some of his poetry for them, and he obliges, reciting poetry for a long while, with nobody able to make him stop. His poetry describes with great beauty the abode of a hermit and the private musings of Holger's mind.

After the poetry recitation ends, Hans presses his hand to the glass and asks if Holger can tell him how much longer his stay here will last: after all, he initially came here thinking he'd leave after three weeks, and now years have passed. Holger replies cryptically, spelling out "go," "across," and then saying something about Hans's room (Room 34). Then, without warning, the lights blow out, and the room becomes pitch black. Frau Stöhr cries out with fright. Dr. Ting-Fu, another of the residents, suggests turning on the ceiling light, which calms everyone down. When the lights go on, though, Hans looks down at his knees and finds Clavdia's interior portrait (her **X-ray**) resting there. Hans knows he didn't bring it into the room with him.

The theatrics involved in the séance—the tea, the dimmed lights, the lettered tokens—seem designed to heighten the guests' suggestibility, which could prompt them to sense supernatural presences that aren't actually there. Even so, the narration leaves room for ambiguity, and readers have no reason to doubt that a supernatural presence did indeed tip over the wineglass. This scene builds on the magical elements at play in this chapter, and this underscores the heightened atmosphere of irrationality and restlessness that has overtaken the Berghof as of late.



This scene is played for comedy (it's bit of a stretch to assume the "Holger" has misspelled "POET," and Holger's bragging description of his "Beautiful brown, brown locks" is delightfully funny), but it also points to the way a shared desire to believe in the same thing can lead people to behave irrationally. Even so, the narration leaves open the possibility that Elly's supernatural abilities are genuine and that Holger's presence is really in the room.



Hans's question about how much longer he will stay at the Berghof reinforces how in denial he is about his inner malaise. He doesn't need a ghostly entity to answer this question for him. Hans isn't being held at the Berghof against his will and can therefore leave any time he wishes—he's simply choosing not to. When Clavdia's X-ray image appears on Hans's lap, apparently in response to his question, he should take it as a sign that he has stayed at the Berghof for far too long. Initially, he stuck around with the hope that he would see Clavdia again. Now that she has come and gone, he should learn his lesson, cut his losses, and re-enter society while he still can. As Holger's first series of cryptic answers—"go," "across," and "3-4"—seems to suggest, Hans has been at the Berghof for three plus four years, or seven years in total.



When Hans later tells Settembrini about the séance, Settembrini scoffs and calls Elly a fraud. Then Settembrini goes off on Hans for believing in such nonsense. He tells Hans it's his "inalienable right" as a human to use his rational mind to tell the difference between good and evil and between "truth and the sham of lies." Hans just nods along without responding.

It's no wonder that Settembrini scoffs at Elly's supposed supernatural abilities, given that rationality is a core fixture of his humanist ideals. One wonders what Hans sought to achieve by telling Settembrini about the séance. Perhaps he did not like what "Holger" told him via Clavdia's X-ray image and wanted Settembrini to discount the séance so that he could disregard Holger's "advice."



Later, Dr. Krokowski starts inviting select residents to the sessions he holds with Elly in his office. Hans doesn't attend the sessions himself, but he hears bits and pieces from residents who do. Apparently, Elly made a wastebasket hover in the air during one session. Krokowski's theory is that Elly's condition is a matter of "biopsychic subconscious complexes into the objective world [...]." By this logic, then, Elly might be capable of physically manifesting the spirits she convenes with in her head—in other words, she might be able to project apparitions of the dead into reality. He sets to work training Elly to make this a reality, and Hans hears that eventually Krokowski is successful, with various attendees of the sessions reporting that they were "touched by materialized hands."

Hans's avoidance of Krokowski's sessions with Elly suggests that he's still unsettled by what Holger communicated to him via Clavdia's X-ray image. Multiple people have advised him to leave the Berghof for the sake of his wellbeing, and yet he obstinately and irrationally disregards their helpful advice. Years have passed, and yet Hans remains just as naïve—and because he has spent critical formative year cut off from the real world, just as inexperienced—as he was when he first arrived at the Berghof.



Krokowski even manages to coach Elly to materialize Holger, who it turns out "really did have 'beautiful brown, brown locks.'" Elly also claims that she's able to materialize any deceased person. Hans hears this, and it eventually compels him to participate in the Berghof's paranormal activities. One night, he heads to Krokowski's basement office to attend a scheduled session. Krokowski and Elly greet all the attendees with lighthearted cheer, apparently to keep the room's atmosphere calm and unmenacing. Despite this, Hans feels ill at ease.

It's unclear why the revelation that Elly may be able to manifest the dead is what compels Hans to finally attend one of Krokowski's sessions. He has been so critical of the way staff and residents try to downplay or outright deny the reality of death, and the notion that the dead may be resurrected via magic seems to call into question the permanence and harsh reality of death. Hans's choice to attend the session despite his wariness about it makes sense, though, given his characteristic ambivalence. He repeatedly gravitates toward experiences he knows (or at least should be able to predict) aren't good for him.



When all the attendees have arrived, Krokowski asks his assistants—Frau Magnus and Fräulein Levi—to accompany him and Elly to the adjacent office, where Elly will receive a preliminary exam before the main session begins. Meanwhile, Hans and the others, who are all regular attendees, wait in the consulting room. Hans looks about the room and sees a bust of Hippocrates and an engraving of Rembrandt's painting *Anatomy Lesson* above the fireplace. The floor is covered with a red carpet.

The Rembrandt painting on Krokowski's wall depicts a demonstration of the dissection of a cadaver. Meanwhile, the bust of Hippocrates brings to mind the Hippocratic Oath, which outlines the ethical standards that doctors must uphold. Together, these two details emphasize a doctor's obligation to heal (or at least improve the quality of life for) their patients. This contrasts with the event that's currently taking place in Krokowski's office: it's unclear whom this séance is helping, and how.



Ten minutes later, Elly, Krokowski and the two assistants return from the examination room, and the session begins. Krokowski turns off the lights, enveloping the room in darkness. He explains, mostly for Hans's benefit (because it's his first time), that Elly will put herself in a trance state. After that, her attendant spirit, Holger, will speak through her. Now, Krokowski instructs everyone to link arms, and then he orders another attendant to turn on the music. A Millöcker overture begins to play from the gramophone. By the time it's over, Elly has fallen into a trance state. Hans is given the privilege of "exercising scientific control" over Elly, which requires him to sit facing her and grip her hands and allow her to whisper into his ear, essentially serving as a middleman between Elly/Holger and the attendees.

Elly squeezes Hans's hands, which means that Holger is present. Krokowski asks Holger if he's still willing to make a deceased person appear, and Elly/Holger whispers "yes," into Hans's ear. Hans feels "goose bumps" prickly his skin. Krokowski asks which deceased person they should ask Holger to materialize. After a pause, Hans asks to see Joachim. Krokowski commands Holger to get to work materializing Joachim and then orders the music to resume. Elly remains in a trance for hours without anything happening. But then she suddenly starts to convulse. When the convulsions finally stop, Elly comes to, opens her eyes, and smiles. At this point, everyone takes a break to chat and smoke.

The break comes to a close and the session resumes. Hans asks to have someone else be the mediator, but Krokowski refuses his request, and Hans sits back down in his seat facing Elly. The gramophone is turned on again, and Elly reenters a trance state, and then more hours pass with nothing happening. When one of the disks on the gramophone ends, Hans suggests they play a specific piece, a song from Gounod's [Faust](#), next. He explains that it will help set a particular "emotional state" and that the piece is "quite special." The music begins.

Krokowski frames Hans's job as "exercising scientific control" in order to give the séance an air of rationality and believability. It also makes the event seem like it's fulfilling some medical purpose and is therefore more ethical. Hans's role as middleman between the living and the dead is also highly symbolic, bringing to mind the state of limbo he has existed in over the past several years. Though he has not physically died, his gradual disassociation from ordinary society leaves him lost to himself and to the world, which is a figurative sort of death.



Hans's reason for asking to see Joachim is unclear. Given that there has been no concrete evidence to support Elly's ability to summon the dead, it's possible Hans may be counting on the fact that Joachim will not appear. That being said, his request could also convey his conscious or unconscious desire to turn to Joachim for advice. Hans's life has been consumed by decadence, irrationality, and malaise ever since Joachim's death. Joachim has a straightforward and practical understanding of the world, a strong sense of honor, and a willingness to translate his moral code into action. Hans can use someone like this to set him back on track.



Gounod's [Faust](#) is based on the German legend of Faust, in which an alchemist sells his soul to the devil for infinite knowledge. Hans's choice to play this particular opera during a séance is rather on the nose, given the opera's focus on black magic. Hans's musical selection also reinforces the point that he is aware that he is doing something potentially self-destructive in trying to summon Joachim. He seems to sense that it will cost him to see his deceased cousin again, yet he moves forward with his plan anyway. Though Hans has matured and gained experience in some ways, he continues to make foolish, self-destructive decisions.



In the middle of the song, a deep voice announces, “I’ve been watching him for some time now.” The record ends, but nobody moves to lift the needle. In the corner of the room, off in the background, an additional person has materialized: Joachim, as he appeared in the final days before his death. But Joachim isn’t wearing his normal uniform—this one has a narrow collar, as well as a cross. He looks like a military man, yes, but one from the long-ago past. The room is utterly quiet. Hans feels like he’s going to be sick. He cries out, “Forgive me!” and then breaks down in tears before losing consciousness.

Hans awakes to Krokowski calling him by name over and over again. Hans says nothing and goes to the door and turns on the lights. Then he walks toward Krokowski and tries to say something to him, but he can’t bring himself to speak. He instead “nod[s] menacingly” at Krokowski and then leaves the room without a word.

Joachim’s presence confirms the authenticity of Elly’s talent. More importantly, it deeply unsettles Hans, who immediately apologizes, seemingly ashamed to have disturbed Joachim’s peace. Hans, in keeping with his character, has let his emotions drive his actions and failed to consider the consequences of his behavior. Now, he has selfishly disturbed his deceased cousin. He has also instantaneously dismantled everything he thought he knew about life and death, undoing much of the progress he has made over the course of his self-education.



Hans’s anger at Krokowski as he leaves the room reads as misplaced. As Hans “nod[s] menacingly” at Krokowski, he seems to blame the doctor for the seriously unsettling experience he has just had. In reality, though, Hans voluntarily attended this séance, and it was his idea to summon Joachim. Hans’s lingering immaturity comes through in his failure to take responsibility for his actions.



PART 7, CHAPTER 10: THE GREAT PETULANCE

As the years go on, a “ghost” starts to “walk the Berghof,” one Hans believes to be a mutation of the aforementioned, demonic “Great Stupor.” Both demons have always existed within the Berghof, but now the new demon begins to spread, infecting all the Berghof’s residents. Hans is horrified when he realizes that, as soon as “he let[s] himself go the least little bit,” he, too, is infected. The narrator describes the observable symptoms of this infection as a testy, restless, angry atmosphere all throughout the sanatorium. People get into fights over the smallest things, and some even turn physical.

The infection that has spread throughout the sanatorium has affected Settembrini, too, dulling his characteristically sharp intellect and leaving him unable to come up with any of his usual cutting responses. Naphta, too, is under the weather, though his illness is more physical than Settembrini’s. He spends most days in bed, though he celebrates his body’s weakened state, an attitude that fuels his and Settembrini’s usual arguments.

As time passes, the Berghof residents grow more restless, and their former “Great Stupor” morphs into behavior that is more violent and reactive. In one reading of the novel, the Berghof—an international sanatorium—symbolizes Europe in the years leading up to World War I. The violent restlessness that spreads among the sanatorium’s residents, then, symbolizes the mounting political tensions throughout Europe as global conflict became increasingly inevitable. Hans has been at the Berghof for seven years now, and since he arrived in 1907, that means that war will be declared within the year.



It speaks to the intensity of this “infection” that it has affected even Settembrini and Naphta, the Berghof’s most vitalized patients. In a reading of the novel as an allegory for Europe in the leadup to World War I, Settembrini’s diminished state could symbolize the initial decision of Italy, which had been a member of the Triple Alliance (along with Germany and Austria-Hungary), to remain neutral after war was declared.



One February afternoon, Hans, Ferge, Wehsal, Settembrini, and Naphta meet up and take a sleigh ride to Monstein. It's a beautiful, snowy day, and they see the beautiful Zügenstrasse appear before them as they near their final destination. In Monstein, they stop at an inn, or "Kurhaus," before continuing on their way. Immediately, the Stulsergrat (a mountain in the Swiss Alps) comes into view. They see a high mountain peak materialize before them, and to Hans it appears almost "supernatural, like something from Valhalla, distant, sacred, and inaccessible."

Hans's reference to Valhalla (in Norse mythology, Valhalla is the paradise where those killed in combat go after their deaths) could suggest his growing disillusionment. He has spent years trying to learn, grow, and achieve self-awareness, yet he has mostly failed on all accounts. Now, he seems to sense the inevitability of war, even if his stay at the Berghof has kept him ignorant of the developing political situation in the flatlands). He seems to recognize, if only subconsciously, that he is running out of time; in short, the enlightenment and wellness he hoped to achieve at the Berghof has become "distant" and "inaccessible."



Later, everyone returns to the Kurhaus for a snack and some coffee. Before long, Naphta starts lecturing about freedom, which he claims comes from Romanticism rather than Enlightenment thinking. What's more, he claims, the desire for freedom is directly to blame for the rise in militant nationalism the continent is presently experiencing. In contrast, the freedom of mysticism and the Church protect individuals from "absolute monarchy." At this point, Settembrini, frustrated, interjects to tell Naphta he's tired of him corrupting the impressionable youths with "dubious ideas." Their argument grows heated, and Hans and the others nervously look on in silence. The argument reaches its peak when Settembrini declares Naphta's spreading of dangerous information "infamous" and says he needs to be "punished." Naphta, irate, challenges Settembrini to a duel before storming off.

Settembrini and Naphta argue the same broader points they've been defending or attacking over the entirety of their acquaintanceship. But this time, Settembrini insults Naphta with the accusation that he should be "punished" for corrupting the youth with "dubious ideas." Naphta's response to challenge Settembrini to a duel further underscores how tense and volatile the atmosphere of the Berghof has become lately. Settembrini and Naphta have argued nonstop over the course of their knowing each other, yet it's only lately that their arguments have become physical. Now, with the duel looming before them, it seems that their arguments might escalate to the point of death.



After Naphta has left, Wehsal asks Settembrini if he actually plans to accept Naphta's challenge. Settembrini, though he does not theoretically approve of dueling, says that the "practical" circumstances require him to follow through with it. On the ride home to the Berghof, Hans feels dizzy and ill at ease. He gets even more upset when it's revealed that Naphta wants to duel with pistols rather than fists. And, "as the injured party in an affair of honor," it's up to him to decide which weapon they use, so Settembrini has no say in the matter. Alone with Settembrini, Ferge, and Wehsal, Hans laments the pointlessness of the duel: it's not even over an "actual insult." Settembrini disagrees, though, and tells Hans that intellectual disagreements really do matter and "become personal." And, what's more, a person who can't defend their ideals with their body isn't worthy of those ideals at all.

The duel will be a critical moment for Settembrini and Naphta, giving them the opportunity to defend in real life the principles they argue over in their intellectual debates. Naphta's seriousness comes through in his insistence on dueling with pistols rather than fists, which raises the distinct possibility that either he or Settembrini will pay for their deeply held principles with their life. Hans's distinction between an "actual insult" and the insult Settembrini and Naphta are fighting over reveals his wavering, tenuous commitment to his own ideals. To Hans, there's a line between one's theoretical ideals and how one conducts oneself in daily life. To Settembrini, on the other hand, there is no distinction.



In the days leading up to the duel, Naphta informs Settembrini of the rules of the duel: the men will be five paces apart and will be allotted three shots. Settembrini accepts these rules, but Wehsal—his second—is horrified. Because nobody involved actually owns a pistol, they borrow them from Herr Albin, who also shows them how to use them. Hans selects the duel's location: the beautiful meadow where he “play[s] king.”

Wehsal is horrified because he, unlike Settembrini, isn't committed to Settembrini's ideals to the degree that he is willing to die for them. The fact that nobody involved in the duel owns a pistol highlights how high tensions have risen at the Berghof: under normal circumstances, none of would be violent, murderous people. Now, they behave as irrationally and haphazardly as Herr Albin. Finally, it's symbolic that Hans chooses the meadow where he “play[s] king” as the duel's location. In the meadow, Hans mused over abstract ideals that he could never translate into lived experience. In suggesting that the duel take place in this place, then, he is conveying his hope that the duel will not result in any real, physical consequences—that both men will escape alive.



The night before the duel, Hans anxiously realizes it's probably a good idea to have a doctor onsite. It's unthinkable to ask Rhadamanthus (Behrens) to be there, since the director of a medical facility is unlikely to assist in illegal activities. Ultimately, though, Hans's anxieties are pointless, as Naphta declares that he wants no doctor present.

Hans tries to interfere in the duel, believing that having a doctor there might minimize the chance of anyone dying. But Naphta's commitment to his ideals is so fierce and unhinged that he finds the idea incomprehensible. In his mind, minimizing the risk of death defeats the purpose of the duel.



Finally, the morning of the duel arrives. Hans hardly slept the night before and feels awful. His teeth chatter in the cold air as he, Ferge, Wehsal, and Settembrini make their way to the meadow. Suddenly, Settembrini stops, places his hand on Hans's, and tells Hans that he will offer himself to be shot before killing Naphta: this is how he will fulfill his duty to honor.

Settembrini's plan to offer himself to Naphta allows him to fulfill his duty to participate in the duel while also honoring his commitment to pacifism.



Finally, they arrive at the meadow, where Naphta is already waiting. Naphta gets straight to business and asks for the weapons to be presented. Then Ferge draws the boundaries in the snow, and Settembrini and Naphta take their places. Naphta commands Settembrini to come forward and shoot. After taking his final step, Settembrini raises his pistol directly upward and fires. Naphta is furious that Settembrini has shot into the air. Settembrini calmly says he'll shoot where he wants. “Coward!” Naphta screams at Settembrini—before turning the pistol toward his own head and pulling the trigger.

Naphta's choice to shoot himself honors his principles in the same way that Settembrini's (now foiled) plan to offer himself to Naphta honored Settembrini's commitment to pacifism. In shooting himself, Naphta destroys the physical body, which he has repeatedly degraded throughout his debates with Settembrini. His actions also demonstrate the self-destructive nature of irrationality, one of his defining characteristics.



The gunshot echoes through the mountains. Everyone rushes toward Naphta's body. Settembrini gets there first and cries out, “*Che cosa fai per l'amor di Dio!*”

Settembrini's exclamation roughly translates to “What do you do for the love of God!” He's referencing the Bible here, specifically the expression “Love of God,” which originates in the Deuteronomy, after the Israelites have received the Ten Commandments and are called to love God with all their heart, soul, and strength. Naphta has made good on this calling, but for what? Settembrini seems to ask.



PART 7, CHAPTER 11: THE THUNDERBOLT

In total, Hans remains at the Berghof for seven years. During his time there, he sits at all seven of the dining hall's tables. His final place is at the Bad Russian table, and at this point he has grown a misshapen little beard. None of the medical staff "invent diversions for him" any longer. Instead, they only ask him if he's slept "well," and this is only a formality. Behrens hardly speaks to him. He no longer requires supervision—nobody expects him to do anything rash or dangerous, and he's "no longer even capable of forming the thought of a return to the flatlands."

Throughout the years, more deaths occur. Consul Tienappel, Hans's great-uncle and former guardian, dies; Hans learns about the death via telegram. Hans writes a letter in response and tells his family that his present condition prevents him from returning home to pay last respects to his late uncle. This death breaks Hans's last connection to the flatlands, and from that point forth he writes and receives no more letters. He also no longer orders **Maria Mancinis**, having since found a different, suitable brand to buy up in the mountains.

In Hans's seventh year, "the rumble of thunder" arrives: World War I. The war catches Hans, who hasn't bothered to read the paper in quite some time, completely off guard. Settembrini had tried to keep Hans informed of all the events happening in the world below, but Hans was too busy "playing king" to pay him much notice.

Settembrini and Hans's relationship has also changed. Whereas in the beginning it was Settembrini who sat beside Hans's bed and tried to correct Hans's misconceptions "about matters of life and death," now Hans sits beside Settembrini's bed and listens to him talk about "the world situation." Settembrini hardly gets out of bed these days—Naphta's suicide affected him greatly. Lately, Settembrini's contribution to *Sociological Pathology* has been stalled indefinitely, and he'll now deliver his findings about human suffering in literature orally rather than in written form. As tension builds throughout Europe, Settembrini finds that his humane, pacifist ideals clash with his humanist desire for freedom and progress. Settembrini reacts to the assassination of the archduke with both horror and admiration for the act that "was committed to free a nation [...]."

Hans's final place at the Bad Russian table (and the little beard he has grown by the time he moves there) marks the transformation he has undergone since first arriving at the Berghof. Though once he rejected the idleness, irrationality, and subversion of bourgeois social norms he encountered at the sanatorium, he now embraces them wholeheartedly. And, as the fact that staff no longer "invent diversions for him" to remain there indicates, he's no longer in denial about his transformation and no longer needs to feign illness to justify staying at the Berghof.



Hans cuts ties with the people and pastimes that connected him to his old life. The finality of Hans's decision to abandon the person he was and the life he might have lived comes through in the fact that even the death of his former guardian can't compel him to leave the Berghof.



It's almost comical that the arrival of World War I—a major conflict, and one close to home, too—catches Hans by surprise, but it also speaks to his total isolation from the real world. He's been so preoccupied with his abstract, hypothetical musings—with "playing king," that he has no energy left to muse over things that really matter: and that will soon come to impact his life in a real, unavoidable way.



Settembrini, unlike Hans, ultimately proves himself capable of acknowledging the limitations of his abstract ideals. The assassination of the archduke Franz Ferdinand by a Serbian nationalist (regarded as the event that instigated the start of World War I) exemplifies these limitations, forcing Settembrini to accept that his belief in pacifism and his regard for human life falter when a violent event like an assassination "[i]s committed to free a nation [...]." In this way, Settembrini accepts that the real world is imperfect and ugly and incapable of adhering to the standard of perfection his abstract ideals lay out. But one must choose to live in that imperfect world nonetheless: it is the only option.



When war is finally declared, the Berghof erupts in chaos. It's only now that Hans—"our sleeper"—begins to rouse and look around. Finally, "the enchantment [has been] broken," and Hans is "set free—not by his own actions [...] but set free by elementary external forces, for whom his liberation was a very irrelevant matter."

Ever since Hans's spell was lifted, the Berghof has been in a chaotic state, with all the panicked residents rushing to pack their bags and retreat to safety in the land below. Hans, meanwhile, freed from his former state of disillusionment, remains calm and collected. Settembrini encounters Hans as he is packing his bags. He embraces Hans and kisses him, lamenting that Hans will be returning to the world under such unfortunate conditions—he wishes it could've been Hans's choice to return, but such is life. He urges Hans to fight courageously, and then he bids him goodbye.

Now it's dusk on a battlefield in some unspecified location in the flatlands. Missiles howl through the red, fiery air. It's the final stretch of a battle that has been going on all day. The soldiers are mostly volunteers and young people. The meadow they march through is wet, muddy, and immensely difficult to traverse. The soldiers' faces are all covered in mud. There are 3,000 soldiers—1,000 extra to guarantee that there will be 2,000 left to retake the nearby burning villages. Projectiles fly toward the soldiers, and many are hit. Others are shot at and killed. More and more soldiers are sent out from the surrounded wood to replace their fallen comrades.

Hans Castorp is among these men. He looks like all the others, flushed and covered in mud. He sings a song to himself: "Upon its bark I've carved there / So many words of love—" Then Hans stops singing and throws himself to the ground to avoid being hit by an explosive shell. Hans watches as the shell—"this product of science gone berserk"—buries itself in the ground before him and explodes. He watches as two of his comrades are blown to pieces.

Hans has separated himself from reality over the past seven years. But now reality—in the form of a major global conflict—comes to call, and at long last "the enchantment" of the Berghof has been broken. Notably, Hans re-enters reality, but "not by his own actions": the war forces the issue.



The involuntary nature of Hans's return to reality prevents him from completing his self-education: one can reliably assume that, had the start of the war not brought about this long-delayed reality check, Hans would continue to waste his life away at the Berghof. Settembrini's farewell to his young mentor is thus tinged with remorse: he wishes his lessons could have gotten through to Hans and helped him mature into an experienced and capable young man, but now there's no chance of that happening. Hans, this passage reveals, is leaving the Berghof to fight in the war, and it's highly likely he will die before he has had the chance to take full advantage of having been freed from his former state of disillusionment.



The chaos and destruction of this scene underscore the harshness of the reality to which Hans has returned. At the Berghof, he mused about life and death, and he entertained the notion that suffering brings honor or dignity to the sufferer. But now, on the battlefields of the war-ravaged flatlands, Hans is forced to confront actual death and suffering, and the brutality of his present environment renders his earlier musings self-indulgent and superficial by comparison.



The song Hans sings here is the "Lindenbaum" song he sang to himself as he pined for Clavdia following her initial departure from the Berghof. That he sings it now underscores just how drastically life has changed for him since his aimless and carefree days at the Berghof. Back then, the worst of Hans's problems was his lovesickness. He sang out of the foolish nostalgia for an irrational love. Now, he understands the song's meaning all too clearly—and much too late.



The narrator confirms that Hans has only suffered a minor injury to his leg from the exploding shell. Hans gets up and limps away, continuing to sing love songs as he struggles onward. Finally, the narrator bids Hans—"life's faithful problem child"—goodbye. "We" won't know whether Hans lives or dies, the narrator admits, but his chances aren't good. The narrator, addressing Hans directly now, recalls the days back at the Berghof when Hans would "play king," and when, during these moments, Hans "saw the imitation of a dream of love rising up out of death and this carnal body." But, the narrator asks Hans now, as Hans takes in the endless death and destruction that surrounds him, "will love someday rise up out of this, too?"

The narrator's final question to Hans essentially asks whether Hans, at long last, has learned his lesson. Before, Hans tried in vain to find meaning, purpose, and nobility in death and suffering—an intellectual undertaking that would allow him to justify his unjustifiable and irrational choice to squander his youth away at the Berghof. In immersing himself in death, he thought, he might learn how to live. Now, it is all but guaranteed that Hans will suffer greatly and perhaps even die. Faced with the unflinchingly real possibility of death, the narrator's rhetorical question to Hans asks whether he still believes that death has something to teach him.





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